

SpinTrap: Worlds Within Worlds

Book Two of the SpinTrap Saga, by

Rik Roots

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This book continues the story started in the first book
Spin Trap: The Lonely City

**Dedicated to the loving memory of
Anne Margaret Roots**

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1. The Healing Pool

I am ... tightness.

No.

There is a tightness. There is a ... me.

There is a thing and a different thing: there is the me, and there is the tightness. The tightness is parted from me. The tightness arounds me.

There is a ... light. Is this a different thing? Light. Sky? Sky! I am not sky; sky is apart from me.

The tightness binds me. The sky ... shimmers me.

There is another thing ... a shape on – no, in – the sky. It is a ... long shape, a ... yellow shape. The shape is here – no, here, and here – binding? No, beyond. Beyond the tightness.

The yellow there becomes the ... more? Yes: more. More yellow here. Less sky and more longness and less sky and more yellowness.

The shape becomes at – over? Into? – the tightness. Quick it becomes – larger, all ...

ThereIsAPAIN! The Pain ... it is at, on me. The Pain is – short? Shiny? Sharp. Very sharp!

Something that is me ... moves. Pushes. Pushes is – not – a thing. It is a *does*, not an *is*.

It pushes against the tightness. It pushes against the sharp yellow shape. It pushes.

Not it. I.

I push with my ... with my arm. I push with my leg. My leg pushes as I ... squirm to – struggle to ... straighten my leg. My knee. My knee is tight against my ... chest. My chest is tight against my ... chin! My chin! My arm is

tight around my knee. The tightness surrounds me. I push against the tightness.

The shape pushes against my tightness. The shape Pains me.

Within the tightness I push. I – rush? Run? No, roll! I roll and the sky ... slides. The sky ... is not. The sky – marks? Moves? Yes! It moves. There is no-light ... dark ... at my chin, at my ... face. The dark faces me. The shape is ... gone.

~~~

*~ You are different. You are old and new. The other eggs are new. You are new, and yet you are old.*

The words that rouse me are within my head, but I know they are not my words.

My eyes open to a blur of dancing shadows. I can feel the bladders surrounding me, tucking my limbs tightly into my belly and chest. Beyond the bladders, I seem to float across a landscape of pebbles and sands.

A dark marble of fish cruises between me and the ends of this place. Sparkles of brightness and dimness weave across the sands and pebbles in fascinations.

*~ I know you. I do not recall you. The others – I do not know them, nor do I recall them. You – I know.*

Something stabs at my back. The pain jerks me away from the japery of patterns, which in turn are disrupted by my reaction. The fish darts out of my view with a flick of its tail.

*~ I shall not aid the other eggs. They are new. I do not know them. I shall not aid them. I know you, yet I do not recall you. You must recall you. I cannot aid you if you cannot recall you.*

I must recall me. Which means there is a 'me' to recall. Which means I must have ... recalls? Reknows?

'Know' and 'call' and 'recall' and ... it is too much! I close my eyes against the sands and the stones and the image of the marbled fish, and I float.

~~~

Geit kicked me awake. He was the current leader of our gang, and thus it was his job to kick us awake. If there are qualities to leadership beyond the ability to kick us awake, then Geit made a special effort to keep them hidden.

"Up, Kal! To work. Leic is due to walk among us again. You must go find him."

I liked Leic more than Geit, whose kicks were less coordinated and more likely to cause damage. Leic was better at finding the shape of a good canoe, too.

Within moments of the kick I was walking away from the longhouse. With a pretence of haste I passed beneath wide-limbed trees towards the healing pools.

Jiar joined me in my task before I had reached the cliffs. He was the next smallest of us, and thus the second most likely to be kicked by Geit.

"Leic will spit teeth when he discovers who won the fight to replace him."

"It's too late for him to challenge," I said. "The hollowing is half-done."

"Leic would have found us better wood to shape."

I hadn't bothered to answer my brother; that fight was old talk and I had no interest in retalking its details with one of the losers.

We reached the land's edge at a place where the cliffs offered an easier climb down to the healing pools.

"Do you know where he is?"

Jiar shook his head. "His burning was long and bright. He'll be in deeper water."

I pointed towards the rocky stack with the arch at its base and the tree sprouting from its midpoint. "There's guardians over there. Half a dozen at least."

"No. Too deep, I reckon. The kelps grow thick at the footings there. Let's try over this way first."

~~~

The Dream Sight rolls through the kelps of my knowing, revealing the hidden things.

My name is Kal, I recall.

*~ Kal I do not recall. You I know. I shall not aid you.*

I recall the healing pools. I recall that when my body's flesh failed – drowning, perhaps, or an accident with an axe, or overwork, or being at the wrong end of a bad kicking, or letting a woman bite too deep on my neck as I took comfort in her – I would wake again in a healing pool. Start again. Strive again.

I recall the peace of the healing pools, caught between the land's cliffs and the sea's storms. Some pools were warmer than others, some were deeper than others. Some had crabs and sting flowers and swaying weeds to jape my eyes in the time between my renewal and my release. Some pools – like this pool – were less interesting.

I know who I am, and I know where I am.

~~~

Jiar found Leic, as was right: they often took comfort together and had a tight bond between them. The pool was in a place of sharp rocks. He was already reaching his arms around the tough leather of Leic's bladders when I reached his side.

"You brought his cloak with you?"

I nodded as I loosened the straps that held the bag to my shoulders.
"Fresh and supple, from good bark. Achoa finished sewing them three sleeps ago."

"Achoa is a bitch with the needles."

"She guards her grove fiercely. Strong bark."

"She sews badly on purpose. Leic knows her tricks."

"She never sews bark for me," I admitted.

"You are too good at thieving it."

"So?"

"And you are shorter than her."

"Always she promises to sew me a fine cloak."

"And always you fall for her lies. Give me your blade."

I loosened the long stone sliver from its loop on my vine-rope belt and handed it over. "I know her tricks."

"Maybe if you let her win, she would sew you a good bark jerkin."

"It hasn't worked before. She has sharp teeth, has Achoa."

~~~

The tightness of the bladders around me is increasing, and the urge in the muscles around my chest – to move, expand – grows. Nobody has come to cut me free. This is ... unexpected. Gang brothers should know that I am returning: the guardians are faithful in that duty, at least, and would have told my friends or, if I was short on friends for any reason, my gang leader.

My lungs crave air; the waters I breathe taste stale and foul.

I tame my body to patience and calm. They will come, I tell myself. They have a duty.

Nobody comes.

My lungs demand the balm of salt-sweet air.

I open my eyes and look beyond my aged, yellowing bladders.  
Beneath me, the floor of the healing pool is unhelpful – sand and smooth pebbles.

My flesh begins to panic. Spasms push my limbs against their constrictions. My lips make way for teeth as they try to lunge at the tough wrappings; enough give remains within them to defeat my tearing efforts. All I manage to achieve through my struggles is to roll my line of sight away from the floor of the pool to its side ...

... where sharp rocks intrude into the water.

My eyes snatch at the sight and my muscles act on it before I have the know of what I am doing. My struggles become frantic, yet ordered – each thrust brings me closer to the sharp jag of rock. I lose sight of the pool's rough knife before I feel it press against me, dig into my thigh. The sensation triggers a series of more violent jerks to bang my legs against the point of rock: again, and again, and again, and ... it rips! Immediately I stretch, unfurl my length with every last sinew, forcing the tear to lengthen, widen.

My lungs scream for air!

## 2. The Empty Island

The wind is light and the sky is hot. A sweat of raw gratitude springs across my back as I finally clamber over the cliff's lip and crawl into the shade of the closest trees.

My exhaustion competes with my thirst. It has taken me far longer to reach the safety of the land than I ever recall. The need to close my eyes and submit to the thrall of my fatigue dominates my Inner Voice.

My muscles know better: they haven't finished with me yet. Somehow I struggle onto my knees and, with the help of a close tree stump, my feet. Clutching at low branches, I press further inland, step by sore step.

Above me a seagull floats; I catch the white of its wing at the edge of my sight. "Bring Jiar, Leic!" calls out my real voice, a crust of whispers. "Bring Geit!"

It offers me no response, or regard. I stumble and fall on my hands as it glides over the edge of the cliff and heads out to sea.

I am so tired! My hairless hide burns where the bladders' skins have rubbed it; my thigh aches from the gouge of the healing pool's sharp rock spear. Cuts from the journey across barnacle smothered reef tatter my hands, my knees, my feet.

I cannot end in this flesh yet: to return to the pools so soon would be a humiliation!

I need water.

I find berries.

They cluster around the thorny stems of a small bush, close to where I have fallen. It takes a crisis of effort to lever my limbs across that short distance. When I lie on my side to stretch out to them, the thorns add new marks to my bloodied fingers.

The first berry is hard and dry: my fingertips have un-knowned their skills to feel firm from soft. I reach out again and pluck at its friends, ignore thorn-pricks to jostle them free of their branch.

They taste vile.

I refuse to spit them out. I force my teeth to bite into the flesh of each gift, let their dampness burst free to scorch my gums with tart saps.

The sensation re-gathers my wits to me. As I swallow, my throat scalds and my stomach contracts: pain confirms my continued existence.

~~~

I find a source of water a little while after my berry meal forced me back to my feet.

When I find hints that promise the presence of a grove, I allow myself a moment of ecstasy – just a moment, no more. The discovery is enough to settle my senses into their more expected ranges; it also triggers reflexes that fold me into a sudden, still crouch.

I scope out everything about the grove: the paths that lead to it; the state of the hedges planted around its edges; the colours of the barks bearding the central trees. I look for smoke and listen for song.

Nothing. The hedges are badly overgrown and the bark looks old and rough. Either the grove has been abandoned, or the woman who owns it has set a trap.

My Dream Sight reknows me that I am nimble, with a reputation for raiding these places – rarely am I caught. I wait for a hundred breaths, and a hundred more. I check everything about the grove and the terrain that surrounds it.

On my fifth step towards it, I tread on a twig hidden between grass tufts ... it cracks!

I freeze at that instance, wait for the sting of a dart in my flesh ...

Nothing?

I command my lungs full, empty, full. I risk a new step, a next step, another step. And another.

If the branch was a trap, then I've sprung it with no retaliation! I spit my cautions into the earth, abandon my stealth, hobble to the closest path leading into the grove.

I force myself through a gap in the hedge with all speed.

Within its thorny defences, the place reveals itself to be long abandoned. No woman would allow the litter of dead leaves to collect so deeply across the earth. Even the hearth stone is covered in old foliage.

I scramble through detritus, hunting for a well. Instead I discover a small heap of clay pots, each filled to the brim with cool, stale rainwater. Never has such liquid tasted so hale and sweet! I recall the need to swill the remnant flesh of the bitter fruit from between my teeth before I commence on the fourth pot.

A woman almost always builds her roost in the branches of her favourite tree – she can never be too careful! If this grove still has a roost, I do not know it. The leaves by the hearth stone offer me a deep and soft welcome as I collapse on my back into them.

~~~

"Why do you have such sharp teeth, Achoa?"

My question brought a grin to the woman's face as she worked at her sewing.

"Don't laugh at me. Tell me!"

She kept her eyes on her busy needle. "You know why I have sharp teeth, little Kal. It makes it easier for me to eat you."

My eyes were not distracted by her needlework. During this visit, she had not bothered to wrap her longleaf cloak over her shoulders, leaving me with a good sight of her hanging breasts, each the equal to the other in length and weight. Only the nipples were hidden by their soft-creased bark cups. As she drew her arm straight to pull each stitch tight her breasts swayed to one side, gently, enticingly.

She knew me too well.

"I am too scrawny for your taste," I told her, my eyes refusing to move from the japes of distraction.

"Nonsense. You are well built. What you lack in height, you recover in bulk. Your buttocks I find very appealing."

"Appealing enough to be covered in your bark?"

"Perhaps," she said, taking a moment to brush her cascade of soft, brown hair away from her brow. "Eyes to my eyes now!"

The words were enough to restore my wits to me. A quick glance around the grove's nest confirmed that the woman's knives and blowpipes remained where I had persuaded her to place them before I approached close.

"We have been busy with the fishing," I said.

"This is good. Men need to eat fish."

"Leic has found herbs."

Her eyes narrowed at the words, and her lips tightened a little. "Leic has a knack for finding herbs."

I managed to keep my sigh silent, let my eyes steal back to the sway of her chest. "We shall be cooking the fish soon, with the herbs. Maybe you could visit us?"

"Maybe I could," she said, drawing her arm straight at the completion of another stitch. "If only to keep your pert cock in my eyes." I catch the warning, command my glance back to her mouth, her teeth; it is enough to ease the tension from her lips. "How else will I know that you are safe on the beach and not back here robbing me of my knives?"

I made a determined effort to keep her smile from infecting my own face.

"I cannot believe that a woman as wise and beautiful as you could ever skull-speak such scurrying words about me. You know I like my fish

cooked. The smell of the hot flesh will keep me staked to the beach until my eyes fall shut from too much beer!"

She laughed: "Such tales you offer me, Kal. Your stories are the reason why I keep my teeth sharp!"

~~~

A great noise awakens me. The word that enters my head is 'bears': I do not waste even a breath-pull worrying why my head fixes on that particular nonsense sound. Quickly I mark my surroundings, eyes checking for directions and distances. The still leaves around me show that no gales blow at this time; broad mauve spirals in the lavender sky above hint at rain to come, but not for a good while yet.

A woman would never make such a noise: they have a justified pride in their hunting skills. Perhaps a cliff slips somewhere, or a boulder rolls towards the grove?

I am tempted to stand my ground, risk an injury to prove myself equal to this trial, but my limbs shake from hunger and my eyes are dry. As the noises draw near, I take to the base of the surrounding hedge where the ferns grow high.

The noise resolves into the form of a man.

He walks like a japester on a floating log! His arm swirls in wide arcs around him as he beats branches and grasses out of his path. His other hand easily cups his tackle, tucked small within his angular hips.

He bellows: "Sam! Sam!"

I cannot help but let my jaw drop wide at his stupidity. His bald skin, latticed in cuts, talks of a recent release from the healing pools. If I had a knife on me I would quickly return him there! Such wailing will bring more than women to this place, and I have no wish to cease breathing just yet.

He moves awkwardly, with no balance. At each new step he winces, as if the soil burns him. Even though he hunches his shoulders down and keeps his knees bent, I can tell he is tall – he has at least two hands on me. I hold still as his brown eyes sweep around the glade.

"Sam!"

He approaches the hearth stone. Like an addle-skull I have un-called to roughen the leaves, to wipe the dents of my sleeping shape from their surface – as soon as he spots them, feels for their warmth, he will know I have been here!

I realise I have no recognition of him. He is not of my gang. I have not had time to mark my skin with gang patterns: he may well attack me as soon as he sees me.

He seems – possessed? – by distractions; when he trips over the hearth stone, clatters down into the stack of empty pots, I use his screams and sobs to mask the sound of my own hasty departure.

As I scamper, I wonder: what is a 'possessed'?

~~~

My instinct is to stick close to the shoreline, but netting that glance of the pained, deranged man has reknowned to me that I have yet to see any of my gang brothers. Their absence is ... not right.

More importantly, the ache in my stomach grows harder. Have I poisoned myself by eating those berries? The wound in my thigh also shouts at me, and probably needs fixing.

When I reach an avenue of grass between the trees I take a few breaths, consider my choices. To move downhill will lead me to the cliffs, to the places of men. I do not recall this avenue, but I feel confident that, properly approached, no gang will refuse to aid me – they might even adopt me, given the dereliction of my brothers.

I look along the avenue: seawards, and then landwards. There are no sounds to announce the coming of walkers; the sky is cast wrong for a Procession. As the trail moves away from the land's skirts, it curves slowly around the bulge of the closest hill, upwards towards the bulk of the great mountain whose peak I refuse to look at.

To walk landwards without the support and protection of my gang ... but women are far better skilled at the easement arts.



"Which clan lives behind this hill?"

I cast the words into the air in the hope that they will bring me a haul of fresh knowing ... but my Dream Sight fails me: I cannot find an image of this avenue within me, nor does the hill's shape spark silent words. Even the healing pools – I have no recollection of walking across those rocks before.

I search the skies seawards for a guardian. Nothing appears.

To approach a woman-clan naked and unmarked ... it is the act of a man begging for the attention of darts and knives, ropes and flames.

I need to find black mud. I need to paint gang patterns on my skin. Only then will I risk walking into these gut-knotting hills.

~~~

Away from the shoreline the air grows much warmer; it fights against my sweat to dry out the muddy daubs across my chest and thighs and forearms.

The avenue here is well grassed, with few patches of stone showing through the green cover. Wherever possible I walk along the softer strands of clover, avoid the sharper tufts of spine-studded grass and the gravels that cover smoothed rock. My feet are still weak: they enjoy ease when they should be striving to endure any hardship that I task to them.

I keep my eyes wide as I pass along the curve of the hill. The land on either side is tight-woven in trees. On occasion I spot a longer trunk thrusting above the canopy of its peers: some look ripe for the harvest. Some look over-ripe, past their prime – good for nothing apart from the fire.

Behind the hill, I find a valley. I do not recall it.

I can hear the quiet slush of running water somewhere downwind of me, where the ground falls gently. Closer by, upwind of me, the other side of the hill meanders for some distance inland, and the avenue clearly follows its shape, in some places digging into the side of the hill to keep the climb easy. Beyond the river stride other hills, much higher than this one. I suspect that somewhere up ahead the two seams will narrow the valley into a gorge.

The call of moving closer to the mountain and its High Domain worries at my courage like a dog ... a 'dog'? Another word that hints at meaning?

No. I mean a worm – a worm on the bone. More than once I have to throw (quiet) words at the air to keep my legs to their work.

~~~

My throat has been itching for moisture for a good while by the time I find the spring. It is an ordered arrangement, too, with a series of dips carved into the low cliff to hold the water. As I approach I can see that moss has been allowed to grow along the stone rims, and small ferns cluster above in the long rock overhang. But the water is fresh, and swift to pour from dip to dip. Gladly I duck my entire head in the lowest one. I scrub hard at my bald, barely stubbled scalp before moving to a higher carved dip to hand-cup water, to ease my dry lips and mouth.

Sated, I take a moment to rest. Only when I hunch down to lean my back against the cool, damp cliff-face do I spot the bones.

He sits at the side of the avenue much as I do, though he is further along the avenue, just above the spring. His spine balances upright, and one arm drapes over a crooked leg. He looks as if he fell asleep, with the side of his face resting against the cliff just as my back does. He is – entirely – bone: white bone at that, with no skin or flesh to discolour his frame.

I take a second, slower drink before I investigate him.

When I am ready, I walk up to him slowly, checking the cliff and the avenue for marks and traps. Nothing seems out of place. I take a few steps nearer, then nearer, close almost to touch. This close, I have to crouch to bring my head down to his level.

The bones look good, but I can see that they are not entirely clean – sinews still stitch across joints, and within thin shadows there remain flecks of flesh and skin. Yet all of his offal is gone and the smile he offers me, from his eye-free skull, is pure tooth.

Sinew. Not twine.

This is not a woman's work.

But if this is not a warning, then where are the marks of the bone worms? No animal, no part of an animal, can survive unless it has been cured – preserved in some manner such as smoke or powders or balm.

One of his arms, the one that doesn't rest on his angled knee, drapes over a bag. Curious, I shuffle closer and reach out my hand to take his wrist and lift it away. The movement is enough to break his delicate balance: in a cascade of rattles he collapses, his skull taking the opportunity to roll along the cliff's skirting towards a muddied puddle close to where I had sat.

Her skull, I realise. Not his.

The bag is made of leather and, now I can see it more clearly, the swirl of the tattoos that pattern it mark it as a woman's bag, fashioned from man-skin.

No man would dare use his brother, nor his enemy, in such a humiliating manner.

I utter a curt cry for my brother's suffering as I take the bag in both hands and heave it into my arms. From within its space come the clinks of clay jars – many still full, I judge, given the weight of the thing.

A woman, apparently alone, with a bag full of small jars – perhaps she could be a herbalist?

A call occurs to me: if a woman finds me near here, with this woman's bag, she will not bother asking me questions about what I have found. No, she will chase me down, with her sisters, and she will take me beyond the reach of my brothers and she will keep me breathing for a long, long while as she consumes my limbs ...

I will not suffer that indignity again!

~~~

This grove is as empty as the first one, the one in which I had watched the skull-addled man crash and collapse.

I had veered from the avenue as soon as I had found the bag, following the trickle of the spring's water into the valley. When I entered the woods, I had been on my guard: these trees were familiar in their form, but not their location – fruit trees and nut trees that had an air of care and cultivation about them. I was not keen to meet their carer.

As soon as I found cover I had taken a moment to search through the bag, before I hid it in a heap of arched brambles. Then, armed with the comfort of stolen flint in my palm, I had covered my tracks and gone hunting for the grove.

It took me a while to find it. The usual paths leading to its guard of hedge were badly overgrown, as if no feet had trodden their length for the passing of many, many Races. The woman had taken care to conceal it beside an outcrop ridge of jumbled rocks, a little further inland and midway between the avenue and the river. I certainly would not have found it if I had not taken a big risk by climbing one of the rocks, to see if I could catch any signs from its summit.

"Why would a woman abandon such a well-built, well protected grove?"

I've stacked the skeleton woman's pots to one side of the hearth stone, and taken special care to re-cover and re-hide the leather bag, pushing it deep between wide-spreading ferns and arranging the leaves back to their natural cascade.

"Why leave a carcass by the side of an avenue? Why let its presence foul the airs surrounding the spring?"

I've taken to whispering my questions into the air. I have little hope that these sounds will net any answers for me; I just need to hear my voice ... any voice.

"What's happened here?" I mumble as I struggle to break the seal on the first jar. "Where has everybody gone?"

3. Strangers on the Beach

The wind is stronger, here by the cliffs, much stronger than it was when I hauled myself from the healing pool. Below me the waves play at gang-fighters, each taking its turn to send attacking white caps across the field of broken, jagged rocks, to flood and re-flood the craters and canyons tucked like traps in the rust-black landscape.

The men who hunt among the pools – there's something wrong about them.

One of the men I recall from the time he staggered into the glade bellowing for harm. He stalks between the rocky outcrops like a cripple, each step tested before he places his weight on the foot. He walks with the aid of a stick – no, it is a pole, about three hands longer than he is and broken to a point at one end. When he arrives at the edge of a new stretch of water he crouches and peers through the disturbed surface before pulling his pole round and stabbing into it, as if he wants to eviscerate it.

It is a fascinating jape!

The other man lies on a cast of sand near the base of the cliff, a little upwind from where I crouch. I don't recall him at all. He is a little shorter than the first man, with a stubble of light hair – almost as bleached as the grits that pile around his fingers. He also has a better build than his companion, broader across the shoulder with a set of stout muscles gathered within his pink hide. He doesn't move much; he seems bruised – his blackened eyes talk of a possible crack to his skull.

"You should help them," says the part of me that still talks to the air.

Neither of the men wears their tattoos, or any markings beyond the story of scabs carved into their skins. I have met women who chose not to bear the signs of their clan on their bodies, but these two are clearly not women. I recall hearing stories of women who make their homes in the High Domain – in the caldera itself, even – those women were rumoured to keep men as tethered pets. The men in those stories bore no gang marks, for no gang would be stupid enough to claim such unfortunates as their own brothers: why invite the attention of those most dangerous of women?

'I cannot help them,' I tell my voice. 'They must carry a curse in their touch.'

"They cannot hunt; and they lack the know of gathering."

'The guardians must have marked them as they healed in their pools.'

Stories, stories. Our lives revolve around them. When the sky commanded a time of rest and play we would gather in our longhouse, my gang brothers and I, and tell each other stories. Mostly we shared our boasts, of where we had travelled and what we had stolen – or charmed, for not all of my brothers were as short and ugly as me – from the women set in their groves. Or we would relive our most recent Race: the discovery and shaping of our canoe; the Procession to the competition place; the purification rites and the time of striving itself. And we would whisper our Dream Sights of the celebration after, tell each other about the visions we saw in the dance of the flame.

We would talk about Her, and how our leader had performed with Her, and how great a flame he made as he honoured Her during the final consumption.

Geit – he of the happy kick – had been the first (an image recalls) to tell me the story of the unmarked men. Maybe he had seen it as a vision gifted by the celebration pyre? Or maybe he had been one of the unmarked men himself, a long time before: his knowing of the world was certainly different to that of my gang brothers, or indeed my own.

~~~

"Who made you the boots? Achoa?"

"Achoa doesn't like me. These are Vuanna's work."

Geit had been quick to snatch the boot from my hands. "You're too late!" I told him. "I've had my feet in them already."

"Achoa is always happy to make me new boots," he said, not bothering to answer my challenge. He examined the needlework with some care before tossing the item back at me. "She has better skill than Vuanna."

"My woman has been working on these boots since before the last Race. Look at the bark ..." I held the boot with both hands above my head and tugged them apart sharply "... strong and supple. These boots will not chafe me!"

"They are too large for you, or your feet have shrunk since she measured them. You stole them, huh?"

I couldn't keep my face straight, not even in front of Geit. The raid had been well executed and I had come away from the woman's grove with more than footwear. I offered him the details as I drew the boot onto my foot and started to lace it to my leg.

He was laughing with me by the time I reached the last words. "Ah, Kal!" he said, settling himself onto the wooden bench next to me. "You are quick, and cunning – none of your brothers can dispute those facts. But you still need to think before you act."

"You never praise, do you. You never take pleasure in your brothers' victories. What is a 'think'?"

"Skull-words, little brother. And I take pleasure in your victories, know. I would take even greater pleasure if you had managed to steal a matching pair of boots."

"They match! These are good boots."

"Their patterns match," he agreed. "But one is not the pair of the other: they are both built for your left foot, and none for your right."

"'Left', 'right' – what are these words?"

When I looked across my shoulder to him, to watch him answer, I could see the grains of happiness leaching from his face, washed away by a smear of dampness that sparkled across the whites of his eyes. For a while he sat silent, gazing at nothing but the air.

I grew tired of his company. "Don't answer me, then," I said as I stood up ready to test the boots on the soil. "I can smell the searing of fish, and my belly rumbles."

Before I could take a step he reached out and grasped my hand, pulled me back down onto the wooden bench. Rather than fight, I accepted his decision for me. I could tell the man was in one of his stranger moods, and there might be a possibility of a story hidden within it.

"I'm sorry, little brother," he started, offering me a wry glance as I settled my bare arse back onto the wood. "Sometimes I forget where I am. These words I use – 'left' and 'right' – these are words that I used to say: to show the place of things, the direction of where they are. When you stand on top of the cliff and watch the sea, the upwind is what I used to call 'right' and the downwind is 'left'."

I studied him for a moment. "So these are secret words, yes? Words used between brothers of your former gang. I have heard of such things – it is the same as the way we call the dotted stinger fish 'Rappoe' because it is like our woman Rappoe, with a sting at the tip of her tongue and venom to match. But other men never call the fish 'Rappoe'. They call it the dotted stinger fish."

The story brought a small smile back to his face: "Rappoe is indeed worthy of having such an evil fish named after her. But this is different – not just a different word for a thing, but a different way of seeing the world."

"How so?"

"Because if you turned your back on the sea and instead looked at the clouds that hide the High Domains, the upwind would now blow onto my 'left' and the downwind would be my 'right'."

"That makes no sense ..."

"Of course not," he agreed. "You live in a world where the wind blows always in one direction, always chasing itself in a great circle around this great island ... upwind and downwind, landwards and seawards – those are the only directions you need. But where I come from ... there is no such wind to tell me where I stand, and no sea to tell me front from back."

The man's claim astonished me: these words had the makings for one of Geit's more skull-addled stories.



"So how could you tell where you stood, without the help of the wind and the sea?"

"Oh, that was easy – I used my body to tell me where things were, and where I moved from and to: this side of my body ..." he bashed his hand against the shoulder closest to me "... is always my left side, and this ..." he repeated the action on his other shoulder "... is my right side. They never change. And I can tell you now that this foot ..." he brought his hand down on my knee, the one touching his, making me yelp out "... is going to be very sore by the time you sleep, because you are forcing it to wear a boot built for the other foot. Because you stole two left boots."

"You lie," I protested. "Your stories of places where the wind won't tell you which way you face. Places with no sea – who heard of such a thing?"

"You don't have to believe me, little brother."

"I won't! I know you lie. In fact I shall wager you: if this good boot hurts its foot much more than this equally good boot, then ..."

"Then what?"

"Then I shall let you take me when we next sleep."

"Now there's a worthy prize. And if both boots behave equally?"

"I shall take you, though the call doesn't appeal much to me."

Geit had laughed, then, loud enough to attract the attention of some brothers a little upwind who were busy fixing their nets.

"I shall take your wager, Kal, though my prick will not thank me when I claim the prize. And thus shall you learn your right from your left."

I joined him in his mirth. Then, when my lungs had settled: "Tell me, brother Geit, where is this place you speak of? This place where winds lie?"

"I can barely remember it now," he said, letting the last of his chuckles leave his body. "It is a place far distant from these skies." He took a breath in recall, maybe two. "Uekh – that was its name. The skies were so wide there, and pale – as pale as the bark of your fine new boots."

"I can't imagine a place with such a sky ..."

He got up, stood above me and reached out his hand to help me stand. "You know Kal," he said, "we're not that different, you and I. Both of us cast adrift from our homes – though you do not know it, not yet at least ..."

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The man with the spear has caught something. I watch him fight with a fish as I bite deeply into the flesh of a brelfruit that I had brought with me. He is, I decide, a japester with no concept of how to hold a stick, no less how to use it. I wager against my speaking voice that the fish will escape before I finish my fruit: indeed, it thrashes itself back to the hug of the waves before I take a third bite.

I have returned to these sea cliffs because I do not know what else to do. These two strange wormskulls are the only breathing people – man or woman – that I have come across since my latest healing.

The skeleton on the Processional avenue was the most complete stack of bones that I have discovered. Since then I have found a couple of skulls lodged in trees, and a half dozen more jaw bones with good teeth circling their rims. In two groves I found separate chime-traps built from strings of rattling rib bones, but those bones looked much older, as if preserved by womanly alchemies.

My other expedition had been downwind, across the hills to the coast; it took me easily a hundred-hundred paces and more to reach the next valley cutting its way through the cliffs to meet the sea in its bay. I had slept on the deserted beach alongside the remnant poles of a storm-wrecked longhouse, its furnishings as scattered as the rumours of the gang who had once lived there.

It was not a wasted journey: I scavenged for clothing and found several pairs of over-long trousers, their bark still supple. Boots, too, I took – though none were as pretty as the boots I had once stolen from Vuanna. Carved gourds I uncovered, for the carrying of water and juices, and a useful supply of twines and ropes woven from tassel vines. I even discovered a tattoo pricker and a fresh block of ink – I still feel naked without my gang marks.

The emptiness of these places – it grates at me. I am at a loss for an explanation, for at no time has the sky's lavender banding spoken of a Race – and even the smallest of gangs will leave many behind when the best men take up their canoe to Process to the competition place. And beyond the Race, gangs do not fight: kidnap, maybe; torture captives caught unawares – but the clearing of an entire longhouse? No. The women would not permit such stupidity.

And where are the women? Every glade that I have come across lies as abandoned as that first one, with goods scattered about. In one grove I found a stack of bark, harvested and roughly shaped, but as yet untreated; in two others I found the plates set out for meals and the bedding prepared for the conjugal ceremonies: no woman would leave her grove during such important rituals. No woman would dare leave bark harvested but untreated. Their sisters would mock them mercilessly!

There are bad vapours in the air, I feel, so I have not antagonised the elements by stealing anything from the groves beyond the essential – some medications and a couple of sharp glass knives. I have not yet slept in a woman's roost; there are no women in these places to invite me. Rather, I risk the discomforts of the soils and leaves around the hearth stone, waking myself regularly to fend off the attentions of bone worms and scab beetles.

I gather my bag – a weave of kelp fronds, not the skeleton's man-skin bag which remains safely stashed – and move away from my vantage; head upwind to the scarf of sand where the second man lounges.

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The beach marks the mouth of a small stream that has cut itself a shallow channel through the collapsed steps of the cliff. It is not large, perhaps thirty paces in length and a dozen paces at its widest. Behind its low bulk the stream gathers in a small lagoon with a good growth of reeds about it. I take a moment to investigate the silted waters and quickly see that it contains a wealth of mudslumberers and murky brown scallifish; I even spot the telltale scrapes where a turtle has come to lay its round fruits in the wet earth.

"Sam! Sam! I got one!"

The distant voice sounds triumphant. I take a moment to tie a knot in the rope that holds my trousers to my waist, to reknow to me to return here to harvest this pool's wealth, then drop my bag in the reeds and creep to the cliff-side, where bushes hug the rock and I can hide to net a glimpse of the next instalment of this ongoing japery.

The man on the beach is sitting back, resting his weight on his arms. One of his legs – the upwind one – is stretched out ahead of him, with the ankle swollen. His skin bears the marks of healing cuts, mainly on his hands and feet, though a few longer scratches across his back and chest tell a tale of missed balance among the healing pools that stretch between the sand and the sea. Nothing about him suggests any serious damage, except for the style of his face: his eyes wander from place to place and his jaw hangs loose in the chin – the look of a man haunted by dark images that peck at him like the axe worries at the trunk of a tree.

"Sam, look! It's as long as my arm!"

The other man is coming closer now, ignoring the surf that batters at his legs. He slips before I can focus on his prize, slamming into the sharp rocks and breaking his stick. The fall seems to rouse the beach man from his fretting: "Maak? Maak?"

When the other man stands, he copies him. He grabs his own spear from the sand and uses it as a crutch to lever himself to his feet. He manages a couple of short strides before halting.

The fisher man is smiling now. He has recovered what remains of his stick: "I've still got it," he shouts. "We'll need something to cut it and gut it." In triumph he raises his prize above his head, swinging it around its wooden tether.

I break cover without call.

If the sight of my arrival shocks the sand man, I do not notice it. All my attention is focussed on the man walking towards the beach, and the Rappoe fish – still gasping and now enraged – that spins above his head.

"Drop it!" I shout. "Throw it and run!"

My voice stuns the man still. I increase my speed, dash across the sandbar and into the surf. With its loss of momentum, the fish on the stick begins to flex and wrench its body against the wood; barely a hands-width separates its mouth from the man's wrist, and the tail is already within striking distance of his head.

"Addle-skull!" I scream. "Drop it now!"

The fish seems to grin as it wriggles down and arches its tail back. In a fluid movement it puckers its spines free of their grooves along its flank and ... thwack! ... empties its venoms into the inane grin that masks the man's face.

I am too late! I reach the man as he staggers, grasp the stick from his hand and pull the fish free of his face. In a single movement I hurl the triumphant Rappoe back into the waves, as far distant from me as I can manage, and reach for the man's collapsing frame.

Already he fits, foam swirling from his lips.

## 4. "Dead People Get Buried"

"You keep away from him. You hear me? You don't touch him!"

The man with the lighter hair – Sam, he calls himself – has positioned himself between his brother and the fire, where I crouch. I offer him a glance, but he flinches away from eye contact: "You don't go near him!"

Brother Maak is still prostrate on the sand. He has done little more than shake for the best part of three worktimes now. The bark sheets that I had carried to this place before the first sleeptime lay scattered around him: his fever jerks his limbs, which shake the sheets free from his form.

This is not a good place to be damaged – it is too close to the healing pools, and the creatures of those brines do not appreciate the disturbance caused by someone in so much pain: I'm surprised that the crabs and pinchworms have not dragged him into the foams already.

I have done what I can. I've built them a fire and collected sufficient wood to keep the flames alive while I'm away from the beach. I've given them some of my gourds and filled them with fresh water. I've caught and cooked them food: mudslumberers boiled in a pot with some roots, and scallifish roasted above the fire – though it took a fair amount of persuading to get Brother Sam to eat. I was going to share the turtle fruits with him but, given his attitude, I decided to keep them for myself.

What I haven't shared with the strangers are my words. Those I keep safe to myself.

Sam the beach man has settled into a crouch. Sometimes he copies my movements, as if he is teaching his muscles how to work through imitation. As I sort through the stack of twigs and leaves, so he sorts through a stack of invisible tinder, each movement a scant breath behind mine.

"Why is there no night here, savage?"

I ignore his question as I pile fresh branches in a cone around the low flames. The last of the scallifish are at my feet, already gutted and threaded on long sticks ready to be staked into the sand. I take care to prod the sourscape roots, each oval tuber wrapped in gallo leaves, deep into the

embers; I have to trust that the man recalls how long they need to cook, and how to eat them once they are done.

I cannot waste any more time here.

"Tell me where the sun is. Tell me why there is no night, only day."

He guards his brother, I assume, because he wants the man to suffer. Maybe they have fought over a woman, or the dark haired one has bullied Sam to a point where retribution is both justified and honourable. There could be other reasons but, because I will not share my words with him, I'll never recover the details of their story.

I already know how this tale will end for the one called Maak. The Rappoe was not kind to him: by the time I reached him, the fish had buried several spines in his face – one piercing his eye – and the poison was already burning the flesh. And the poison does not relent; where once the man had a cheek, all that remains is a bloody mess. The bones around his mouth show where the skin has split, and his eye cries nothing but pus. He is beyond help.

A good brother – a caring brother – would not hesitate to slit the man and let his Vital Breath break away from the flesh, to float back to a healing pool where he can form into a new body. I can recall a number of times when I have been grateful for the swift thrust of a brother's knife across my throat; the flesh may fall away, but the Dream Sights stay close – to recall harsh pain while being healed is ... unpleasant.

Sam danced a madness fit to embarrass the skies when I had readied my glassy blade to perform the mercy, during our first encounter. His attack was unskilled, yet total in its force. Rather than risk a fall in that surf, or possibly stepping on the injured Rappoe, I had backed away, leaving the man to drag his brother out of the water. I tried to offer him the knife so that he could do the work himself, but he had thrown it back at me.

That is when I vowed to not share my words with these men. Sam dishonoured his gang brother through his actions, and he dishonoured me by refusing my gifts.

I had also determined that I would not waste any more worktime on the pair. If I had found another person – even a woman – in these woods,

they would never have seen me again. But there are no other people in this place, and it is dangerous for a man to be alone for more than a short while.

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'Tell me where the sun is. Tell me why there is no night, only day.'

The sand man's words come back to me as I walk inland to my current hideout. I'm passing the first grove that I had found when the Dream Sight strikes.

I force myself to climb to the unknown woman's roost as the recall takes me. A woman's dart is not the only danger here: a bryesnatcher's moan; caddiwhip trills – I know they hunt nearby.

'Tell me where the sun is. Tell me why there is no night, only day.'

Geit had told me about a place where the winds deceived and the skies were yellow, not mallow. It is a strong image because his story managed to worm its way into my dreams on many occasions afterwards.

Geit had also taught me about the words 'left' and 'right'. They were strange concepts, and useless to me because I did not need them to know where I was in the world. Yet they stuck with me, those words, and settled into the marrow of my bones.

The words that Sam used – 'night' and 'day' and 'sun' – they have a similar feeling for me. It is like I have heard these words before, but where?

Ahh ... yes! Melwais. I can smell her skin and feel the roughness of her deep plum-tinted hair as I bring her name to my throat.

It was the time of the Race – my last Race, perhaps? Before some calamity had taken me back to the healing pools and then here to this deserted place? Her face seems like an old image, like a story that starts in one longhouse and circles around the coastline until it returns, after a hundred-hundred sleeps, to the man who first told it. But it is recent. Yes, Melwais was the last woman to lead our gang in Procession through the High Domains.

The skies had commanded a race, and the guardians had flocked over my gang's longhouse to celebrate our selection. The great gulls came at a

good time, for once more Leic was our leader and he had already overseen the construction of a magnificent canoe – its carvings so intricate, its balance so perfect ...

I, too, had worked hard before our selection; few brothers were surprised when Leic claimed me to be part of the final crew. When the women arrived to guide us to the competition place I was almost as perfect as our wave-conquering canoe.

I do not understand the competitions that the women hold, between sisters, and between clans of sisters. Perhaps it is something to do with the neatness of their sewing, or the skill at tanning manskin. They are not men, thus it is not a man's place to understand their ways.

"Will you miss me?" I asked Achoa.

"I will not miss you, little Kal."

She looked more sublime as she spoke those words than at any moment I could recall: her sisters had braided her hair tight to her scalp and woven delicate reyalla blooms within the cords, their shape a shimmer of gold and green layers reaching down to her waist. She also wore her new cloak, the one she had been sewing since before the last Race in which our gang had competed, whose inner side was a fluff of dense down to complement the sheer whiteness of the smallgull feathers ranged in taut patterns across the outer side.

I would have axed away my legs at that moment to be given a chance to snuggle into that cloak, to feel Achoa's fine arms cuddle us tight into its warmth.

"You are cruel to me. I have the respect of all my brothers!"

"And I do not dishonour you with my words. They are the simple truth."

"How so?" I asked. We were gathered, my brothers and I, in Achoa's glade. Many people were there to celebrate our departure, not only my gang brothers but also many of Achoa's sisters.

"Because I am to walk with you. Have you not heard?" The shake of my head disappointed her. "Still you are a rascal and a thief, Kal. You have no honour."

I tried to look downcast, but it was a wasted effort. She was already smiling at my discomfort.

"Is this the one you told me about?"

The questioner stood behind me. Her voice was cast a little deeper than Achoa's, and seemed to come from a mouth level with the crown of my head.

"It is, my Lady. This is Kal. Kal, turn around and offer the proper greetings to the Lady. She is the one who has come to walk you to the Race, and she has selected me to be her second."

I turned and stumbled some appropriate words at the new woman. Her name was Melwais, her fingers were fine and un-calloused, and I was in full lust for her within three heart-skips.

Ahh, Melwais! For a while I un-know the unlucky, abandoned roost in which I sit and let my recall wander over every inch of her body once more.

I did not speak to her again during that meal, nor did I enjoy her company for the sleep that followed – I made do with Jiar, my crewmate, who was always a good friend: we were both in lust for the Lady that time, and made passion between us with cunning whispers of how we could both share her comforts.

It was a long journey – twenty hundred-hundred steps and many more along the wide avenues leading into the High Domains, and around the Great Caldera, and down again to the competition place where we were to build our smallhouse and ready ourselves for the Race. During that Procession I had the honour of lying with the Lady Melwais twice, neither time having to share her affections with any other man.

It was during our second sleeptime together that we had talked of strange places.

"Fol Huun grows impatient with our progress," she said. "We must step more quickly – more work, less rest."

"Does the Great One talk to you?"

She drew her fingers up from their settled place on my thigh – my right thigh, I recall, as the breeze was too weak at that moment to offer good directions – and trailed their tips across skin to my stomach.

"She always talks to those who have eyes to watch the skies."

I stared at the slew of bands and whorls above us for a while. "I don't understand," I admitted.

"Those patterns are Her messages – each shape has a different meaning and, together, they can be revealed as Her words, Her commands."

"This is a woman's thing, yes?"

"And a man's thing, too."

"One of my brothers, he told me a story of a place where the skies were different – a different colour."

"Did you like his story?"

"No. It worried me. It worries me still. It makes shadows in my dreams."

"Like the sun casts shadows?"

I looked into her eyes, prepared to risk another kiss. But she had the know of men's calls and distracted me from my idea by biting my ear.

"Ow! You cannot eat me now. After we win the Race, then you can have my flesh."

"Oh, I shall keep you to that promise, little Kal, even if you lose."

"We cannot lose," I said, offended. "What is this 'sun' you talk of?"

"It is a great ball of fire that travels across the skies."

"Now you tease me! Who has heard of such a nonsense thing?"

"Maybe your brother has, the one who talks of yellow skies."

I could not stay peeved at her: "Geit has many stories, but he has never talked of fiery balls in the sky."

"Did he give a name to this place with yellow skies?"

I shook my head. "Maybe. I do not recall the sounds."

"Maybe he called the place 'Uekh'?"

"Yes, maybe."

"Your friend is well-travelled then."

"Such a place exists?"

"Yes." She let her fingers pause in their circling of my navel, let them draw away towards my crotch and the baubles – now claimed as my gift to her – couched within their curly mattress. "I have been there."

"Truly?" I watched her nod her head. "And there was fire in the sky?"

"Not there, no. The sun lives in another place – another world, where it travels from one end of the sky to the other, and then beneath the world to rise again, like the winds that circle the land in this world."

I managed to close my mouth, though my eyes remained wide: "Such madness!" I told her.

She laughed at my doubt. "And yet it is so. When the sun is in the sky the people say it is 'daytime', and the light casts hard black shadows of their own shapes behind them. And when the sun hides under the world they say it is 'nighttime' and their shadows merge together to drink the light to nothing. They tell how time passes by the circles of the sun."

"And the beats of their hearts, I wager, and the paces they take. And the sleeps between work."

"No, just the sun. Day and night, day and night. Nothing else matters to them. Their skies are blue and white, and grey, and black. And sometimes

gold and red when the sun passes between the land and the skies. It is a wondrous place!"

~~~

As I stand here on the cliffs, I have a good view of the little beach upwind of me, its lagoon, the healing pools just offshore. One of the men – Maak with the dark fuzz of hair – lies very still on the sands; the other – Sam – is digging a man-sized hole: already he has hollowed his ditch to the height of his hips.

I did not plan to come here again, but my last sleep had been disturbed by Dream Sights of a black sky, its unrelenting colour peppered by bright points of light. I had been searching for my sharp shadow while a terror had paced at my back, never seen.

Apart from the men on the beach, I am alone in this place ... and it scares me! No man should ever be alone, not like this.

I leave the safety of the lookout point and scramble down the settled collapse of rocks to the little stream. When I reach the strand the man pauses, stares at me with hopeless eyes.

"He's dead. Help me. Please ... help? We have to bury him."

I circle past the man as he resumes his digging. He uses his hands to scrape clumps of wet sand up to the lip of the hole, but as one clump reaches its destination, another two crumble from the sides to the bottom, which already swirls in water.

I am glad to see that the Vital Breath of Maak has departed; he did not deserve to suffer such agonies.

"Why are you digging a hole?"

"I have to bury him. I can't leave him here."

"How does burying your brother's flesh honour him?"

My words break him from his work.

"He has to be buried. Dead people get buried, or cremated."

"Cremated?"

"Burned."

I nod my approval at this idea. "To burn the flesh is a good way to honour a brother. And it would be safer than staying here."

The words that I share with the man seem to bring some focus back into his face.

"Is there danger here? Apart from the fucking fish ..."

"There's danger everywhere," I tell him, "though there's more danger in this place than there is elsewhere. Especially because you've dug a hole in the sand. Making holes so close to the healing pools – the crabs will be angry beyond their endurance."

"Crabs ...?"

I wave my arm towards the cliffs. "Come with me. We shall build your brother a pyre away from the reach of the crabs, yes?"

Sam looks down to his feet, the hole in which he's planted them. His mouth moves as he breathes hard. Five breaths. Ten breaths.

"Yes," he agrees, wiping his hand across his tear-tracked cheek.

## 5. The Flayman

The climb to the top of the ridge, which separates the place of the abandoned longhouse and the next big valley downwind, was tough. Yet good work: from this height I can see the clear length of the wide woodlands we have just crossed and the much narrower, meaner vale that we need to tackle next. More worrisome, I spot clouds bustling like waves around the distant mountain and its High Domains; soon the wind will lie to us and cold rain will clatter our tired bodies.

Sam lags behind me. The man makes too much use of his stick to help him climb; he should trust the exertion to help toughen his ankles against future sprains.

When he finally scrambles close enough, I offer my hand and grab at his broken spear, help haul him up the last few strides to the summit.

"This is a good place for us to eat. Give me your bag."

He shrugs it from his back and hands it over wordlessly, too busy sucking air into his lungs to argue with me. As I take the kelp net from him, he hunkers down on a rock shelf just below me; once seated, he sets to fussing at his leg, pulling the offending ankle onto his knee so he can prod at it.

"You should leave it alone," I tell him. "Pain only works its spite when you make it feel welcome."

He ignores my advice. From my own bag I fish out a snack: sweet smelling brelfruit, possibly over-ripe. I use the food to net his attention away from his injury by holding one of the ruby globes near to his nose. He grasps it quickly, grunts his thanks and bites into the flesh without bothering to check for fretworms.

"You speak English," he says, finally, his chin smeared with juice. "How do you know English?"

The question bemuses me. "I speak words. I share my words with you – do you not like this gift?"

"No. I mean I'm glad you're talking now." He muffles his voice in the fruit as he takes a second bite. "It's just that this isn't England, yet you speak English."

"'Ing Lend' – what is an 'Ing Lend'? What is 'Ing Lish'?"

"England – it's a place." He looks around at the view from his ledge. "A big, big island. It's the place where I come from. In England we speak English."

I'm sure he means to make sense with his words – I can see no guile in his eyes. I have to shake my head.

"There are many places in this land, but we don't give them names. Names are for people, for gangs and clans. Not for rocks and streams. Words are precious things."

"So you don't have a name for any of this?" He waves his fruit wide around him before returning it to his mouth for another bite.

"I have heard my gang brothers call it Fol Huun, for this is Fol Huun's world."

"Is 'Fowl Hoon' your chieftain? Your leader? The big man?"

"Fol Huun is ... Fol Huun. She is everywhere."

"She's your goddess, then. You worship her."

I can only shake my head again. "Your words – they make no sense to me. 'Goddess'? 'Worship'?"

"Pray to; kneel before. Love?"

I consider the ideas for a moment. "I have 'loved' some women in my brighter moments, taking much enjoyment with them before and after we slept ... I would not know how to love Fol Huun. She is ... She's not a woman. Is love a 'worship'?"

"Loving – worshipping – isn't fucking," he says, letting his foot fall from its perch on his knee and leaning back against the rock. "Worshipping is ... you close your eyes and pray to God, and ask Him for favours and



blessings to help you get through the bad times, and you have to thank Him for the good stuff as well ... I suppose. Maybe if I had done more worshipping when I was alive, I wouldn't be here now."

"Alive. 'Alive' and 'dead'; 'night' and 'day'. 'Worship' and 'fuck' – do all your mystery words come in such pairs?"

"You know what death is: you saw Marc! He's dead now; we burned him."

I can't argue with an argument that struggles to make sense to me. Instead I turn my eyes to my own fruit. I sniff the rind at several spots, checking for the whiff of worm before taking my knife to slice at the ruddy flesh.

"Why do we have to climb over these hills? Why couldn't we follow that road?"

"You ask too many questions, yes? I told you, the avenues are not safe. Not for us."

"Yeah. You've got monsters in your woods. Like you've got nasty crabs on the beach that we have to run away from."

"Listen to your words." The man tires my ears with his uncalled questions. "Everything is dangerous ..."

I glance at his brelfruit and spot a telltale thread weaving its way towards his thumb. Quickly, I reach down and slap the half-eaten snack from his hand as he makes to take another bite: "... Even the little fretworms that are about to feast on your face! Believe me on this."

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The avenues are deceptions, like the tracks of nectar that tempt an unsuspecting fly into the burning waters pooled in the base of the pot vine's leaf.

"But you must have been born somewhere!"

Brother Sam talks too much.

I wave him to silence before carefully parting the curtain of dangling traps and slowly pushing my head into the space beyond.

This avenue is much rougher than the first, almost like the bed of a storm fed stream. It runs in a shallow gully below us. It looks deserted, but something about the place – maybe the lack of noise, or a whiff of not-quite-right – makes me mistrust my eyes.

The new-grown hairs on my arm pucker: something is down there, waiting.

"Everyone is born, and everyone has to ..."

I turn and slap my hand across the man's mouth before my heart has a chance to complete its beat. I push him backwards, force him to take unseen steps away from the gully. As soon as we are clear I turn him – my palm still clamped tight to his face – and propel him to the safety of the trees that make this rocky hillside their home.

For once, he doesn't struggle.

I head for a tree a little way uphill. It is larger than the others, with buttress roots flaring from its wide trunk; at some point, not too long ago, men had marked it for felling, chipping a set of steps into one of the sloping roots.

It will serve in a crisis.

"Climb!" I whisper into his ear. "No words, no protests. Be silent, yes? Climb high!"

I don't wait to see if he does as he's told.

I crouch low as I turn back to the avenue, angling my route seawards towards a spot where, I hope, the gully walls will be at their highest. The ground is more level in this direction, it allows me to use my hands to clamber over and between rocky outcrops. I approach the lip of the gully almost on my belly.

I was right to mistrust my eyes.

It leans absolutely still, its back tight against the avenue's opposite wall. Its face is directed away from my vantage, with all its senses seemingly focussed on the curtain of pot vines a little distance landwards.

A flayman! Part of me wonders why it has wandered so far from its normal hunting grounds.

Its masking is near perfect – it was perfect, I realise, for anyone broaching the avenue from where we had just been. Its fur-less body has taken on the hues of the rocks and soils of the bank behind it, and it has flattened and flared its skin to muffle its outline and minimise any tell-tale shadows. But from this angle the colours don't quite match their background, and darkness behind the legs and arms help define its man-like shape.

There's rain in the air, and the breeze is becoming fickle. At the moment it probably can't smell me, but one misguided gust from the coming storm will be enough to ruin my emerging plan.

Flaymen. What do I know about them?

They are not real men, though they may take a man's shape. Their limbs are thinner and their chests are barely wide enough to accommodate a narrow neck and slim, sloping shoulders. I skull-speak of them as flat men – things that scuttle-creep through the woods looking for people – no, men – to feast on. When travelling landwards, a wise man does not sleep unless one of his brothers watches over him, or he has a woman's protections about him.

Achoa once told me that they feed on a man's terror, tracking their prey by the droplets of fear that spring from the pits and crotches of flesh caught alone in the woods. I'm counting on Sam to flood the woods with a torrent of such sweat. I cannot hope to get behind the beast on the avenue, where only two approaches are possible. I need to tackle it on more level ground.

"What's going on, savage?"

Without call, I pivot on one heel and smash my fist into Sam's face. As he staggers I sweep my leg behind him, tripping him backwards. He reaches out to grab at me as he falls – and I oblige him, grasping his arm as he grasps

mine. I use my weight to swing him and lever him onto his side, bringing him close to the gully's lip.

I push him over the ledge.

He screams out as he falls. The sound is enough to give me a few moments to dash landwards, to a place where the slope down onto the avenue is less steep. As I reach my new vantage and crouch down, I pull the glass knife from its loop in my belt and place it – carefully – between my teeth.

The flayman has its full attention on Sam, who has come to a halt at the avenue's verge and now sits and rocks, holding his arm. I doubt that he can see the creature.

It moves.

I have met flaymen before. This one lacks the fluid motion of those other beasts; its limbs jerk as it pushes each one forward – quietly, slowly, taking its time to keep its masking intact, both by colour and by shape. Away from the gully wall it flattens itself to the level ground, making its body no more than a couple of hands higher than the surrounding surface.

"Scream some more, brother," I let my voice whisper. "Let the clouds of your rage enchant it."

I watch the edges of its skin flare and flutter, their silent buzz a blur to hide its methodical advance. It is barely two man-lengths away from its victim when it jerks its arm forward too quickly, disrupting its disguise.

Sam spots the movement; he has a puzzled look on his face. When his eyes resolve on the threat of the stickman his mouth forms a perfect circle. He doesn't bother to scream; instead he scrabbles hands and feet into the dirt and stones around him, attempts to climb back up the bank, his chest to the sky in a jape of the creature's own gait.

The flayman takes a moment to snuffle at the air, gauge distances and trajectories.

And then it leaps.

Now I move! I lever my way down onto the avenue track as quietly as possible. A drop of rain falls on my shoulder and a small gust kisses my face – the breeze has chosen to change direction, trailing my scent landwards.

I know the breeze could reverse itself at any moment; storms have that habit.

The flayman has judged its leap well: Sam smothers beneath its cloak of loose skin. Now it works at enfolding its victim into its own shape, but the man struggles against the attack with enough strength to heave them both away from the ground.

I take my chance and charge: two dozen long strides bringing me to the fight. I don't give a breath to hesitation. Copying the flayman's attack, I launch myself onto the struggling bodies and crush them both back to the ground. With the man-beast pinioned by my weight, I scrabble through its fleshy sheets, seeking the creature's head.

It reacts by spiking its skin against me, the needles sharp with the threat of barbed pain at each tip. I already have a leg beneath me, ready to hurl myself away, when my hand makes contact with its hidden head. I reach down further into the flap-dancing mass and clench my fingers around its neck. Already I have my knife in my other hand and bring it down on the beast's throat.

It shrieks! The noise is shrill in my ears, loud to the point of pain. My arm jerks in beat to the judders of the flayman's limbs as I saw and hack through gristle and cartilage. The creature beneath me cascades harsh colours across its skin, their flashes an attempt to set my eyes to a fit. I carve harder, pushing my full weight into the action.

When the head rolls free of its neck, I bowl it away.

The creature's flesh is like elastic bark: I cannot cut through it. Standing, I grasp at the body and overturn it.

Sam still struggles against his new cloak. I follow a free leg into the folds and pull the warm flaps away from their wrap. Hips are exposed, then a back, a shoulder, an arm.

The final part of Sam to emerge is his face, raw already from the flayman's bile. He whoops air into his lungs as I pull the monster free and fling it to one side – where it disappears in a heartbeat, merging its shapes and colours with the stones and earths beneath it.

6. The Longhouse

"You used me as fucking bait?"

"I apologise. It was the only way I could deal with it."

Below us, waves pile into the long inlet; they dance as the storm pushes them first this way and then that way. Thankfully this longhouse has a sturdy construction, its roof and walls still entire. The gang who built it, halfway up the side of the hill, are – were – skilled craftsman, with an eye for a good view.

"I could have died!"

"You still breathe, yes?"

"That's not the point ... you did kill it: tell me you killed it?"

I offer the man sat opposite me a smile: "Kill it?"

"Kill it. End its life. Like Marc."

"If you mean: 'did I take its breath from its flesh,' then no. I did not *kill* it. That one has been damaged – it will take it a fair while to re-grow its head, but it has not gone."

A look of disgust wraps creases around Sam's mouth. "Are there more of those things around?"

"I doubt it. They do not tolerate each other's company very well. And they hardly ever venture this close to the sea."

"So we're safe here?"

"From flaymen? Yes. They never climb; they seem to distrust wood."

"But there's other dangers – what were those worms in that fruit? Could they have killed me?"

I recall our journey, seek his worry: "Fretworms?"

He nods.

"They are an annoyance," I tell him. "They live in the fruit, but sometimes they make their home in a man's cheeks, rotting the flesh by their passage. The irritation can lead to torture, but most men afflicted with a fretworm will throw themselves from a cliff long before that happens."

"What, they get into your brain?"

I glance at the fire sat in its hard-clay hearth in the middle of the room. The wood that I had found piled at the far end of the longhouse burns brightly, with little smoke.

"I've not heard of that happening."

"Why else would a man throw himself from a cliff?"

"To free his Vital Breath from his bones, of course."

Tiring of the constant questions, I stand up and walk across the tight-fitting planks over to the fire. "Where did you put your bag? We can bake the last of those sourscape roots; they'll be ready to eat by the time we wake."

Receiving no answer, I turn to see if he is watching me. Instead I find him with his head cocked to one side and his tongue loose at the edge of his lips. I can spot a skull-speaking posture when I see one.

"What worries you?"

"I thought I was dead," he starts. "When I first came to ... I remember dying, I think. In the tomb under the warehouse, and then there were lights, and floating ... and Marc was floating with me: somehow I knew it was him ... and something tried to grab us, engulf us, but we followed the demon – shit, there really was a demon? In my fucking head?"

He considers his own question for a moment. "And then I was floating. Marc helped me escape from the bag in the rock pool. He said we weren't dead, that we would live forever now – together forever ... but I told him I was dead and then ... then he really did die. That fish killed him ..."

A crack of burning wood breaks into the relative silence caused by the man's faltering trail of words.

"Your brother ... Maak, yes? You say he is dead – killed ..."

I retrace my steps, hunker back down and place my hand on Sam's shoulder. "His flesh is burned," I continue, "but his Vital Breath remains."

"What do you mean?"

"Always the questions with you! Your brother's flesh is burned – we burned it: a good honouring, that – but his Vital Breath still exists ..."

"Like a spirit? A ghost?"

I shake my head. "More words that have no meaning to me. A man's Vital Breath leaves his body when the pain becomes too much, and the lungs and heart cease their counting. Your Maak will have found himself a healing pool and even now he will be growing new flesh. In a dozen sleeps, or a hundred – however long it takes him – he will emerge from the healing pool ..."

"You mean he's alive? Like a reincarnation?"

"Don't look so glad, brother Sam." I spot the bag across the room and stand to fetch the roots from it. "I doubt he'll be happy with you, not after the agony you forced him to endure. What did he do to you to make you hate him so badly?"

The man shifts his weight from one buttock to the other, leans back on his arms to look at me directly.

"Reincarnation – that's a lie! We die and we go to Heaven, or Hell. Or maybe Purgatory. That's what the vicar said when I asked him. He said my Mum would surely be in Heaven with God. He said maybe Dad was in Purgatory, because he was a good man with just one moment of madness marked on his soul ..."

I have work to do: the sourscape roots won't wrap themselves. But the man's gaze is steady on me, it keeps me from turning my back on him.

"... this place, maybe it's Purgatory. Maybe my Dad is here."

'Dad' ...

Like many of the words that Brother Sam spatters into the air, it holds no meaning to me. And yet the sound of it in my ears feels – worthy. Secure.

The opening at the far end of the longhouse flares as a spear of lightning passes from sky to sea. The thunderous crack of its passage follows quickly after, loud enough to make me duck to the floor.

"Shit! That was a close one!" I turn and see him grinning at me, as if to laugh at the fear clenching my guts.

It is pride that straightens my knees, and my spine. Pride that takes my feet across the room to the bag and the sustenance it contains. My bones determine that I must fight this sudden panic, refuse it access to my face and my bowels, refuse to let it reflect in the eyes of a stranger.

Never have I netted a glimpse of the sky and the sea commune in such a violent manner before.

So why does my silent voice shape the sounds 'lightning' and 'thunder' to describe such impossibilities?

~~~

I have counted a hundred breaths twenty times; still my body refuses to sleep.

Brother Sam sleeps. A while into my count, after we had settled on separate sides of the hot hearth clay, he had crawled hand-by-knee over to me and shaped his limbs around mine. I had kept my eyes closed and allowed a few snores to rattle from my throat; apparently he was not looking to play for his true snores soon joined my false ones in an offbeat duet.

There is a comfort in his warm skin, but not enough to still the chaotic chants of my silent voice. Oh, how I sing in my head, sound on sound: 'mum', 'dad'; 'alive', 'dead'. Nonsense words ripe in their healing pools deep in my lung, begging for release and welcome – 'day', 'night'; 'sun', 'thunder' ...

Slowly I shift the weight of the man's leg from my hip – my *right* hip, I recall – and ease my body from his cuddle. The fire has burned to embers

and glowing ash; I should add more logs to it: it had taken me an age to coax flames from the tinder.

Let it burn out.

I step towards the long wall of the open room, settle myself down in a gap between the plank walls where my legs can dangle over the platform's edge high above the waves.

The world I look upon is far darker than it should be. Above me, the clouds are shaking the last of their rain down to the sea's purple waters; only the tightest shreds of mauve sky streak between their grey towers. The – lightning – that so scared me has gone, and the storm no longer bellows in pain. Even the wind is settling back to its true path: as I sit I can hear its gusts ruffle the fronds that stack over the roof, feel them buffet my face.

*Mum. Dad ...*

I know these words. I know the intimate shape of them in my throat, the lip's kiss of one and the tongue's tut of the other. I know their touch around my body.

I cannot recall them.

The missing call pulls another from my Dream Sight. A guardian's sharp yellow beak pressing into my flesh as it pushed words into my hidden ear: *'I know you. I do not recall you.'*

It has been twenty eight sleeps since I broke from the healing pool. I haven't seen a guardian since before my first sleep.

No brothers, no women. No guardians ...

"Are you crying?"

His voice startles me! I have to grab at the wall to stop my body flinging itself into the air. An instant later I feel his hands clutch around my arm.

I stare at his thumbs, his arms; his face. It takes an effort for me to draw air into my chest and, when it departs, it carries a laugh with it.

"Shit, brother! When did you learn to be so quiet?"

Brother Sam smiles, loosens his grip and slaps me on the shoulder as he settles on the ledge next to me. "Your eyes are wet ..."

"It still rains ..."

"... and red. I didn't think you were capable of crying."

As he speaks the words, I realise the truth in them. I can feel the tell of an ache in my face that signals a moment of failure, an image of grief as when in the Race the opposition draws clear beyond the power of my sinews, the strength of my gang brothers, to pull level. It is a feeling of undeniable, unalterable loss.

A sharper gust shivers my skin. "I'm cold," I reply. "The fire's almost out."

"And that makes you cry, Savage?"

"Another nonsense word springs from your tongue. What does 'sa vij' mean?"

"You haven't told me your name yet. 'Savage' is what you do, with your black knives and spears and digging for eggs in the mud. I don't know what else to call you."

I consider these words for a moment. Names are ... difficult ... things. I've learned to my cost that my name in the wrong mouth can tether me as effectively as any stake. But I don't know how to explain this to the man.

I gaze across the bay to watch the waves shatter themselves in the rocks. Thankfully, Sam chooses to honour my silence. I do not move my hand away when he weaves his fingers into mine.

Again I count breaths: ten; twenty; thirty. The part of me that is not counting is assessing the storm's damage to the trees around the bay: there will be plenty of branches and kindling to harvest when I next wake.

Fingers stroke across my forearm, pinch at my elbow before easing down to the wrist and into my palm. It is a welcome gesture, I realise. My digits need no order from me to spread wide their welcome.

"A man I knew told me, once, about a world with yellow skies. And I heard a woman claim she had walked under skies that turned blue, then black, then blue again – though that sky hosted all colours because there was fire in it."

When he draws my hand into his lap I follow its tug, letting my shoulder – my *left* shoulder – rest against his. "What colour was your sky?"

"Blue," he answers after a pause. "When I was alive, my sky was as blue as my Mum's eyes." His free hand travels across my back as he speaks, and comes to rest on my hip. I feel the bristle of his chin as it nudges towards my ear.

"Tell me about your 'alive'."

He sighs as his head nestles against mine. "My life? I don't know ... sometimes I struggle to remember it. I was born in a big city called London – it used to be the biggest city in the world ... it used to rule the world, though that was before my time. I grew up there, went to school, then college for a while. I worked and lived there; I wish I had travelled more, now: so much to see ... but then most of the world came to London so I didn't really need to travel. The kids at my school spoke dozens of different languages ..."

Most of his words are empty gourds of meaning to me, but I enjoy their sound. "You told me about 'ing-lish' – this is a 'lang-wij', yes?"

"I can say 'fuck off' in nine languages."

When I turn to look at him, he presses his half-parted lips against mine. The shock of the act flicks my head backwards.

"I'm sorry ... you don't want ... this?"

I look into his face and see a whisper of hurt and worry in its set. The angle of his stare begs an answer from me.

"Want ... I do not know your meaning. We have already met ... yet your hands ... they tell of a different thing. They say you want us to comfort each other."

"So you are gay – I guessed you were." My eyes must be crossed in confusion. "Homosexual. You like to fuck men?"

"Ah!" I say as the sprays of misknowing clear from my call. "You *do* talk of comfort. I know this now. If no woman is willing to give comfort then yes, there is no shame in taking it from a willing brother. But kisses like that one ... they are a woman's trap!"

His smile is enough to let me know that he doesn't understand my words. How can I explain this?

"Listen to my words. Sometimes a woman will use her lips to ... to snap a man from the safety of his gang brothers. And yet a woman's kiss is a great pleasure; all men will risk everything for the gift of a woman's kiss, and the greater gifts that follow it. But such kisses can loosen the words in our heads and set our purposes to the flames."

I squeeze his fingers between mine. "All gifts have a reckoning. So brothers do not kiss ... well, we kiss to welcome each other, and to congratulate each other on the success of our work together. But we do not kiss like a woman kisses, not for ... this kind of comfort."

He nods his head, still smiling. "In my world, it's the other way round. Men may never kiss each other in public. We must shake hands when we meet, and can slap each other on the back for a good job. But kissing is a secret thing, done between men when they're alone."

"In your world there are no women?"

Now he laughs at me. "Of course we have women! And yes, they kiss just like men. All sorts of kissing. It's normal. Everybody does it."

I can feel my surprise stretch my face. "Normal?"

"Perfectly normal!"

I can only shake my head. "Your kiss, it was a dangerous kiss! Do you not know that? Women are dangerous: they use that sort of kiss to catch men."

Sam laughs. "And men don't like to be caught by women? It sounds like a gay paradise!"

"Not always so happy. Our women are often hungry after the comforting, and they adore the taste of raw man-flesh. That is the reckoning of a woman's kiss."

"They eat ...? I don't get what you're saying – you're laughing at me."

"They don't just eat men. They have a use for every part of a man's body: the skin makes good hide, and the sinews ..."

"People mustn't eat each other: that's wrong!"

"How do you mean wrong?" I consider his obvious disgust. "What else should be done to a man's flesh once his Vital Breath has returned to the pools?"

Because burning is wasteful.

"Of course," I continue, "a man will only offer his flesh to a brother after losing a Race to that brother's gang. And our leader's flesh – win or lose – must always be gifted to Fol Huun's guardians. Though it is true that some women prefer to eat a man's flesh while it still holds the Vital Breath ..." An image of pain shudders my spine "That is never a good thing – those women are never to be trusted ..."

I look across the bay to the hill. The trees no longer fight among each other, and the waves that lap on the rocks have lulled to a caress. Achoa had very sharp teeth, an image reknows to me.

"So ... you love men in a different way to how you love women."

I give his words time to play in my ears.

"I suppose so. Why else would Fol Huun give men and women different shapes? And you can never turn your back on a woman."

"But you always fuck a man from behind?"

"It usually ends up that way. It depends on how we wrestle – the stronger will take the weaker, but when two men are well matched they may share their pleasure ... " I lift our joined hands to my face, pull his thumb to my mouth – in, and out "... like that."

He brings his head forward, lets his teeth nibble on my little finger.  
"So men *do* eat each other."

"Maybe we – taste – each other, beyond the Race. Sometimes."

"But you never taste each other's tongues."

"Only to say 'well done' ..."

"Would you let me say 'well done' to you? You know I am not a woman ... " Now he is drawing our hands back down to his thighs, then higher, untangling our fingers so he can cup my palm around his growing prick "... and I only want to taste you, never eat you."

When his – *right* – arm tightens around my waist, and his fingers stroke their way to my own twitching stalk, my body does what my Inner Voice would not. I shift my legs and relax into his embrace.

"I reckon you are not from Fol Huun", I say, "just like Brother Geit said he came from a different place. Maybe he didn't lie."

I arch my neck back to look at Sam. "Geit kissed me once, as a woman kisses, and he didn't eat me – this is true." I reach up to let our lips brush past each other. "But I shall keep my eyes open, just in case."

His tongue is quick between the breach of my teeth; swift darts to test their roots in my gum before rolling under, then over, my own word-shaper. He tastes – salty, and dry: a man in need of a drink, keen to suckle on saliva. He has no fear; I watch as lids slip lazily over eyes. When he sighs air through his mouth I accept the gift readily into my lungs, hug it in ribs and – reluctantly – return it.

Raindrops peck on my leg where it reaches beyond the safety of the longhouse's planks. When his teeth nip at my lip I tense my toes straight and stiffen the sinews around my – *right* – knee. I push my – *left* – shoulder



deeper into his chest ... and we topple together; his elbow halts our slow fall.

He breaks the kiss with a grin, his lids half-opening as he pulls back his head until only our nose-tips touch. "You are eager. You've played this game before!"

An instinct pulls me from the moment: quick glances around the space to check for knives and binding ropes.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Which is true. Our nets lie beyond the glowing hearth clays, my knife and tools safely hidden within them.

"You want to wrestle?" He moves his hand away from my groin to grasp my shoulder. I can smell my must on his fingers.

I move my own hand and catch his meat-stones, grip the neck of their pouch in a drawstring of thumb and finger. "I'm good at wrestling. I will not hurt you too badly."

He looks down at his groin, and laughs. "That must be against the rules!"

"Only the Race has rules."

"That's not fair!" He surprises me with another kiss, slipping the full length of his tongue into my mouth. I – welcome – his move, loosen my jaw to accommodate the intruder.

I close my eyes and lose myself in the wrestling of tongues. He fights with guile and slippery persuasion, but I am not defenceless. My mouth does not need instruction from me to take advantage of a moment's laxness; soon my tongue-tip pushes at the roots of his sharp teeth.

"My arm hurts," Sam says after a while. "Shift up."

Taking advantage of our shifting weights, my eyes reflexively check the long house as my hand strokes the skin of his thigh.

"You really don't trust me?"

I stare into his eyes and smile my response.

"Tell me your name, savage."

"Kal," I say. "My brothers call me Kal."

I watch his face slacken. "Kal," he repeats.

"Mm." I reach my jaw towards his face, ready to resume the kissing battle. When our lips touch – he doesn't react.

His muscles are tightening, in his legs, his chest. I know these signals: already I'm flexing my limbs into my torso when he swiftly shifts.

"No!" he screams. A foot punches into my back, hard. The other slams into my buttocks. "Out! Get out!"

I realise without panic that my body has chosen the wrong strategy. I should have spread my limbs, kept my weight low to the floor. Instead I am closer to the edge than my sudden attacker, with nothing to hold on to.

"Get out! *Get out!*" The kicks come fast now, hard, each one pushing me closer to the gap in the wall. In moments my buttocks balance on the floor's edge.

*"Get out of ME!"*

... And I fly!

Branches rear up to catch me. I reach out my hands – and miss! One bough knocks the knots from my belly; a second sends me spinning. A third snaps my neck back. I reach out again – but my arm will not move.

I tumble through leaves, slower now: the wind slows and my heartbeat slows; a noise that has followed me deepens – it is my noise. My scream. Slowly I scream; slowly the ground grows larger, grass over rocks. Sharp, sharp rocks ...

I bounce. I roll. The rock has stolen my scream. Another tumble brings me to the water – cold, vibrant water on my face. It comes to wash the dirt from my scream. It comes to heal me. I loosen my bitten tongue from my jaw and let the water seep into my mouth ...

I cannot close my eyes ...

The water is red ... red like ... 'mother' ... and warm ...

## 7. Renewal

The water is warm, and calm. And tight.

No.

The tightness is not water. The tightness surrounds me, and the water surrounds it. The tightness is ... safe. It is good. It separates me from the surrounding water.

I open my eyes.

This healing pool is a feast of life. A set of darts captivates my fresh eyes, exercising the muscles within them to focus on this fish, then that, then another one deeper than the others. Brown fish with silver flanks, small and lithe. At one moment they shoal, their movements a perfect example of good gang craft – a demonstration of how many can become more than one, just as men can become more than men when they join together in the Race. And the next moment, they split in all directions: up, and down, and to all sides – each to its own purpose.

Some fish dart into a woodland of redweeds that glisten in their soft-glass bubbles, each leaf with its own stalk reaching down to a secret holdfast, hidden from my sight. Here, white-knotted worms and bright-tattooed shrimps graze across the fronds. When a fish approaches a worm, I watch it contract into a barrel of spikes. A slick of Dream Sight shows me stepping on such worms, when I breathed air; I recall the shock of pain that this pinhead fiend can unleash on a misplaced toe. The fish, too, knows of this worm: it backs away rapidly, soon joined by its gang brothers in a new shoal-dance.

I test my tightness. Fists and heels stretch against the toughened bladders that surround me. The water I swallow is sweet. The healing pool still has much work to do.

I close my eyes and dream of *cities*.

~~~

The crab needs a new home. Its current shell clasps it as tight as the bladders holds me. I have been watching it for a while now as it scrambles

around its rough wall, checking the quality and size of potential dwellings with its great blue claw. None pass muster.

Closer to me a snail glides across its redweed frond. It is an admirable beast with a strong grey foot and bright-striped stalks for its eyes. Its shell is large enough to attract its own vegetation – a miniature forest of fine green nets, complete with a tiny sting flower. I know this snail: its flesh is tart-sweet on the tongue, but fiddly to prepare – it carries within it a spear whose poison can separate a man from his flesh within a hundred heartbeats.

Clearly the crab doesn't care. It needs a new roost. Already it is scuttling across the rock face towards me, to confront this unwelcome visitor to our pool. It even leaps at one point, launching itself across a fissure. When it lands, its old home drags it backwards, downwards towards the sands that lie in deep shadows beneath us, almost at the limit of my improving sight. It takes some nifty claw-work, and a savaged sting flower in the wrong place at the wrong time, before the crab finds a firm footing and continues its hunt.

A call occurs to me: helping the crab could help me. The frond on which the snail grazes almost touches my bladders – I recall stories told by my brothers about snails just like this one: of how they like to feed on the eyes of new-forming flesh, of how they will glide over the face and slowly puncture through bladders to send a man's Vital Breath screaming in agony to a fresh healing pool.

I twist in my tightness, send ripples of pressure to push the frond towards the rock wall and the approaching crab.

I watch the red leaf recede.

I watch the red leaf slowly rebound back towards me. Still the snail glides along its Processional path, oblivious to the movements beneath its great, grey foot. Does it know that I'm here?

It stops. Slowly, it detaches the base of its head from the frond and lifts up its body. Slowly, it waves its head through the water, as if sniffing for opportunities. Striped stalks retract, then one bulb extends towards me.

It is no more than two hands from my face. The other eye also grows, its direction a sure and true copy of its twin.

It knows that I'm here.

A weave of fear catches in my throat. If there was air in my lungs, I would bellow!

A heart thud passes, then another. Somehow, I've managed to keep my body still. Slowly, the distance between the snail and my face grows – three hands, now four. And a finger. The snail's frond is a branch in watery gale; it has no choice but to sway.

It takes an effort to wrench my stare from the flesh grazer. I look to see where the crab has gone. A shock of relief gallops through my limbs when I finally spot its frantic semaphores. It clings to the rock-face, close to where the frond should collide. All the crab needs to do is wait ...

It doesn't wait! It can see its new house, and is eager to start the eviction. It leaps from the rock, its many legs splayed like a cast net.

It misses the leaf!

How could the japing creature miss?

The old roost, I realise. The crab has let weeds grow across the shell and, like a hand through water, the weeds push against the crab's eager speed. It passes within a pincer's tip of the snail's trail, and plummets down, and down to places where my unbelieving eyes can barely make out its form. When it hits the sand, a great flurry of grains erupts: a flash of teeth, a slash of spines ...

At least I now know that I share my healing pool with a rappoe fish. I must knot that know safely, somewhere, to not step on the sand when the time comes to seek air.

And now the snail starts to swing back towards me. I have a choice: to struggle in the hope it slips from its frond, falls to the jaws hidden in the sand; or to remain still, hoping that the beast loses interest in me.

I recall stories of rotting faces within bladders, of burning hurts from a splinter of a spear to the face.

I struggle!

I twist and tumble in my stiffened bladders. I stretch and collapse, I try to roll myself into its path, hoping to crush it between my back and the rock. I yell, expelling piss-tainted fluids from my new lungs!

My final roll swivels my face directly into the snail's path. I stare, mouth open, as it rears once again and flares its sticky foot wide. When it extrudes the lethal thorn from the depths of its flesh, I cannot close my eyes. A cold shock shivers in my blood. Three fingers of water separate me from agony; two fingers ...

A golden shape, sharp, plunges towards me ... from above? Long it is – as long as my new hand – and swift! Down it comes, straight and true ... straight for the killer as it feathers onto my face!

And then the beak is gone, leaving behind nothing more than a froth of bubbles and a stump of a redweed frond, raggedly torn.

My eyes need no prompting to roll back in their sockets as I faint.

~~~

*~ You are different. You remain old; I know you. Yet you are also new: I do not know you. This is a different thing.*

I can barely make out the form of the guardian. It perches on a rock just above the water's surface, and that surface is being rippled by the wind. All guardians are big, I know, and most come clothed in a set of grey-on-white feathers. This guardian has a very impressive bill – bright yellow with a red patch beneath the hook that terminates it.

*~ The other egg is still new, though I have seen it before. I know it, but I do not recall it. This is another different thing.*

*~ I recall me, my Inner Voice tells the guardian. ~ Do you recall me?*

The bird considers this proposition, cocking its head lower to bring its eye closer to mine. I take time to admire the slice of its beak.

*~ You recall this sky, it says. ~ This is clear to me.*

I am impressed. The guardians are not known for their helpfulness, or for their conversational skills. I risk another question.

*~ I have heard of other skies. A sky as yellow as your beak. And a sky that has no colour, and all colours, but mainly blue. I have dreamed of such skies.*

*~ But you do not recall them.*

*~ No, I agree.*

The bird's head disappears. Wings spread wide to fill my sight. "Ak! Ak! Ak!"

Jiar tried to teach me the language of the guardians, once, though I doubt he knew any more of it than I. This call could be a challenge, or a summoning. No man has a real understanding of the guardians beyond the necessary. It is enough to know that they do not appreciate being plucked, or eaten.

The bladders surrounding me have shrunk, and the liquids they hold are stale. Soon I will need to break free of them and resume the counting of breaths.

My renewal will be much easier if the guardian agrees to help me. A recent image, vivid in its haloes, recalls the deserted groves and abandoned long houses; I doubt that any brother will be looking for me in this healing pool.

Wings fold, and the beak returns to my sight.

*~ I know you. I recall you. I welcome you, Kal of Tintuun. You I shall aid. The other – I know it, but I do not recall it. I cannot help it. That is your task.*



The guardian moves out of my sight, but it is not gone. I feel a sharp stab in my thigh, and another – it is tearing at the bladders already, eager to have me gone from the pool.

~ *Where are my brothers?* my Inner Voice cries.

~ *Stretch your legs. Your brothers have been summoned to serve a greater purpose.*

I do as I'm told. I do not struggle as my limbs extend, tearing the bladders along the holes the guardian has made in them. Soon they hang in tatters around me.

I recall - *remember?* - not to move my chest. Free in the water, I look for hand holds in the rock wall – a ledge would be better, but none has been gifted to me for this renewal.

When my head breaches into air I squeeze my ribs tight onto my lungs, and squeeze my legs deep into my belly. Water leaks from my nostrils and mouth in ropes, and then dribbles.

My first breath is deep, and loud, and complete.

## 8. Maak-em-ay-are-see

It took me less than a dozen heart thumps to grow used to breathing air again. By the way this man is choking and whooping, curled in limbs on the sharp rocks, it will be *days* before he recovers his strength.

Not that this world of Fol Huun has ever experienced *days*, or *nights*.

Not that I recall what a day - or a night - is. My Dream Sight fails to supply me with any recollection of living in a world with alternating blue-black-blue skies. But somewhere, deep within me, I *know* what 'day' means.

The healing pool seems to have fixed more than my flesh, this time around.

The man at my feet is taller than me. Or he would be, if he could find it within him to control his jerking legs long enough to stand.

"I told you not to breathe the salt water."

If he can hear me, he makes no effort to show it.

I want to walk away from the man. The sky shines brightly at this moment, and the rocks have embraced the brightness and responded with a strong heat. The wind, too, blows more warmly than it should. Soon I will need water – proper water, not the sea's brine – and it has been a long while – *weeks*, maybe – since I last chewed and swallowed real food.

I cannot walk away. The guardian made it clear that this man is my responsibility. I am to be his brother, whatever his calls on the matter may be.

Reluctantly I crouch down by his head and place my hands on his shaking shoulder. I can spot blood on the rocks. I need to move him to safety soon, I realise. The smell of blood will attract the attention of the crabs – proper crabs, not like the little hermit in my healing pool – with claws capable of snipping through a man's wrist.

"Can you hear me? If you can hear me, open your eyes."

His eyes are a mix of brown and grey – larger than Jiar's perhaps, who claimed he could see the caldera's cold sheen from the beach – or maybe his face is narrower, longer. He holds my gaze for a moment, no more, before returning to the comforts of his own agonies.

"Good. Your name is Maak, yes? I recall you. I saw you on the beach. Do you recall the beach?"

He offers me a definite nod, before embarking on another series of body-shaking coughs.

"This is good, too. Do you recall the rappoe fish? You caught it on your spear, and then it caught your face on its spines. Tell me if you recall the fish."

The man springs his eyes open so wide as to show a full ring of white about them. His hand clasps at my arm.

"You recall the fish, then. This is good."

I consider my words. "Well, maybe not so much 'good' as 'useful'. But it is not a pain that we should try and recall too well, yes?"

He squeezes his face shut in a grimace. Gently I take his hand and lead it up to lay flat on his cheek.

"Can you feel through your fingers? Feel your face – see, it is whole again. The only pain there is the pain you recall. It is not a real pain, a 'now' pain."

He tries to speak: "Ssss. Ssss ... mm ..."

"Hush, now. There are things we need to do. You need to do. You must stand up, yes? We cannot stay here. This is where that fish lives, and we do not want to attract its attention again, nor that of its friends. You need to stand up!"

~~~

He tells me that his name is 'Marc-em-ay-are-see'. To me, it sounds like a long echo of 'maak', but then it is his name, not mine, and he can add

whatever sounds he likes to it. I shall call him 'you', when I have to call him anything.

I told him my name was 'sav-idj'. He said that 'sav-idj' was a thing, not a name. I didn't bother to argue with him, or tell him my real name: the last time I shared my name I ended up falling through branches and smashing my skull on the rocks.

It took a bag-load of heartbeats to get the man to his feet, and another countless time to shamle him from there to this grove. A flash of image tells me that it was right here, in this grove, that I first saw Marc-em-ay-are-see, hollering like a skull-addled man, naked and not caring to guard himself from the attentions of women. Now I understand why he acted like that: he is not of Fol Huun; he has no concept of where he is, or how to survive here.

Such insights don't make me like the man. He may be my only gang right now, but he will never be my brother.

I've left him sleeping in the grove's dilapidated roost. I am on a search for food and fresh water. And if I can find that guardian, some answers.

~~~

"Not that one. It's far too hard! Am I wasting my words on a deaf man? Poke it!"

The glistening brelfruits lay scattered around my feet, there in the woods high above the bay. Luntas, who had led me to the fruiting grounds, was scowling at me. I was keen not to disappoint him – he was the only brother in the gang who had bothered to take an interest in me since I had been pulled from the healing pool. He had promised me that, if I learned quickly, he would persuade the others to etch my skin with ink, not knives.

The fruit in my hand seemed fine to me; its skin had flexed when I pushed my thumb on it, and bounced back to the round when I let go. But when I had plucked it up from the ground, it had pulled a rope of stiff white root behind it.

"Shall I push it back in?"

"No!" The man took a moment to glance at the sky and curse any guardian that might have been nearby. "Sheesh, they must have tortured

you for an age of sleeps before sending you to our pools. Can you honestly recall nothing from when you last breathed?"

I shook my head. "All I see inside me, around me, is coldness. A coldness like to crack bones."

"They say the caldera reaches beyond the clouds, with winds that carry white rain. The women there must have kept you in a high cave while they tortured you. Tie the root to that branch overhead: if you put it back on the ground now it will spread a rot through the whole patch."

As I followed his orders, I took a moment to feel the whole fruit with my fingers. The base of the globe, close to the root, was much harder than the rest of the shiny red flesh.

"It needs to be soft at the bottom, yes?"

"Firm, not mushy. And you must twist before you lift it. See the cluster of buds close to where the root joins it? In a dozen sleeps, one of those buds would have grown big to replace the fruit you've just plucked."

His words made sense to me. Soon enough my mistake was tied securely to the branch and I was on my knees poking at another brelfruit, and another, until I found one softer than the others. Carefully I twisted it around its base until I heard a soft crack as it broke from its root.

"Good," said Luntas. "You do know how to learn." It was with some pride that I placed my prize into the net tied around my naked waist. His net was already half-full, I noticed. "But stay off your knees, huh? Bend to the fruit, don't kneel to it."

"Because that's quicker?"

"Because once a man is on his knees, he never stands up again."

~~~

~ Why do you show me this dream?

The great gull perches on a knob of rock a dozen strides upwind from where I sit on the lip of the cliff.

~ You were once like the nestling you hid in the tree. You recall this.

As astonishing as this conversation is, I struggle to make sense of the guardian's responses to the questions my Inner Voice has asked.

~ You mean the man?

There is no echo of an answer in my skull. I assume that the silence means "yes".

The turtles have been busy in the pool by the beach – they have given me three handfuls-worth of their fruits. I reach into my net and pluck one out, then nip at the leathery end to make a hole for the sucking.

Luntas! I haven't called an image of that man to me in a good while. My Dream Sight of him is not clear: snatches of speech; an occasional image of him knotting nets or spearing fish. He would help to shape a vessel, but I don't recall him ever competing for a place in the crew. His favourite places were in the hills, away from his gang brothers.

He had a better understanding than I of women.

~ The nestling names himself 'Marc-em-ay-are-see'. I have never met a man with such a long name.

I take a moment to chew on a small morsel of yolked, shelled meat.

~ He is new to Fol Huun.

All I hear in my skull is the gentle shush of waves over pebbles.

~ His brother threw me out of the longhouse. He had a short name, like mine: Sam. He talked of 'day' and 'night'. My name is Kal, but you gave me a longer name when I was in the healing pool.

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak!"

Another guardian is approaching us, its wings arch and taut as it glides across the bay. Only at the last moment do they break their shape, as it pushes its legs forward to step onto the rock. The first shuffles aside to give the newcomer room on its perch.

I un-know my trail of recalls as I watch the two batter their beaks together. Their dance is a mixture of foot stamp and hiss, one bobbing its head at the other in a regular rhythm while the other copies the movements a half-breath later. I do not realise that I've taken another turtle fruit in my hand until it touches my lip.

Luntas taught me how to find turtle fruits, and the importance of leaving half of the globes in each scrape. He had told me that the turtle fruits were the same as our healing pools: to eat them all would deprive the creatures of their renewal.

It was Luntas who told me about gang tattoos ...

Did he teach me everything?

Both gulls are staring at me. ~ *Your nestling is hungry.*

I take the hint and leave them to their dance.

~~~

"I'm not eating raw eggs!"

"They are the turtle's gift; why do you refuse them?"

Marc-em-ay-are-see has made himself a proper nest, up here in the roost. He sits in a corner of the room half-hidden by strips of old bark and hunks of half-wound twine. Two bags have been stuffed with dead leaves from the thatch above us: I reckon I will enjoy telling him the leather's source, but not just yet.

"We need to make a fire."

"The wind is warm enough."

His stare is aggressive, but I know he is not fit to fight.

"What about clothes? I need some clothes."

"We can search for clothes when you have some strength in your legs, yes?"

"I could wear your cloak. At least let me cover myself up!"

"A cloak is a gift between brothers." Which is not true. "You are not my brother."

We stare at each other for several breaths – his faster than mine. When he looks away, I feel like I've won an important victory. The man may have tried to make this roost his own, but he is no woman to command me.

"This isn't how it's supposed to be!"

I turn my back on him, settle into a crouch over my net of roots and fruits. The ruby brelfruit are particularly large, almost to the point of splitting their skin. I grab hold of a clay bowl and push the fruit into it, letting their juices escape before taking my knife to the flesh. Above me, herb pouches hang from a beam; I reach up and grab one, pull open its neck to sniff at the contents. The tart aroma of rash-tender picks at my nostrils – the leaves are old and dry, but maybe they still hold some healing properties in their crinkle. I shrug my shoulders, pour half of the leaves into the pot and stir it all together with my finger.

I straighten up and stride back to the man. I have to wave the food in front of his face before he reaches out to grab it.

"This is good fruit," I say, "with some healing powders. No need for fires to make it fit for the eating."

He picks out a lump and carefully sniffs at it, then sticks out his tongue tip to poke the flesh. When he doesn't collapse – which was a possibility, I suppose, as I have no great understanding of women's herbs – he clenches courage in his jaws and pops the lump into his mouth, eyes squeezed shut.

"Tell me about your world."

Perhaps he is too busy stuffing the bowl's contents into his mouth to hear my question. But when he lifts it to drain the last juice, I can see from his glance that he has been considering answers.

"Quid pro quo."



"Huh?"

"Quid pro quo. You tell me about this world, and I'll tell you about mine."

"I have no urge to help you."

"Then piss off!"

"Huh?"

"Piss off. Go away. I don't need your help."

The offer almost overwhelms me! Without knowing it, Marc-em-ay-are-see releases me from my obligation! But, I realise, I am not obligated to him: it is the guardian who set me this task, and my need for answers is too urgent to risk upsetting it just yet.

"Do you know where to find brelfuit, or the bark to make a cloak like mine?" My tone is harsh with resignation. "Do you know how to make a fire? Which fish is good for the eating, and which is good at killing you?"

Again we engage in a battle of stares. Again, I win. This time he slumps his body deep into the corner. "I don't know what to do. Where's Sam?"

"I do not know where your brother is ..."

"Is he dead?"

The healing pool has given me a concept of 'die' – a Vital Breath torn from the flesh unable to find a healing pool: lost, and ripped to shreds in the ever-blowing wind.

"Did you die?" But this battle is beginning to tire me. I force myself to offer the man more words: "I do not know if he is still breathing, or if he has returned to the healing pools."

"We can look for him?"

I shrug.

"You will help me look for him? Please?"

"Is your need for revenge that desperate? I know he made you suffer badly – let him be, for a while at least, yes?"

"I don't understand ... I need him. I need to be with him."

I did not expect this answer. I can feel my eyes widen to show my surprise.

"I ... I love him ..."

I take a moment to reach into my net for another brelfruit, quickly sniffing it for threadworms before passing it to him. "Where did you meet him?"

He doesn't hesitate to bite into the fruit. "London," he says as the juices run down his chin. "It's a city ... in the place I come from."

"Tell me about 'city'."

"Cities?"

His confusion is written in the lines across his forehead. Yet I know what I'm doing. Many times a woman has confused me into confessing a thing simply by asking an unexpected question when my calls are elsewhere.

"Tell me ... please."

"They're places," he says, chewing as he talks. "Places where people live. Millions of people, all living together."

Again, I have the know of a word that had no meaning before passing from his lips. 'Million' – a thousand thousand steps, my Inner Voice tells me.

"They must cover the world," I say.

"No – we all live close together. Sam and I have – had – a flat together. Flats are like stone houses all stacked together into a tower," he adds, anticipating my next question. "Do you have stone houses here? I remember looking, but I never found anything. I never thought to look in the trees."

"I hold stories of stone houses. I have heard of a place where many stone houses are together in one place – but we never called that place a 'city'."

My words seem to rouse Marc-em-ay-are-see. He straightens his spine and leans towards me. "Maybe we can go there? Maybe that's where Sam has gone already. He never liked the countryside ..."

"Maybe," I agree, though I shake my head. Walking into the Great Caldera – no man has ever *walked* into that place. Carried, maybe, or dragged. Never *walked*. "But first you must gather your strength. Try a turtle fruit: I'll show you how to eat it."

## 9. The Search for Sam

One thing Luntas taught me was not to fear the hills. Most of my former gang brothers had no trust of the land beyond the shoreline; they would panic if they found themselves stranded alone in a place where they could not smell salt in the air. For them, such places were part of a woman's mysteries: not to be trusted. Men fished, and played, and prepared themselves for the Race. Women did – everything else.

Luntas taught me that the best fruits and nuts are to be found a good walk beyond the cliff walls. Water tastes freshest when taken from springs, not rain puddles. He also taught me that while women are dangerous, they are much the same as men in many ways – they have their pride and their shame, their skills and their needs. A clever man can survive well in the hills if he can gain the trust of the local clans.

These hills are as deserted as the shoreline.

Marc-em-ay-are-see is a fast learner. He doesn't ask questions incessantly, like his brother Sam; rather he watches, and copies. When he does ask a question, he listens to my words and then captures them on thin bark in a series of tattoo-ink loops and lines.

I reckon he also steals the essence of things in his ink marks. With a few quick lines and smudges he can capture a hill, or a worm, or a fruit, and fit it amid his squiggles ... they look so real, these 'sketches'; my jaw slackens in awe each time he performs that magic!

We could have followed the route that Sam and I had taken before, tracking the coastline downwind towards the longhouse on stilts overlooking the narrow bay. But since my Dream Sight revelation of Luntas and his lessons, I have grown curious. The guardian was clear to me: the men have gone elsewhere. Was the same true for women?

"Which leaves are best?"

The voice pulls me from my recalls. I can see he has dug a hole and performed his business. In his practical way he has collected a selection of leaves and spread them before him.

"To clean between the buttocks? The sculler leaf – it has three points, feels soft, yes? Use it quickly, folding it between wipes. The lighter side has a sap that will sting your fingers if you press too hard, so wrap them first in that longer blade – that's right: that one."

"And then bury them all?"

I nod, then turn away as he follows instructions. Marc-em-ay-are-see does not like to be stared at too long.

This vale is filled with trees, each competing with its neighbours to stretch its twigs closer to the sky. They offer us some welcome shade, and make a good home for a wealth of herbs and flowers, some reaching above my head. The tidiness of the place kept me wary at first: surely a woman had made it her garden – but this soil had not been tilled for a long while.

"Can I have the water, please?"

I turn to the man now standing by my side: "We've not long drunk water ..."

"I need to wash my hands."

I sigh and offer a glance to the cloud wisps scudding above the canopy: "Your *left* hand for wiping; your *right* for eating."

"Oh," he says. I hand over the water skin and return to my considerations.

My new gang brother is keen to go to the 'city' in the Great Caldera. He still reckons that we can get help there. I have a feeling that we may need to go there, but not yet. And I am certain that Sam will not have strayed far from the longhouse where he kissed me; I have a strong recall of our encounter with the flayman. That had scared Sam badly – why else seek comfort from a stranger? A scared brother rarely moves far from the longhouse.

"Shall we collect food here?"

"Mm?"

"Food. We didn't bring much with us."

The man makes a good point. I check the undergrowth around me, sniffing the air, but my nose offers no guidance. We are surrounded by herbs and grasses which, while useful in their own way, won't fill a belly by themselves. I let my eyes wander further, looking for signs of fern stands or clambering plants wrapped around trunks. I spot some sweetmoss hanging from a bough not too far downhill from us – it will give us a snack to keep the shakes from our limbs while we cross the shallow valley to the next hill.

~~~

"Tell me how you got here. You and Sam. How did you come to be in Fol Huun's healing pools?"

The peak on which we sit is easily the tallest between here and the sea which, thanks to the lack of trees, I can see. It seems to go on forever before colliding with the sky.

Marc-em-ay-are-see is fascinated by the view: "The horizon must be at least thirty kilometres. Are there other islands out there?"

"Kewid pro ko'," I reknow to him.

"Ah ... okay. It's all a bit messed up in my head, to be honest."

"We have time. We can give ourselves a thousand breaths here before looking for somewhere to sleep."

"And food ..."

"And food," I agree. "Give me the water, yes?"

He hands the water bag over to me without words, already lost in some puzzle of images. I take a moment to wipe the wooden spout glued into the leather before squeezing a trickle of liquid into my mouth. The container was a good find, discovered in a storm-blown glade not too far inland from the first. A tattoo that I recall to me winds slantwise across it: this skin's owner had belonged to a gang that had some repute in the Race.

"I know how I died. My uncle ... my ... he fucking shot me! I choked on my own blood! It was ... horrible! Worse than the choking after I got out of those rock pools."

"Fish breathe water," I agree. "Not men, once they are free of the bladders. Did you die and then wake here?"

"No ... no. There was a time in between. I remember floating away from my body, towards Sam ... and then Sam was with me ..."

"He told me he died."

"Did he? I asked him, but he wouldn't talk about it. I remember that I was ... at peace, complete. I would have been happy to fly away from that room, with Sam, forever. But Sam ... he was angry, man! There was something else – someone else? It wasn't my uncle, I'm sure of that. Sam was angry. He chased after the other one, dragged me with him – like he had a towing rope buried in me and I had no choice but to follow."

He reaches out to take the water bag from my hands, and lifts it to splash the warm liquid over his face.

"Don't waste it!"

"Sorry. I don't remember much else. Sam pulled me round his body and then ... into the Book? There was something in the Holy Book, in its spine; it scared the shit out of me, but he headed straight for it, after that thing ... and then I was here. Floating."

"In the healing pool ..."

Somewhere deep inside me, the story feels – right, good; as if I've solved a knot on my guts, a reckoning inside me of something needing to be done, now done.

"So what's the story with the healing pools? Every time I die, I'll go back to them and be reborn?"

"They are Fol Huun's gift, yes ..."

"Fucking marvellous! Immortality – I can really live forever!"

"We do not die – whatever 'dying' is. We exist for the Race."

The man seems to have lost interest in my words. His eyes have glazed in a kind of wonderment. I am concerned enough to check around our vantage for dangers: more than one kind of creature uses miasmas in the air to calm their prey.

"What was your world called?"

"Huh?"

"The world where you and Sam lived – what did you call it?"

"The world is ... The World. Or Earth. Planet Earth."

"Not Uekh, or ... Tintuun?"

"Maybe in another language. The French say 'Le Monde' – every language has a name for the planet. 'Terra' is another name. What did you say just now? The pools are someone's gift?"

"Fol Huun's gift."

"Fol ... I've heard that name! I remember it from somewhere – something my Uncle told me? It's hard to remember everything ... and my memories feel all jumbled up. Something about a lost stone?"

He has my full attention now. *'You'll need extra ears for this story,'* my Inner Voice tells me.

~~~

*'Once upon a time, God made a seed ...'*

The sky has dimmed somewhat, and the wind has cooled from its unnatural heat. Still, I cannot sleep. The words that Marc-em-ay-are-see has fed into my ears turn tumbles like waves, capping my swirling recalls in white foams.

There is a *book* – a stack of thin, dense-inked barks he told me – a *Holy Book* that sets out the true history of how God had come to His World



and filled it with wonder. Or, more accurately, there was a book, until his brother Sam set its barks to the flame.

Books are themselves wonder-filled things, I have learned, where the know of many men – and women – lies captured in lines and loops just like the ones Marc-em-ay-are-see has been making as we travel. When I asked him if he was going to capture me in his new book, the man had laughed and shown me a drawing of a face that he says is mine. That 'sketch' worries at me, though I don't feel any different: my fingers confirm that I still have my face on the front of my head.

The words tethered within the burned book could speak when they were looked at, and the story they told were all about the God's *seed* – a tool, of sorts – which gives the man that holds it great powers to rule other men and women, even the wind and the storm.

These words make no sense. Why would a man want to rule a woman? Perhaps to stop her chewing on his muscles while he still breathed, or to make her give him good medicines or fine clothes ... but such a thing is a lie: women are too severe to be ruled.

Marc-em-ay-are-see has no idea what his story has done to me. He lies on the other side of this grove's hearth stone and snores. I probably pushed him too far on this first stage of our search; his body is still mending itself, even though he seems happy with it: *'the body of a fit teenager, and the mind of a full-grown man – I can't wait to find Sam!'*

He told me that the book had been guarded for many *years* by a gang whose brothers were the best men in their world. Their job was to search for the God's seed, which had been stolen by *demons*. They had invisible creatures – *angels* – to help them track down these equally invisible demons who lived in the heads of unsuspecting men. For only when the seed had been reunited with the book could it sprout and grow and fruit as God's *Final Plan* for the world.

I do not understand it when something is both true and false. Maak's addle-skulled story feels true in my gut, and yet my eyes and ears and nose and fingers clearly show the falseness of his words. This is the battle which sets my skull-words to foaming.

"So what part does Fol Huun play in this story," I had asked.

"Why do you call the rock pools 'Fol Huun's gift'? Quid pro quo."

"They are Her way of restoring a man's Vital Breath to the flesh."

"So that's how new people are regenerated – when somebody dies they reincarnate in a new body?"

"Only men." I catch his next question in his eyes: "I don't know where women go to be healed. They have more secrets than trees in these valleys, and a clever man knows not to ask the wrong questions."

"But Fol Hoon ... you speak as if it – she – is a real person."

"She is not a man, nor a woman. Not even a guardian – a great gull – though sometimes She will take the form of one."

"So she's God?"

"She is ..." I look around me and spread my arms wide. "She is *everything!*"

"Even you?"

His question made my forehead hurt, the way it scrunched skin across brow. "Kewid pro ko!"

He had smiled at that – the first smile he had offered me since I hauled his hairless flesh from the healing pool.

"My uncle told me something – a thing not written in the Book. He had set me a task of looking for God's seed and, for a while, we thought that Sam's family might know where it was. He said that while the Book has much to say about the seed, it never describes what it actually looks like. When I asked him why not, he said it would look different to whoever saw it: maybe a ring, or a brooch, or a statue – it could even look like a teapot or a watch. But whatever form it took, it always had seven different coloured stones in it. Always the same stones, in the same sequence. He said that the stones had secret names that could never be spoken out loud – except for

one of them: Fol Huun – the missing stone. Because originally there had been eight stones in the seed ..."

I roll over onto my side, facing away from the hearth stone, wishing my Inner Voice to stop its chatter so I can sleep. It refuses to heed my ask. It keeps telling me: *'the story is wrong; the seed had nine stones, not eight ...'*

~~~

I do not like walking along the avenues. As the flayman had shown, avenues collect dangers like a dip in the sand collects brine water.

This avenue, I am sure, is the one that will take us out of the hills to the longhouse where Sam kissed me. When I had shared this news with Marc-em-ay-are-see he became very excited; he, too, has come to believe that Sam would most likely stay near the place where we had parted on such – unusual – terms.

Not that I've shared that particular detail with him. All I have said of the matter was that I slipped while looking for food and tinder.

I don't like the idea of meeting brother Sam again. I have a feeling that he will not enjoy our reunion. I have spent a quiet while scraping my new-stolen knives to a keen edge: if there is to be trouble, it will not be my Vital Breath heading back to the healing pools.

Sam's reaction to seeing Marc-em-ay-are-see will be ... interesting ... I reckon.

~~~

"SAM!"

The longhouse has seen some changes since I left it by the wrong exit. There's holes in the roof, for a start; a scattering of blackened thatch around the hearth stone suggests that Sam has been using the great dried leaves to keep the fire burning – for a while at least; the ashes that drift through my fingers are cold. Some of the soot has been used to mark 'words' across the floor of the house: I watched Marc-em-ay-are-see's face become worried as his Inner Voice turned them back into sounds.

"Shouting won't work," I say. "We should have hunted him."

"He's got to be somewhere near!"

"He watched you leave your flesh, you recall? To him, that was your *death*. He was going to bury your body in the sands; I had to persuade him to carry it up the cliffs so we could burn it."

"And eat it?"

I don't understand why these men are so disgusted by the consumption of old flesh. I still haven't told him where the leather for our bags came from.

"Women eat man-flesh, mostly. He will recall burning you; he was firm in his bones that you would never return."

"Maybe he saw us coming down that track ..."

"... or heard you. I told you not to scream his name. Names are too important to be uttered so carelessly ..."

"Hah. So that's why you told me to call you 'savage'. Makes sense now. And you're sure he's alive ... you're not just saying that?"

I point over to the corner furthest from the ladder and closest to the hillside. "That daffask root has fresh teeth marks in it; he was here no more than 500 breaths past."

The man looks inwards as he counts: "Half an hour ago, maybe 45 minutes. Is that thing safe to eat?"

"It's bitter, but it fills the belly. He should have boiled it to a mush and drunk the broth, maybe with poached fish and ..."

"It won't have sent him to the healing pools."

"No," I agree. "Though you need to be desperate to try and eat such a thing raw."

Marc-em-ay-are-see offers me a queer look as he returns to the ladder.

"What do the *words* say?"

"He was trying to keep a diary, but he didn't keep it up for very long."

The explanation doesn't help me. 'Diary' – the word sounds a bit like 'die' which, I've come to understand, is an act of *death*, or *kill*. I walk over to the seaward side of the long house – avoiding the space where Sam and I had fought – and scan the small bay and the littoral across the water.

"He thinks he murdered you."

'Think' is skull-speak? Reckon?

"Is that a bad thing?" I can see movements along the shore: birds mainly, but possibly rabbits too? It will not take me long to gather the materials to make a snare ...

"It's bad for him. Some of the rougher writing seems to be about demons ... I never knew he could write shorthand."

"Bad enough to make him eat daffask root?"

The man takes a moment to stare at me over his shoulder. "Bad in his head ... I'm really worried for him."

"We should have hunted him," I say. "The healing pools can fix more than a man's flesh."

~~~

By mutual agreement, we have both moved around the bay to the place of rabbits so I can set traps. It will be good to taste a roast of meat after our meagre diet of moss and fruits.

In the absence of men, the rabbits have grown both in size and in numbers. They haven't, however, lost their senses of smell and hearing so we were unable to catch them unawares.

I've made Marc-em-ay-are-see a good spear with a sharp stone tip, far better than the weapon he used to help separate his Vital Breath from his flesh when he and Sam were camped on their beach. He told me he has some

skill with 'javelins' – whatever they may be – so I've set him to be lookout, stood atop a rock that pushes into the water.

My traps are simple nooses looped around the rabbit holes and staked securely at one side. They will not be pleasant for the rabbits, but will hopefully hold them long enough for me to reach and dispatch them with my knife. There are so many of them here that it is difficult to choose the best holes to snare; their tracks are a mass of confusions.

Brother Sam, too, has left a number of tracks around the longhouse. Few of them seem to lead round to this side of the bay. Mostly, he seems to stick to the shoreline nearest the long house, with some longer journeys to the head of the bay and the Processional avenue beyond it. I had spotted the rotted remains of a breifruit bush near to his tracks when we first approached the longhouse. Brother Luntas would not have had good words to offer if he had seen the mess Sam had made when he tried to harvest them.

Sam has made many messes. I was alone when I found the remains of my bones, stacked in a pile beyond the reach of the water, my skull between my feet. I felt nothing when I threw them into the bay. I could have left them, I suppose: the bone worms had already hollowed the longer shafts in preparation for their final work. But bones would lead to questions; better to let the crabs finish the job.

I am setting my last trap when I hear branches crack. I glance towards Marc-em-ay-are-see, and see a gaunt shape of mad intent rushing towards him.

My sentry is more interested in watching me!

"Landwards!"

But it is not my shout that makes him turn.

"You're dead! Dead! Get away from me!"

Sam throws something – a rock – at his brother ... who doesn't even bother to duck!

"Use the spear! Throw the japeless spear!"

I watch as he lets the spear clatter out of his hands.

"Sam! It's me, Sam. Marc!"

Sam is not interested in listening. He barely broke step when he threw the rock. With nothing left in his hands, he chooses to throw himself at his brother. I watch them both topple as I sprint across pebbles.

They splash together into the water, Sam's arms wrapped around Marc's hips. And Sam is the first to surface. He may be famished, but his rage makes him quick. As soon as he has disentangled his arms, he pushes them straight down into the water. He screams as loud as the flayman when I took my knife to its neck!

He doesn't notice my approach. When I reach the sentry rock I drop my knife and net and dive in, trusting that the water will be deep enough to receive my body.

It is: my Dream Sight does not fail me. I angle my body into a curve even as I descend: my run has taken me past the men and I must turn quickly.

In two strokes I pull alongside the men fighting on the submerged bank of pebbles. Without call my hand scrabbles for a rock that fits smoothly in its grip.

I stretch up and smash my fist into the back of Sam's head, thrust him to one side as he starts his collapse. Marc-em-ay-are-see resurfaces in a fit of coughs; I offer him my arms as he struggles to find his feet.

His fist is swift into my face – a full punch. A full betrayal!

~~~

*~ Your nestlings do not like each other.*

I feel no need to reply to this comment. I am too busy trying to tease my Dream Sight for clues on how to skin and dress rabbits.

Across the bay, Marc-em-ay-are-see has tied brother Sam to one of the struts that hoists the longhouse into the sky. Sam sits, bound and screaming, not far from where he had stacked my bones. My gang brother

has not asked for my help in this, and I had not offered it; I'm keeping my words to myself.

*~ The shorter one makes noises that interest the crabs.*

*~ The crabs can have them both!*

The guardian perches on the lookout rock. It has been here for a while, preening feathers and watching my work. For once, it is more talkative than me.

The longer that I stare at the bloody carcass in my hands, the less I recall about what I am supposed to do with it. Making the snares had been easy by comparison: I had let my hands do my reckoning for me. They had the know of knots and shapes that created and tethered the noose while I had concentrated my ears and nose on sensing any approaching danger.

Not that I can smell now. It took a while for the blood to stop dripping from its broken shape after Marc-em-ay-are-see had flattened it with his fist. I was too busy swearing to watch him drag Sam's collapsed body through the water back to the longhouse.

*~ The crabs thank you for your bones. What is this new thing in your talons? I do not know it.*

I look up at the gull, surprised. Freed from my supervision my hands cut across the rabbit's belly, feel their way between skin and muscle, and rip the fur halves free in a single, even pull.

*~ Guardians know everything!*

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak-ak!"

I have no idea what the gull's cry means, but the look in its eye recalls to me laughter. My hands take my surprise as an opportunity to decapitate the head and paws from my prey and slice into its belly, spilling entrails over my foot.

*~ You have to know everything!*

*~ What is this new thing in your talons?*



I resort to using my Outer Voice, un-knowing my determination to keep my tongue still.

"They're rabbits. You know this!"

*~ I do not know of rabbits, nor do I recall them. I shall not help them.*

"You don't need to help them." I take a slime of guts in my fingers and throw them towards the bird. "You can eat them."

The guardian stretches its wings wide, then folds them again when the offal falls short of spattering its grey-white plumage. The look it gives me now is hard, questioning. It cocks its head as if weighing options. Within three heartbeats it hops from its perch onto the pebbles and angles its beak deep into the entrails.

Across the bay, Maak-em-ay-are-see is trying to tempt his brother with water. Sam sees the tattoos across the bag and screams louder: "Get away from me, you fucking zombie!"

*~ This offering is hot. She does not permit me to feast on hot flesh.*

"Gulls eat all that fits in their beaks. I recall this thing."

*~ I call to her; She does not answer.*

"You mean the other guardian? The one that was with you when you reknoved me of my brother Luntas?"

*~ That one – no: she also is new. I do not understand her. It is the Great Albatross who does not answer me.*

The guardian speaks of Fol Huun. I know this. The women often called Her *'the Great Albatross who stretches her wings between worlds,'* though never within the range of a man's ears. I have met few men who are brave enough to spy on a clan gathering, where women meet to sing and cast their spells. Luntas was one such man; Geit another. And me.

*~ Do you talk to my gang brothers – the fledglings, I mean?*

The guardian makes a decision, grasps at a loop of offal and flaps back to its rock, trailing the bloody string behind it.

*~ I do not recall them. I shall not help them.*

"You recall me."

*~ I recall you, Kal of Tintuun. You I shall help.*

"What is a 'tin-toon'?"

The gull is huge; its beak is the length of my hand and, by the way it rips so easily through the rabbit's guts, far sharper than my poor glass knife.

*~ This is better than snail, or fish. The heat feels good in my gizzard. You must go and save your fledgling from the crabs.*

"The crabs can have them! They are not my gang brothers."

The guardian is staring out to sea. "Ak! Ak! Ak-ak-ak!" From beyond the bay's entrance, something answers.

*~ There is another nestling, still in its egg. Downwind beyond the smoky cliffs on a long stretch of wing. The crabs grow impatient with it. Leave the rabbit here.*

~~~

"How did you stop your brother's shouts?"

Four rabbits lie to one side of us in a bloody pile; for my own safety, I've told Marc-em-ay-are-see to stay on the other side of the hearth stone. He carries a stunned look in his face, as if it was I who had punched him.

He shrugs at my question. "He'll start again when he sees me."

"We should have hunted him."

"... kill him?"

"Release him back to the healing pool."

The man shakes his head: "I can't ... this isn't the way it's supposed to be!"

I have no time for worries. I reach into my net and pull out the fire pot – all women kept a stash of these magic contraptions hidden in their glades, sealed from dampness and rain by clay and beeswax. I have no idea why they work, just how: drag the stick across the rough clay and a flame erupts from it. This fire pot is almost done; only two sticks remain.

It is a moment's work to set a flame within the tinder stacked on the hearth stone. "You cannot let this fire wither," I tell the man. "I don't know when I shall return."

"Why do you have to go?"

"There are things I have to do. You've watched me hunt and gather – you've near-captured me in your bark work. You probably won't starve."

"What things?"

I sigh. I have no desire to share the guardian's news with him. "You have what you want. Deal with it."

"I don't want Sam like ... like this!"

"Then pull a knife across his throat. Or smother his face with your hand. Or take a rock to his skull. Or drag him to the cliffs and drop him over. Burn him. Give him fruit laden with fretworms. Crush dagger berries between his teeth. Go look for a spear snail and set it on his skin. Or ... or just wait for the crabs to tire of his screams and let them snip him to shreds! Once he returns, his senses will be secure in his head again, and doubt will have been banished by experience!"

I don't realise how angry I am until I see it set in the shock of his eyes. I turn away to feed twigs to the new fire. "There are things I need to do!"

I take the man's silence as consent. Already I've slipped the fire pot back into the net tied around my waist.

10. Chick

Here is a rock I know. It stands proud above the shoreline, like a miniature version of Fol Huun's lodestone spire. Downwind lie the littorals and pools of my gang – my real gang. This outcrop marks the upwind limit of our strand.

I hadn't recalled the landmark when I first saw it because I was approaching it from the wrong direction. The hinterland of my gang's land is made up of a jumble of hills and ravines – a difficult terrain to walk, but the cliffs here are generally low and the beaches wide. We used to do a good trade with other gangs, and the women, in bladderwracks and kelps, and many flatfishes make this place their roost.

But the strand upwind of ours was not permitted to our feet: dangerous creatures buried themselves in those sands, and the rocks of the hills were too sharp and loose for women to tend. Other whispers, too, kept us away from the area: murmurs of curses and addles that walked amid the japing fogs that rose from the hill-screes and lingered around the stunted, twisted trees.

Only when I drew close to the spire, and recalled it to me, did the shock of realisation smack through my limbs – was I the first to walk the length of the forbidden shore, and survive?

~ You must rest.

My guardian was waiting for me to arrive. Now it perches no more than two feet from where I crouch at the base of the spire.

~ The crabs know you are here. They will forbear.

My journey has taken so long, I have almost un-called my purpose.

"The man is still in his healing pool?"

~ I do not recall him. I do not know him. He is new to me. You will help him.

"How many men – people – are left?"

"Ak!"

It is no use asking a guardian to count things. Vuanna, she of the stolen boots, had told me this.

I close my eyes and try to coax a particular Dream Sight into my head.

'Why do you say this thing?' I recall asking her. 'Guardians do not talk.'

'Not to you maybe, little Kal. Not yet. But when they do talk to you, inside your head, recall to yourself that they cannot count things.'

I open my eyes and look downwind. The shoreline here is low and flat, curving gently to form a wide bay. This was a good place for building feast fires – and beyond the feast-times a place where a few of us could gather, away from the judgmental eyes clustered in the longhouse. Women, too, could come here and join us around the fires. Each of us would bring gifts to be shared among us all, and all would leave their weapons stacked here by the spire: it was a safe place for those who knew how to barter comforts.

~ Your other nestlings still breathe. The short one makes much water from his eyes. The tall one cares for him. Feeds him rabbit. This news shall help you rest.

In my eyes I can see a vision of the fires dotted across the sands. It was our duty to light them, tend them, as we gathered the seaweeds washed up on the low humps of sand. The work was not popular; most were glad to see us leave the longhouse for a few sleeps. Jiar would come with me, and Leic, when he was not competing to be our leader. Geit would often come here on his own.

~ There is no rabbit here.

Vuanna was a frequent visitor to this place, my Inner Voice reknows to me. She kept a glade not far from here, a couple of thousand paces landwards over the rough terrain.

"Come," I say to the gull. "I know of a safer place than this spot."

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak!"

"There might be rabbit there."

~~~

For this approach I use a long stem of stoutcane, sweeping and pressing it ahead of me as I test each step along the path to Vuanna's glade. My wariness is justified when I prod the dirt ahead of me, only to see the track collapse into a well-concealed – and very deep – hole. When I check it, I can see sharp cane slivers set upright between a jumble of loose rocks: a careless man would have a choice of agonies in that pit.

Not that I believe Vuanna built the trap for the likes of me. She had a good understanding of the place where she lived, and the trap is close to the borders of the forbidden area.

This stoutcane garden is a maze of turns and spins and – literally – bad ends, grown by the woman to guard the entire upwind side of her glade. Now that I am lost in it, I realise I should have walked a thousand paces further downwind along the shore before heading landwards: the paths are much simpler, and safer, to navigate from that direction.

But here I am.

I ask the gull: "Can you see a way out of here?"

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak!" The response comes from some distance above me. I take a moment to locate my companion, check the set of its wings to gauge the wind's direction – the breeze at my level is as confused as me in this never-ending copse of reeds and canes.

I take a guess that my *left* shoulder is landwards and my face is looking downwind. My Dream Sight maps Vuanna's glade being near the top of a rise – possibly that broken hill that has the outline of a man asleep on his side?

The reed hedge that blocks me is impenetrable: I take out my glass knife and hack my own slim path through its stem walls. One step follows another, and another. The lash of a stem unwilling to be severed slashes at my arm – a thin stitch of blood marks the blow. Other cuts follow, over thigh and brow: I refuse to retreat!

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak!"

I don't notice that the reeds end until after I tumble onto a wide, gravelled path. It is a good path, I realise, as I rest my cheek against the small pebbles. Vuanna had taken great pride in this path, its churns of coloured stones twisted into patterns and images the likes of which I had never netted a glimpse of before. She had been especially welcoming the time when she had shown me this work, proud and forbearing in the new cloak her efforts had won – a sisterly gift of subtle manskins.

Seeing it now, it reminds me of one of Maak-em-ay-are-see's barks, though with far more colour than their black ink lines.

I let the air seep in and out of my lungs. I feel a conflict of hurry to hide myself, so close to Vuanna's place, and yet no hurry while the sweat of my labour runs so freely from my skin.

Only as I refocus my gaze from the rubble of grits by my nose do I notice it.

The rabbit is still, barely an arm's length from where I have landed, yet not scared; the play of light across its furred flanks show no quickness of breath. When I reach out my arm towards it, it refuses to flinch.

We share a stare, eye into sidelong eye. And then it hops to my fingers, wrinkles its nose over their tips, blinks and jumps away towards the new-hacked passage through sharp grasses. The twitch of its white tail is almost friendly as it disappears past my knees.

~~~

I always liked Vuanna's roost; I can recall its details too clearly for my own good health, or sanity. Because of its placement, the woman had felt no need to build it high in the branches of a tree, instead training a set of saplings and hedge-briars to form its beams and walls.

The ache of her absence burns in my chest!

~ Why do you make water from your eyes?

I shake my head. I do not understand the wanton heaves within my flesh.

"Do guardians never weep?"

~ Brine seeps across my beak, at times. It is a function of me. I know this.

"This place – it shouldn't be like this! The woman who makes – made – it her nest ... she would have ripped out her eyes rather than let them catch sight of such mess!"

The walls have indeed grown rampant, forming a broad mat across the baked floor and softening the lines of its entrance. Weeds grow from pots dangled from arches.

~ The one who lived here, she plucked me, once. It was – not unpleasant to have the old plumes eased from my wings. She kept a good stock of fish to help me endure my time beneath the wind.

"You knew her?"

"Ak!"

"She plucked you?"

I cannot convince my Inner Voice to believe such a claim. All guardians are to be feared, of course, but this one has a head that reaches easily above my hips and wings that could break my back. Even the claws at the end of its skin-flapped feet make me reckon more of talons: hard and sharp and black.

I need to sleep. The sky is entering one of its dimmer phases, fuzzing shadows into backgrounds. But eating is important, too, and there is no store of food to be found within the hedges of this grove. The fruits and roots I had carried in my bags when I set out on this journey gave their last worth to me as I walked along the edges of the forbidden shore; my stomach rumbles in a grief of unshaped loss.

As do my eyes, I realise. Though they no longer ooze water, they ache still – a hot pain bridging behind my knuckled nose.

"We need food," my Outer Voice says.

~ She is not gone. She is with the many, in the cliffs above the sky. They wait for the world to hatch. I know this.

Sometimes the words of my guardian defeat me. "Vuanna kept a good garden of fruits, not far downwind of here."

~ Will there be snails? Grubs? Rabbits? The egg you seek is near-addled. You must crack its shell soon!

~~~

Gang brothers battle between my ears, each calling for my attention as my many Dream Sights of this place storm through my head. So often I have sat here, on the lip of this low cliff, under the leaves of this tree, or that one, as I waited for friends – or enemies – to return.

The trees around me have changed; the healing pools are as they have ever been – a slope of rock pools, each of a similar size though none of a similar nature, pushing outwards on their tongue of bedrock separating the sands and muds of the bay's littoral into two uneven halves. Waves still crash at the base of the rocky stacks that mark the furthest extent of the pools. My guardian hunts there now, excited by the riches his beak uncovers.

I rub a cream from a pot stolen from Vuanna's roost into my new wounds. I have no idea whether the cream will help staunch the blood; it smelt herby, which is enough for me to trust in the woman's magic.

The – thing – beside me ... well, it has good lungs in its tiny chest for certain! From the moment I pulled it free of its bladders, far out by the tallest stack, it has wailed. Nothing I do will stop its screams!

*~ The chick hungers, the guardian tells me.*

I've offered it brelfruit, but it refuses to hold the food in its tiny, malformed hands. It refuses to stand, or even sit! Currently it lies on its back by the tree where I put it, and screams! And such a noise! A sound to pierce through my skull and scatter the brothers who witter and jape in my Dream Sight. Utterly unknown, and new ... and yet some part of me, deep in

my guts, knows this noise. It is an effort for me to force my limbs to keep still, to stop myself stepping back to pick it up and hold it close in my arms.

~ *It won't eat*, I tell the guardian.

My wounds are from the crabs. So keen they were to rid the pools of this thing, they set to their snipping in a frenzy, making no distinction between the bladders and my skin. Yet they left no mark on the thing's hide – maybe the tattoo marks across its body protected it?

I've never known a gang brother to emerge from the healing pool with his tattoos already in place. The tattooing ceremony comes later, at the end of the welcome feast, and is – was – a joyous occasion, with much beer and many japes. Yet my thing, my new 'brother', has darkness scrawled over every pore of its skin, missing only from its bright red palms and soles, and ever-open lips and untoothed gums.

I should not criticise the colour of its skin. Too often have my gang brothers mocked me for my fish-pink tones. Brothers can be monsters, too.

Geit, I recall, had also suffered the jibes – though his skin was darker. One time our brothers had bound us together tightly, Geit's manspear in my shit nest, and thrown us from the cliffs. Someone had claimed that maybe when we returned our skins would have mixed to the proper colour.

It didn't work.

It was after that event that I stopped hating Geit. When we emerged from the pools we discovered we shared a new purpose. Together we took the brother who made the suggestion, and fed him to a flayman that Luntas was keeping as a pet, up in the hills. The reek of the creature was terrible, but Geit insisted we kept the man's head free of the flaps as his flesh melted from his bones.

Luntas, an image recalls, had light skin, though not as sick-seeming as mine. Maybe that was why he spent so much of his time alone in the hills? Vuanna's skin was darker than normal. Could that be why she lived so close to the forbidden place? Her stitch work was never as good as that of her clan sisters ...

"Will that noise never stop!?"

*~ The chick hungers. Have you not fed it?*

The guardian lands on the cliff closer to the thing than to me. "It will not eat!" I tell it again.

*~ It is a chick. Chicks feed on vomit. I know this.*

I watch as the gull skip-jumps past the abandoned fruit and halts by the screaming thing's side. The investigation is swift, yet surprisingly gently – a miniature wrist lifted into its great beak and prodded by a white, wormy tongue; a ruffle of wing feathers over its oversized head. Another lung-wail stops abruptly when the gull pokes its beak into the thing's mouth, deep into its throat. The smell of half-digested fish overwhelms me as the bird shares its last meal in the only way it knows how.

~~~

For lack of a better name, I have started to call the thing 'Chick'.

If Chick has a real name, he has chosen not to share it with me. This is his privilege: names are too important to be shared with strangers. And Chick is definitely a 'he', whatever else he may be – slim and long, his manspear dangles over the puckered miniature pouch filling the space between the crack of his thighs. Twice now he has let loose his waters as I rocked him in my arms – not that I care: he likes to be held, and the movement keeps him quiet.

Yet I have other work to attend to. The guardian, currently stretching his wings over the waves and beyond my sight, insists that I need to rejoin my other new brothers back upwind. And while I'm not one to defy a guardian, I am lost as to how to make that rough journey. I'll have to carry Chick all the way beyond the forbidden place with its treacherous rocks and fumes.

I reckon my little brother is incapable of making a single step; he is certainly incapable of controlling his bowels!

So ... I need to build some sort of *sled*?

I have never seen a 'sled' – I have never even heard that word until just now – but I know of this contraption. My Inner Voice suddenly devises some sounds and the image of a 'sled', all handles and woven platform and

ropes for the shoulder harness, appears in my recalls! Like 'thunder', or 'father' – so many strange ideas bubbling from my head like blisters on the skin when I once left my hand too long in a fire.

Looking around, I can see that I have all the material I need to construct such a thing. The poles, the ropes – I am surrounded by the remnants of my gang's longhouse. It must have torn itself apart in some gale and now it lies in a long line above the edge of the waves in heaps and tatters.

I look down at my little brother, see his eyes are closed. Gently I lay him down on the sand beside me and stand to my new task. If I keep busy then maybe my calls will sleep also. Holding Chick has made me wonder if I was ever as tiny as this? An impossible image, of course, but one that feels strangely – right? Good? – in the knot of my guts.

Tiny, and alone, and cold ... so, so stupidly cold!

~~~

The sled is half-built when I realise something watches me.

I look around for the guardian, but the gull is far from sight. Chick still sleeps beneath the rough shelter I had built over him. And the watcher is further inland, some distance away – I have no idea why, but of this I am utterly sure.

Could it be a gang brother? A clan woman? There is no prickle at the nape of my neck to suggest such a thing. Rather, this feeling comes from my legs and my belly, a hot shiver of awareness skipping the length of my bones – should I run? Hide?

No. This needs hunting.

Whenever Chick sleeps, I have been busy fashioning tools and weaving nets. Wherever my gang brothers have gone, they left little useful to me behind. Not that their weapons would have satisfied me: mostly they fashioned nets from kelp; their spears and knives were assembled from wood and bone. All good tools were made by womanly arts, and anyway I have always preferred flint to bone or glass.

None of my brothers knew the art of knapping, and my abilities to draw thin flakes from the knobbly stones storm-washed onto the beach had never really interested them – they whispered, so Geit told me once, that it was something I was taught in the High Domains, thus not to be trusted.

I have three good blades now, of varying length, each bound tight into wooden handles; an axe and two scrapers; and plenty of flakes fixed to the tips of several well-balanced spears, their angles suited more for fishing than throwing – but they will do.

This bay sits mainly between two large hills, their lowest slopes cleared of trees long before my first arrival here. Whatever watches me is not hidden in the scrubs and saplings between the woods and the low cliffs. It must be hidden near the top one of the hills – the closer one, I guess – if it is able to spy on me clearly.

I take a moment to move Chick into the deeper shade of a large thornbush – good for making tattoo needles – and cover him to his chin with soft bark. Then I gather my weapons of choice, a short spear, my mid-length knife, and start my hunt.

I pretend for this exercise that I am raiding Vuanna's glade. Her home is on the other side of the closer hill, so the first part of the raid is always an easy walk along the foot-cleared paths that criss-cross this valley, a diversion here, a brief investigation there – just a man on the scavenge for herbs and grubs.

The land here is not smooth. Rocks of all sizes jag through the covering soils and in some places a more solid surface of rock breaches into the air. Here we could gather rainwater trapped in puddles, places where no person was permitted to piss or shit.

My Dream Sight shows me a hole, near one of the smaller puddles, that worms downwards through rock to open into a larger cavern. The image triggers a recall: it would be useful to gather an additional protection before I continue my hunt.

My Dream Sight speaks truth; it takes me a hundred breaths or so to discover the place again.

The hole is an entrance – a small, thin stab in the land that at times would belch a throat-closing mist; a place that my gang brothers avoided, but which I could sit next to when the need to be alone with my Inner Voice overwhelmed me.

The slit itself opened up to a wider space, I recall, less than a man's length from its entrance. Soft powders, yellow under the sky, plastered the rock surfaces; women would trade much for that powder – though not Vuanna, who had her own supplies. So often had I come here to harvest the foul crystals that I had worn the floor of the passage smooth. Though I could never stay too long; the vapours would soon set my head spinning and twist my Dream Sight to flashes of loss and hurt and hatred that were impossible to endure.

Such is the price of respect.

A reek of the island's farts permeates the space I wriggle into. I struggle to worm my way forwards and downwards through blackness until I reach the turning space, as if I have become larger since my last visit here. When my hand lands on a curve of bone and tooth I reknow to myself to make haste, not to breathe the air of this space however much my chest may ache for expanse.

Sometimes my adventures underground would lead to water, not sky.

Another struggle, this time upwards – the crack of bright lightness ahead of me a beacon to my eyes and limbs. Now I allow my lungs their relief: slow, small gasps to limit the dizziness and forever-taste of rot. As much as my mouth and throat complain of the stench in which I have powdered my flesh, it will not match the disgust any watcher on the hill will feel should it try to consume me.

The tunnel tightens around me as I squirm towards its mouth, as if the cave's vapours have further inflated my flesh. With my arms outstretched ahead of me I lever my shoulders against rock and toe-push my way through the constriction. I have to blow all air from my lungs and almost dislocate my arms before I get to feel the welcome brush of thorns against my scalp.

And ... freedom! As soon as my hips leave the hole's mouth I crawl to the nearby pool and dunk my head entire into its warm waters.

If something still watches me, I can't feel its gaze on my skin. I give myself a hundred breaths or so to rest by the pool, check my knife for sharpness. There's a stillness in the air, as if the sky, too, holds its breath, waiting to see what I will do next.

I choose to crab-scuttle – fingers and toes – along the most direct paths to the hill's foot. The scrub grows more wildly in this part of the gang land, and the paths have not been knocked back for an age, which leaves me many twig-arched tunnels to choose from as I weave myself between the bushes. I pretend I am the flayman, keen on the scent of flesh.

There are other monsters in the woods; I have no doubt that wherever my brothers have gone, they will have left those beasts behind. The ones that particularly like manflesh – bryesnatchers, a pack of caddiwhips, a roil-mouthed tullerscup – the clever ones ... it would not surprise me to find their like somewhere amid the hillside trees. Such recalls do not pause me, nor does the ache that builds in my thighs and arms as I scuttle and twist towards my destination with a spear strapped to my back and my knife secure in its loop of my vine-wound belt.

As the land starts to incline, as the underbrush softens to patches of grass and herb and bracken, I slow my pace, lift to a crouch and free my fingertips from their canter across the rubbled soils. A quick check reassures me that the pains I feel in my hands are the result of strains, not cuts. I raise my head, see the flares of a buttressed middertree not too far ahead of me, and dash for its assumed safety where I can let my breath catch up with my lungs.

So what thing watches me? What must I find and fight?

Bryesnatchers, like flaymen, don't much like each other. If there is a bryesnatcher somewhere on this hill, then it will be hidden on a low bough, ready to hook my flesh with its long-curved claws, or drop its bulk on me. Caddiwhips, too, have claws, but they are much smaller and prefer the ground. A single caddiwhip can be tackled with a knife, but they are like men in their joy of company and I will not be able to fight a pack of them.

They sing to each other, I recall, a pitch of melodies sometimes loud, sometimes quiet, but always one of the pack will be singing, directing the others in their joint endeavour. They're fast as well, and better climbers than the bryesnatcher should their prey take to the trees – but I can outrun them. I recall this to me.

I lean into the curve of the trunk behind me, let my breath calm to its normal counting pace. It's not a bulky old clawdropper or a gang of warbling rats I fear, I realise. The beast that holds my dread is the tullerscup, that tangle of armoured, many-legged worms that can come together into whatever shape they choose and move as a single body, swift and sinuous through trees or across ground – or even burrowing beneath the leaf-litter. They have no scent, nor sound, and can break so suddenly over a man that he will not know what has happened to him until his gang brothers pull him once more from the healing pool, laughing at his stupidity for wandering alone in the woods.

One last deep, slow breath, then I start my climb. The hill is thick with trees: saplings for the most part, already overstretched in their search for a break in the leafy roof above. The youngest ones whip at my skin as I shove past them; others I have to swerve around, their stems already too thick with barks to bend at my passage. The big trees have been tended at some point, each six forming a rough circle so that at any point I have broad avenues to run along.

I keep low as I run, hunching down every twenty paces to ease my breath and scope out my surroundings. After each brief pause I set off in a different direction, partly to avoid the steepest climbs but mainly to make it more difficult for whatever watches me to follow my progress. The rhythm of the run soon silences my Inner Voice: I become my ears and my eyes, my broken nose and toes: quiet, lithe; still and fluid.

The rocks of the hill cause me no pause – most are layered in dead leaves, mosses, worm-scrambled muds. I let my legs piston over their outcrops, relax as I spring and dart ever upwards.

Just beyond the midway point I spot a break in the pattern, a clearing of sorts where one great trunk has been hewn by men's hands, and another has half-fallen downhill, caught mid-tumble by the great boughs of its



downwind neighbours. I recall this place – we harvested that missing tree ourselves: it became the last canoe I worked on.

My feet recall to me that its half-collapsed neighbour is to be avoided: a blisterbark, rarely found so close to the sea. I refuse the invitation to scramble along its length to get a better view of my surroundings. Instead I dart uphill to make my way around the nest of its roots ...

I see flame ...

No ... not flame. I see a man crouched within the roots, his hair long and wild and the colours of fire ...

"No. NO!"

This is not possible. That man is dead. I know he is dead!

I killed him!

I crept upon him as he struggled in the sucking mud pit and I put my little flint to his throat and pushed and sawed at his neck until blood sprung from ruptured tubes to arc through the air in gouts ...

The man with the bright *orange* hair.

The man who killed my *father* ...

... who gutted my *mother*!

I'm surprised to find a knife in my hand , as if it leaped to my fingers by magic. I am astonished by the surge of coldness that erupts from my guts and splashes like waterfalls the length of my legs, my spine and shoulders and arms.

So cold! Am I growling?

I growl at the *bastard* form before me, bare my teeth like the *dog* I once was ...

This man must stay dead!

I watch him straighten from his crouch moments before I leap at him. Tall he is, so tall! And I am so small, seven *summers* to my face and yet I rage!

My legs have sprung me from my own low crouch before I even realise what is happening ...

"DIE! Die again ..."

My arm swing at his face, flint talons hard-grasped in my hand.

"Die and stay DEAD!"

Water erupts from my screwed eyes. Still I swing my knife at his face ... but I cannot reach him! Why? Why can't I reach him?

Why won't he die?

Salt on my tongue; a swell of heat in my throat – something is wrong here. What is wrong?

Why is there a pole sprouting from my chest?

The pole is a wonder of patterns, mosses etching the cracks in the bark. I want to wrap my palms around it, stroke fingers along its length ... but the stone in my hand won't let me: so tight I grasp that rock. Why?

My ears bang so loud – a set of slowing thumps from the sides of my skull ... *why?* says each beat. *Why?*

I cannot voice the question; I cannot take in breath. I can barely lift my head but, somehow in a moment that lasts forever, I force my chin forwards to seek for a face – any face – so my eyes can beg the question for me ... *why?*

A blackness seeps across my vision, leaking from the edges to merge tree to bush to leaf and earth in a darkness as total as my secret cave. Soon the only thing in my world is a fiery man, a face that grows bigger as the world shrinks. A kind face; a sad face, with tears on its cheeks. Not the face of my kinslayer ...

... *who?*

## 11. The Child Without

There is a tightness ...

*'... Ah, shit! Again?'*

There is a tightness, and I have eyes. There is a rainbow of colours about me.

A decent healing pool, then.

I also have eyelids. The colours around me are too bright, and I have no wish to welcome that kind of pain into my growing head.

I close my eyes, let myself float into sleep ...

~~~

"This one. He's in this one!"

"Are you sure? How can you tell?"

"The birdy told me. That white one with the big beak."

"The one that near took my eye out?"

"Don't blame the birdy. You should've stayed away from its rabbit."

"Seagulls should eat fish, not rabbits! What else is there to eat around here?"

"With a beak that size, I reckons it can eat what it bloody well pleases! You didn't bring food with you?"

"We were celebrating the Time of the Great Rut, back in Uekh. Food was not my number one priority when you demanded I come here!"

"Sex! It's always the same with you sodding horsies! Every time is a Rutting Time! And since when have you started eating meat, heh?"

There is a pause in the words. My eardrums must be keen to test their new-formed abilities, and seem to be working overtime to catch snatches of

speech from beyond the pool. In place of words, I hear the grind of sand grains beneath me – fish darts, perhaps. I keep my eyes firmly sealed.

"This place – it's a fucking weird world. I've never wanted meat like I wanted that rabbit! This stone is wrong! It's like something pecking at my thoughts, trying to ruse me."

"You're right there, laddie. Fol Huun ain't improved a touch since my last time through here. Forget you're in a stone; treat it like time in the Outer World. Work on building some stubborn shields round your thoughts and don't let your senses tempt you away from what we're here for!"

A longer pause. Wave slaps echo through water to my tight bladders and the aching, growing bones within. Beneath me, an avalanche of pebbles – a quick glimpse shows me the shapes of two crabs weaving fronds of seaweed into something.

"So this is Kal's original home, huh? The man was always a bit of a mystery ..."

"Huh? No-one told you about him? Not Bull or Spar, or Yorga?"

"I never really thought to ask ..."

"So what do you know? We've got plenty of time to swap stories, by the looks of him in his funny bubble – won't be ready for a good age yet."

"That's another thing not right about this place. Why show everything off? In every other stone you heal in mud. This – it's just perverse! He hasn't even grown a cock yet ..."

"While back in Uekh that's probably the first thing to form, heh? But I'm sure you and Kal have been in the Outer World together."

"A few times. Not often – he seemed a quiet sort, what I remember of him. Did what he was told quick enough. Never caused me no problems, which is the way I like things. Though he could be vicious to his hosts at times ..."

"Vicious ... heh! The bastard's a fucking psychopath if you asks me – what? – Oh, someone who don't understand the folks around him, has no

emotions of his own. Someone who don't really care who he hurts, but enjoys seeing the hurt in others – you know?"

"That makes sense. I've ridden a few like that in my time."

"I'm surprised at you, never asking about him – he's the biggest surprise we've had since the Cold Times. I'm sure the fiskies would've trusted you to know the truth about him ..."

"Fiskies? Oh ... you mean Aherrket. Talking of which, where's he gone now? And why the fuck does he insist on wearing that orange seaweed on his head?"

"Hah! That wig was a fucking masterstroke! You think this place is playing buggery with your head? Well it caught young Kal entire, enthralled him from head to heel. Be interesting to see if Aherrket's ruse works! Monkey boy needs to remember his whole self ..."

"Monkey?"

"Yeah ... he ain't from this place, Heszic. He ain't from any stone - you should've guessed that bit! Even the big birdy knows – won't bloody well shut up about it. Now I ain't saying no more, not with my feet paddled in water. But you just asks yourself why we'd do all this to rescue someone from their own stone, heh? Then go talk to Aherrket when he comes back from his swim. Go talk somewhere more ... inland."

"Aherrket talks in riddles – I don't understand one thing in ten that comes out of his mouth."

"What do you expect? He's a fiskie. Farts out of the top of his head for fun!"

~~~

I hate crabs. I particularly hate the crab currently crawling over my face, prodding my cheeks and lips with its foot-claws, stroking my eyes with its – sharp, barbed, huge! – hand-claws ... if I had a piss pouch I'd empty it!

*~ She does not understand why you do not speak with her.*

I don't need the use of my eyes to tell me that my guardian has come to visit.

~ *She?*

~ *The crab on your face. She needs your words.*

~ *I do not hear her words, my Inner Voice tells the seagull. ~ I hear your words.*

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak-ak!"

This crab has an eye on a stumpy stalk that pokes up from the front edge of its – her – thick shell. She probably had two, at one time, but seems to do just fine with the one. The eye itself radiates a knowing intelligence that chills my tight-wrapped limbs.

~ *She ... is harsh to understand ... she makes an all-sense in me. I do not know this all-sense. I ... endure it. Fol Huun is kinder to Her flock!*

~ *How do you know words, then?*

It strikes me, as I float head-down in the pool with a japingly huge crab clamped to my face, that I've never had call to ask a guardian such question before. I recall Sam had asked the same question of me, once.

A healing should never be as taxing as this, I decide. Most healings are far more serene, with my most severe recalls centred around how to revenge myself on the person who put me in the pool.

I wonder: how many times have I been healed?

~ *I have no use for 'words'. Those yowls are your sounds. I care only for wind-song and wife-call. I build a nest in your Inner Voice from the pebble-clatters it would utter, and from that perch I see beak-dance and eye-cock, I hear fish-flash. An egg is shat between us and then it hatches to meaning. Egg after egg, after egg.*

This is the equivalent of a speech from the guardian.

~ *What does the crab want to say to me?*

"Ak-ak! Ak!"

*~ Not say. See; watch. Become more!*

*~ I recall too much already ...*

*~ The Old Ones know you. They recall you. They say: you do not recall you to you. They say: 'you must know you, Kal of Tintuun.'*

*~ How?*

*~ They have a Weave for you. Look at the Weave. Recall you within you!*

With no warning, the crab loosens her legs and drops from my face. I watch as she flips her body and splays her legs wide, their deep green lines a radiation from the intricate red-yellow swirls across her broad shell. Then a sudden flash of iridescent blues as she unfurls her fat tail from under her body to steer-glide down and down through rippled water.

*~ Crabs have tails?*

*~ The Old Ones are magnificent in many ways.*

I can make out some sort of flat carpet stretched across the bottom of the pool. When the crab lands on it, it smothers the plumes of grit I had expected to see. A snatch of Dream Sight, of crabs working together to lace seaweeds into some sort of mat, bubbles into my eyes.

I cannot make out the design in the weave, not at this distance. A taller man than me could stand on this pool's sand and, reaching his hands high, would not feel his fingertips break through to the air above.

I tell the gull this.

*~ Then you must go closer, he responds.*

*~ How?*

A moment later the waters above me erupt in a cascade of waves and bubbles. The punch of my guardian's feet into the small of my back – it hurts! A second punch follows. A series of punches as the bird pushes my curled flesh into motion.

It is enough. Slowly the sharp, sting-flower-clad walls around me start to move upwards. One last claw-scratching bang in my back is enough to keep me in motion.

There are many crabs in this pool, I realise, hidden in crevasses, peering out of holes bored into the side of the pool – a whole *village* of crabs!

Where exactly is this healing pool located? I have no idea – perhaps it is beyond the rocky stacks, or along a shoreline I have never visited before? These skull-words ... they scare me!

I do not know much about crabs. I know they are to be avoided – my gang brothers had many stories to share about encounters with the creatures, though such stories were only to be whispered between close friends when far from the shoreline and deep in their beer. Women were far more severe: to utter the word 'crab' in their hearing was not only taboo, it was fatal to breath and guaranteed to end in a visit to the healing pools.

The guardian had said: 'Old Ones'. I know I've heard that phrase before.

Aah – that is the where and the when of it!

I was on one of my solo raids, many healings before, my target a glade deep in the hills whose woman was renowned for her brewing yeasts. My abilities at that time were good enough to get me within spitting distance of the place without discovery. But the woman had company – four of her clan-sisters, sat in a circle with her in the middle. Clearly a time for rites, not raids.

No man would ever dare intrude on such a gathering. No man would dare listen.

Why was I so keen to watch, to hear?

The words they chanted together were in the form of a Dream Song – deep magic indeed, and utterly mysterious in their intent.

They sang of unbelievable changes. Their words told of fire in water, of a great mountain rising from steam storms to replace a land of mudflats



and warm lagoons. As they recounted how their limbs shrivelled, their shells cracked, their flesh stretched to abominable lengths – they weeped!

I had never seen a woman wail before. I never want to see it again.

That is when they sang of the Old Ones, the ones who had hidden from the Great One as She ordered this transformation. The ones who disobeyed Her utter commands. The false ones who kept their true shapes ...

The speed at which the rock moves past me is slowing. Hopefully the journey – which has brought my belly to a lurch – will stop a couple of hand lengths above the mat the crabs have been working on so industriously.

Now I can appreciate it properly. It is certainly a meticulous work of artistry. Even at this depth of water the colours are vibrant, the lines of the design clean and astute – almost a *language*

... I have seen this picture before. Where have I seen it before?

~ *Look at the Weave*, my guardian tells me, his voice in my head muffled by the layers of water now between us.

~ *Recall Kal of Tintuun!*

I do as instructed, and look at the seaweed mat. I see its design. I know I've seen it before, but where? When? I make an effort and open my eyes wider, let them wallow in the shapes and curves of lines. I let their story tangle into my Dream Sight, let whispers and hints fill my re-growing ears ...

~~~

"Has he stopped screaming yet?"

"The birdy says: yes. He's quiet again. The birdy don't like what the crabs done to him. Says he can't reach into his head now."

"It was a necessary thing."

This is a third voice – an ancient echo of someone I feel – close to?

"You told the crabs to do this to him?"

"I asked my friends to help. Caxtcheh has planted a seed in the boy's mind."

"Fucking brutal, if you asks me!"

"A field needs the harrow before seeds can be scattered."

"Since when have you fiskies cared about farming, heh?"

"We've all walked on two feet under the sun, and cast our shadows. Yes, even I, Mada. And it's not natural for any of us!"

"That's true enough. It takes me days to get used to walking on just my hind limbs."

That's the first voice, clearly male. Heszic – that's what the woman had called him before.

"Try losing half your limbs when you get summoned, horsie boy! And never the same limbs neither – one time I lost all my right legs in one go; had to crawl across floors for a fucking week trying to work it all out!"

That voice is ... Mada – I know her! I do not ... remember her? No image of her face comes willingly from my Dream Sight.

"How many are healing now?"

"Four," says Heszic. "The others are over there, closer to the shore. What I don't get is why we've all taken to two feet here in this world. Surely we should have arrived as crabs?"

"Too much has changed here. Fol Huun has been closed to Oounous for too long."

"What, even before the stone went missing?"

I assume the silence that follows the question is an agreement. I like the second man's deep voice, I realise, even if some of his words make little sense to me. Now I want to know what an 'ounous' is, and how Fol Huun could close against it. I want to know why Mada would lose half her legs.

So much I want to know – but I cannot ask questions. The guardian hasn't spoken a word to me since that damn crab showed me her seaweed weave ...

"So what's the plan for the other three? And why aren't there more of them? What's happened to all the locals?"

"There's plenty of crabs around, Heszic – pick up a rock and there's another one of the buggers! Lots of fish; too many bloody rabbits. I've only seen the one seagull, though: Fol Huun used to love her little birdies – I remember that much. And there was enough monkeys around, last time I was here, though not as many as you'd think there should be."

"You've been here before?"

"Twice. First time by accident. Second time – well, I'll not talk about that. Healing in one of them pools ... it ain't pleasant. Scrambles your head to fuck!"

"There was always strange rumours about this world – even before Keftiu. Not many from here got summoned, though ..."

"Be glad of that. Monsters, the lot of 'em. Murderers!"

"The rabbits ..."

The third voice has been silent for a while, letting the other two chat.

"... they make no sense to me. Kal's guardian does not know them, though it approves of their taste."

I know the answer to that: the rabbits don't belong here. They come from the same place I come from.

«*Indeed*» agrees the one-eyed crab, crouched in her hole no more than an arm's reach from my face.

«*But you still need to know more, understand more of you!*»

~~~

Something happened to me when I welcomed the images in the crab's weave into my head. Something ... shocking. Like a hole drilled through my skull to let the *sun* and the *moon* and the *stars* flood in.

*«Why do you all-sense a man chipping a hole in a younger man's shell?»*

So many Dream Songs have returned to me, so many words and actions and happenings. I should be driven to madness as they flood and swirl through my head – I ... think?

Yes, I was just that for a while – a ball of madness – but these gifts are too good to refuse!

*~ He is – was – my uncle. He fell from a cliff one day, while on a hunt for deer. It was raining when my father helped to carry him back to the camp. The old man, he knew the quiet paths, the tracks through dreams. He told my father that uncle had a dam in his head, that the life he consumed with each breath could not escape.*

*«And the hole would release this dam? Then surely he would die, as the turtle dies, flesh and Vital Breath together?»*

The crab – her name doesn't translate into proper, decent sounds, but I get a impression that it means something like 'Dappled Gladiator In The Foam' – has a habit of asking difficult questions. It seems to me to be a trait common to all women, whatever shape or form they come in.

*~ No. I had to see what they did to him. Secrets – even then they angered me. I shouldn't have been there at all, but I was still young enough to sneak into places where others were not welcome.*

Even as my Inner Voice speaks, I can see the Dream Sight of that moment build in my eyes.

*~ The old man, he had a special flint with a curve to its edge. He cut uncle's skin away from the side of his head, then chipped a circle into the bone – a perfect circle, it was. He was chanting a song – strange words I still don't understand.*

I can see now the old man's fingers, still and sure at this moment with no hint of their normal tremor, push a thin stone sliver under the bony plug and gently lift it away ...

*«And your uncle, he lived?»*

*~ Yes. Some herbs were boiling in water ...*

*... A good, wholesome smell, I recall: sharp-sweet and yet ... calm?*

*~ They had to wait for the water to cool before they washed out the wound. Then the old woman – my mother's mother – came and stitched the skin back in place. We called him Uncle Spooky after that because he could talk to the little folk, once he was well again.*

This is a good Dream Sight. I am glad I have gathered it again to my call. The crab, too, seems glad.

*«This is the purpose of a Weave – it opens our all-sense to things once lost – but nothing is truly lost, rather mislaid – like a pebble swallowed by the sting-flower»*

The words that are not my Inner Voice break apart my happy recalling of my long-lost uncle. There are some things I have *remembered* which wrench me in horrid ways; feelings I have not experienced since after I met the metal magician and his massive, murderous flame-headed companion ...

I would gladly give back to the green-pink sting flowers, packed close on their rocky shelves, my renewed understanding of words such as 'loss', and 'death'.

I tell the crab this.

*«You did not lose your words» she explains. «You let them be taken from you – but they couldn't be taken, only hidden for a while»*

*~ Who would do such a thing? My gang brothers? The clan women?*

*«The thing that breathed and walked and swam here once, that called itself 'Kal', was nothing more than an empty skin – a flayman of a different*

*shape, forever seeking its lost core – but your all-sense was never lost – you know this thing now, and recall it»*

*~ But how do you know? How do you know me?*

*«I have seen you – witnessed you – many, many times I have watched you in these healing pools – such impossible things demand to be remembered! So know this: we do not die – we are as much the purpose of Fol Huun as your gang brothers and clan women»*

*~ I do not die. Though I am dead?*

*«Do you know now why you fascinate me so?»*

Yes. Because things do die here in Fol Huun.

The turtles come to their lagoons to lay their leathery eggs, and each egg is a new life, and when the turtle's flesh expires the creature dies entire. The same goes for the brelfruit I eat, or the Rappoe fish so keen to share its venom. Only the crabs, and the brothers and sisters – and, for a time, I – have been charged to endure eternities here in this world.

I know it; I do not understand it.

*~ What about the guardians? I ask. ~ Do they not live forever, like us?*

*«The guardians are ... they are like puddles of stranded water from the encircling sea that is Fol Huun – they are themselves for a while, then they wash back to the Power Herself – they lay eggs and raise chicks, and each chick is a new container for a splash of Her – thus can Fol Huun see all and know everything»*

If I could sigh, I would. The waters with me in my bladders are rapidly turning stale, a sure sign that my healing will end soon. I ache to stretch again, to breathe air and move joints. To share words with strangers who, somehow, know me.

I need to know more of me!

## 12. Seven Summers

I am – more – than I used to be.

I sit amid branches, in a tree whose lower boughs are already shorn from the trunk. The toe-holes chipped through the trunk's bark have calloused – old wounds now healed. Leic's directed work, no doubt. Often he would order us to prepare several trees for harvesting; he liked to see how the wood's grain knotted before making his final decisions.

A knotty canoe is a slow canoe, I remember.

From this perch I can see the site of my last ... *murder*? Yes, murder. A deliberate killing, for fun. Though maybe the huge man with the false hair would argue the act was a necessity. A kindness, even.

The – more – of me that sits in my guts, in knots, seems to agree with that thought. So many new knots, each a reminder of who I was and how I became what I became in this place of horrors and brothers and strives and lusts and hurts.

Now I reknow – *remember* – my place and life in Tintuun, my love of Fol Huun is gone, removed from my flesh like an invisible Flayman's wrap cast to one side, headless.

The wind is strong through the scaffold of branches and leaves around me. It does not lie; upwind is upwind and the mountain rises behind me. I do not look towards the mountain and its High Domains. Gazing at the site of my murder holds more comfort; in the distance I can see salt waves with their foam-white wigs dancing in lines towards the shore: their patterns help soften the confusions in my head.

I *remember* the High Domains, now. I know why I fear to look at them. The burn of the freeze of my first death, and the bitter-cold shock of my first rebirth, somewhere above me in the cliff-lined bowl atop its cloud-breaking peak – my skin puckers at the recall.

... How was I reborn? Safe in the hug of this tree, I attempt to reclaim that sight – but no images form in my Inner Vision. Only the shivers of new

flesh as broken air kisses at skin. Only the scream of a new voice that scrapes in my throat ...

"Don't!" my real voice commands my Inner Voice. "Don't hear those calls. Don't listen!"

Quickly, I force the image of a spear branching from my chest into my eyes, force the slick touch of blood along its shaft into my fingers. Let the happy recall of my last ending melt the frost of the first.

~~~

It was the guardian who released me from my latest healing pool. For once it was gentle, pushing the hook of its beak between the crease of my arm and my chest to create a tear in the tight membrane surrounding me. As I unfolded my limbs, slowly, the rip lengthened. I refused to let any hint of panic shake through my flesh while I stretched my back and pushed my face towards the salt air beyond the surface ripples.

My first breath was long, slow, quiet. The guardian was already airborne as my eyes adjusted to the world around me. I observed his path low over the waves, away from the shoreline, curving downwind to move beyond the strand that my gangmates called home.

It was an easy decision to follow the bird's example. There are new people in the world, I recalled, and new people are dangerous people. Better to confront such dangers from a place of strength. I waited, still, for those new voices to move away from the shoreline, before asking the crab to tell the guardian to help me.

That wait, that stillness, had been a harsh endurance!

The pool I emerged from was far from the cliffs, beyond the arched rocks, close to deep water. Quiet and low, I had edged myself across the lip of the space, let the barnacles scrape across my belly and my tackle. The ripples I left as I pushed away from the rocks were quickly swallowed by the low chop of cool waves.

~~~



I know something watches me. I can feel the pressure of its gaze pinned to the point where my neck and shoulders join; a tickle of an itch, a pluck where the edge of my head hair will soon grow.

Yet I do not feel hunted. This is not the malice of the bryesnatcher waiting for me to come close, nor a tangle of caddiwhips silent between their hunting song. Rather, I feel the steady stare of a woman.

Though such a suspicion is a japery my Inner Voice would play on me. There are no women in Fol Huun, not anymore. I've searched too many empty roosts now to know the truth of this.

There is the crab, of course, whose water-aura speaks of old eggs. And the guardian's new companion is clearly different from him, though he does not 'know' her. These are not women.

Nor is Mada, the voice that gossiped beside my healing pool, a woman in the way I know a woman of Fol Huun to be: I've not yet talked to her face but even so I'm sure no clan would tolerate her presence.

I take another bite of brelfruit, then rest my hand back onto my leg that dangles over the bough – my *right* leg, I recall to myself. Brelfruit is good food, but by all I hold dear I wish it was steamed fish!

My mother, I recall, was a woman, as was her mother, who was training her in the small mysteries. Until I found her dead in the meadow ...

Whatever watches me is behind me, mountainwards, and is a person who is not a brother or a stranger. Which means she is a woman in a world where all the women have gone elsewhere ...

I scratch at the itch. Fighting a swarm of caddiwhip rats would hurt my skull less!

~~~

I've stopped counting my breaths, and my steps. I don't know when this happened. Which means I don't know when I am: is it a worktime or a rest time? Sleptime? Without a gang brother to compare counts with, I cannot tell if I should sleep or hunt!

Why am I climbing towards the High Domains? I do not know! The idea to climb had wriggled into my skull and a twist in my belly had eased and ... and now I climb.

I need to know more of me. I need to know why I fear the High Domains.

This deep into the island, the mountain rises in steep folds and dips. Streams run fast and cold over a clatter of smoothed cobbles, their sprays an invigoration to keep me alert when I venture down to cup water, or relieve myself.

"You want me to shit in the water?" my Inner Voice recalls.

I can image the flesh of Luntas, sat on a rock that juts from the ground a couple dozen hands above my face. "It's not safe to leave your soil on the ground, or buried in it," he replies, his face set in its teaching frown. "Such a present would tell every creature that cared that we were here, and what we are."

Luntas had found me in a cave, I recall. The cave was out of the wind, thus not frozen. I do not recall how I found the cave ...

... Ohh, this is an early Dream Sight! It has the feel of a boy with *seven summers* to his face and not long dead, now lost in a place with an unreal sky the colors of mallow flowers.

I need to know more of me! Now I have the edge of this know I need to explore it, wallow in it. The stream I see is not the stream in the recall, though this high on the mountain slope all streams look similar. I spot an outcrop of rock a couple of hundred paces along the bank, with a suggestion of shadow which hints at shelter. With rock to my back, I reckon, I will be safe to allow this, this *memory* to take me along its path.

A decision made, and soon enough done. This great boulder is good, with tall grass all around to keep me hidden. I settle my bare rear into the sprung soil, and slow my breaths.

Now – when did I first meet Luntas?

I recall the cave, and for once the vision builds easily in my eyes. This cave was tall even to its thin entrance, and smelt of bad turtle fruits. Sharp

were its sides, with no level floor. But not deep. There was a dryness to the walls; there was a heat near the back of the space, like the hearth clays soon after the cooking fire goes dim.

I recall my legs ... were whole again? Was there a time when my legs were missing ...?

~ NO! Do not lead my recall there!

My legs were whole, and the slug between them – large. Man large. Large like my father's manhood, but not stiff. Stiffness, my *remember* tells me, was a discovery to come, after Luntas bought me down from the High Domains to the low cliffs, and the sea.

I was warm, I recall, like I had never been warm before. Warm, and starved, like I had been starved when I died ... died the first time. The real time. I know now that I knew then that I had died from coldness and a belly empty beyond pain. I died in snow. I died at night on a chalk hill with no shelter of trees, hunted by men and dogs who needed me dead, who needed the curse I carried in my flesh released, banished from their world.

I remember I had a flint knife in my hand when I died, seven summers in my face, but I was too weak to use it to end me.

I remember I wanted to ... end me!

I wanted me ended like I ended the monster who took my skull and my Inner Voice and my body after the metal magician had hung his shiny *amulet* around my neck. As he was dying. After I found my mother and father and uncles and cousins dead in the meadow. After I hid from the man with the flaming hair and the rage in his spear and his flints who had murdered them in his pain. Who should have murdered me ...

I was in a not-cold cave, out of the wind, out of the rain, in a place with a sky the colour of mallow flowers but no sun, no day, no night, no count of when, or why.

... And then I was with a strange man who tipped water from his palm into my mouth, and fed me small chunks of sweet fruit – brefruit, my tongue tells me – and pulled a supple bark cloak around my shoulders and covered my loin in a weave of smooth, fine kelps.

Luntas. He told me his name was Luntas and I told him my name was Bud-of-the-Ash-Tree, a holy tree, a name which in his mouth sounded like 'Kal'. And so I was Kal, who learned soon after that if you wanted to stay safe in the mountain's High Domains, you needed to dip your arse into swift stream waters and let it take your spoor elsewhere.

At my back, I feel the boulder shiver.

13. The Render

ThereIsAPAIN!

The Pain ... it is at, on me. The Pain is – in me: here, here, here! Many Pains. They ... *jape*? The Pain in my thigh japes with the Pain in my hip japes with the Pain in my hand japes with the Pain in my eye ...

My – *right* – eye?

Yes, yes! My right eye! My eye is – shut. No. My eyes are shut. My, my fist is closed. My *right* fist. It is closed, tight closed. My ... fingers? My fingers wrap around my right thumb. They wrap so tight around a thumb that is huge and yet thin – a chick's thumb – a *child's* thumb. A thumb that is and is not and is all, all, all ... Pain!

Wraps ... wraps ... wraps?

There is no tightness around me!

This is a not-tightness, a ... wrongness. Not right. Wrong!

I can stretch an arm – a *left* arm – *my* arm – across stone. Warm stone. I can stretch and ... *lift*? Yes, lift. I lift my left arm, my left hand, my left thumb – around which no fingers wrap. I can lift them all away from the warm rock. I can gather together the parts of my left limb and break – *bend*? – yes, bend them to each other and rest them on my chest and *worm* then to my neck, my face ...

My face – it is ... *wrong*? Not *fixed*. No mouth – jaw – should sit on a face like this. My jaw is a jape on my face. It is wrong. It is a Pain that wrecks me! So, so much wrongness is at me, on me. To me. My Pain. Not a healing pain ...

Not a healing pool. No tightness; no membrane; no float of water ...

It is to much. This is too much!

I keep my eyes shut, let a float of darkness take me from Pain ...

~~~

*~ I recall – remember – pain!*

A rain of pain; a deluge. An ocean of raw, burning sunlight, a tumble of hard agonies spiking from rock and soil and worms to beat at me. Everything I sense, I reknow, is its own, unique, timeless agony that refuses to meld and dull into a more comforting throb of hurt.

"I know you can hear me!"

I recall a voice. That voice. A voice that splinters my skins into sparks with each sound, words gathering into a hammer of flint on flint on flint to beat me beat me senseless – no, sense-full, sense ... burst; sense-drowned to new levels of freeze and burn and stab and ache and tear and boil and rage and rage and rip and scream and tears and beg and hate and stop, stop ... stop!

"Hear me," the voice in the Dream Sight tells me. "Listen to me. Follow me. Do as I say and we can make the pain go away"

*'... Stop?'*

"Do you remember your eyes?"

*'... Remember?'*

"Yes, remember. Recall, maybe. Do you recall your eyes? The way you would close your eyes? The way you would slowly close them?"

*'... Yes?'*

"Good. Good! Do that now. Remember yourself slowly closing your eyes. Remember the way your muscles shift and press on your eyelids. The way the light dims and the world hides as you press harder and your eyes close. You remember? Do that now. Slowly close your eyes."

So hard, that first movement, to close down my eyes. And as I push muscles against eyelids the pain ... lessens? The pain ... blurs, like stirring a bright pool with a stick to muddy the waters – still water; still pain, but ... less bright, less hurt!

"That's it, lad. You're doing good!"

As the sparks of his sounds mellow into words, I sense that this is a voice I have never heard before. A strange voice, yet ... concerned? Warm?

*«This was a voice you could trust?»*

~ Yes, I agree. Though as I am caught in my Dream Sight I do not know why I would hold such a belief, to trust – to love? – the man to whom the voice belonged.

Another Dream Sight excess, I suppose. How can I trust a man I've never thought of before?

This exercise is a crab thing. Caxtcheh had come to me in the darkness of slumber and set an all-sense egg in my skull and now I can talk again. Not my real voice; my jaw, I now know, is too damaged to make real words. But I can talk to the crab, and the crab can talk to the woman who rescued me from the rockfall.

*«Why do you choose to share this particular Dream Sight with me?»*

~ I ... my leg is smashed. My pain is intense! My pain – it follows me from work time to sleep time.

*«And this is a recall that resembles your stateness now? Perhaps a call of a thing that happened?»*

Perhaps the crab is right? Is this Dream Sight something that is more truth than fear?

"That's it, lad. You're doing good!"

I close my eyes and slowly the place around me ... *resolves*? No, that is not a word I know. The place *comes together*, like the final work to fit a canoe's prow.

I can see blue sky above me; I can feel the heat of a ... a *sun*? Yes, that word I know! The sun is in the sky and while I cannot look at it I can tell, by the heat on my skin, that it has been sailing the sky for a good number of breaths. Many hundreds of breaths.

But my eyes are closed. I know this! I have closed my eyes and now the pain racks only my leg. My broken leg. I have broken my limbs many

times in Fol Huun, I recall. This pain in my Dream Sight is now a comfortable pain, a pain that often ends with a visit to the healing pools.

'... *Still ... see?*'

"This is your first time in the Outer World?" asks the man in my Dream Sight. "It's been a while since I've had to introduce a Vital Breath to riding a host. A long while! But it's simple enough; we'll soon have you hopping along."

'... *Host?*'

"You don't know what a host is?"

'... *No?*'

"Lord of all Fucks! Then how are you here?"

'... *Where?*'

"Here! Here in the Outer World!"

I can hear exasperation in his voice, like Leic's comments on my attempts to carve an oar. I would always blame it on the poor quality of the branch my brothers had assigned me to carve; still he would sneer, despite the evidence before him.

'... *Outer World?*'

«Aah!» says Caxtcheh. «*Do you know the shape of this Dream Sight now?*»

~ *No*, I admit.

In the Dream Sight, the voice beside me, this voice of a man whom I will come to trust, falls silent. I can shift my eyes-not-eyes, my head-not-head, to see the walls of the alley in which I lay. Walls made of – *brick?*

Yes, brick. Mud bricks stacked together to make the walls of a, an avenue ...? No, an *alley*. I do not have the know of alleys, though I call I will know later that they maze. This has no sense to me. I can hear the buzz of a



– a *grasshopper*! – low on the wall near to my collapsed body. I can smell the salt in the puddle in which my body lies.

Salt in puddles ... a real thing; a solid know!

I watch as a shadow moves on the wall. It is the shape of a flayman. I look away from the wall, and away from the sky. I lift my head.

The shadow belongs to a man. The man stares at me with dark, dark eyes. The man has a thin face and short, rough-shorn hair; a nose long broken. A skin lighter than the skins of my brothers; a skin like mine, caught in the tans of a long summer's work.

I see that he wears a shift, but not of soft bark. It is not a woman's cloak of gull feathers. It is not the skin of a – *deer*? – or the stitched furs of, of *hares*. A different material, then, bright and light and stained in patches of muds and sands.

Around his shoulder he wears a cloud of light like a gust of hearth smoke. It has many colours, this ... thing he wears around his shoulders, through his head. But mainly blue, like the sky yet deeper and lighter.

The man stares at me, but not at my eyes. His eyes dart in small ways around my head, like Leic examining my attempts to carve an oar's curved blade. Looking for knots and veins run askew.

The man mutters: "Not Ounous, nor Tincas. You are a strange one, lad! Both blue and red ... which leaves Fol Huun, but that's impossible!"

'... *Fol Huun!*'

I know Fol Huun. It is where I am me. It is where I have brothers – Leic, and Jiar, and Geit, and Luntas.

'... *Brothers ... where?*'

'... *See! Eyes closed. Why see?*'

"See?" says the thin faced man. "Yes, you can see because you look through your host's eyes. When we are in the Outer World, we of the *Band* can exist only in the flesh of others who know only the Outer World. We use their eyes to see, and their ears to hear. We taste their food and drink

through their tongues ... fuck! I could do with a good flagon of wine right now!"

'... *Band?*'

"Yes, lad. The Band. Ounous, Tincas, Fuebe, Uekh ... all the Worlds Within Worlds together as the Band. How do you not know this? Even the millions in Fuebe know this thing! Even the folks who hide in Fol Huun ..."

I watch the man stop talking, watch the smoke around his head tighten, gather its colors into a sway of strands.

I watch the man reach for string hung around his neck, pull on it, draw something from within his not-bark shift ... a dull grey *amulet* of, of *metal* dangled from reed-string to rest over his heart ... but not just grey metal, but also pretty stones, each a different colour – red, and green, sky blue, sea blue, amber ... seven stones.

~ *No. No, no!*

I know this amulet. I've worn it! I died with it around my neck, my seven summers in my face frozen in that winter hill's snow ...

I recall in my Dream Sight – my *memory!* I recall my question:

'... *Seven?*'

And suddenly the man's eyes are at mine, like the spear through my mother's chest!

"Yes, lad. Seven!" he says. "Seven stones! Mountains become boiling clouds and waves charge over cliffs and fields and suddenly Fol Huun is ... is gone!"

His mouth is suddenly a grin: wild and angry: "Except for you. Here I find you, screaming at the furnace of the stars, the last of Fol Huun ...

"What sort of fucking disaster are you ...?"

## 14. Melwais

The rock which holds me is a hole of solidity, a tunnel of warm ... rock.

Each time I wake, I panic, convinced that I am once more in the tight tunnel of the yellow powder and I am sat amid skulls – my skulls, left behind each time the addled air of that place released my Vital Breath from my flesh.

The rock of the tunnel shivers. I shiver with it.

"I watched you fall, when the hill fell into the valley. It is a cliff now, that hill, and a lake behind the dam it made – a good place for a new grove."

"Hkkk ... hwww?"

"How?" There is enough light from the cracks and holes that thread the roof of this tunnel for me to make out the woman knelt beside me. She can see my attempt at a nod.

Melwais has changed. Her skin is still a deep *copper*, but cracked now, with many tiny folds around her eyes, her mouth. Her hair carries the plum tones of the pot vine's traps, darker than blood, which call out to the bugs and flies to come visit, drown in the trap's nectar ... but it no longer shines so bright, and some strands look pale, like drying sand.

"How did you fall? The ground shook, and the hill tipped and its side fell and you fell with it. Rocks filled the valley and the stream's waters now gather behind the new dam."

"Nnnnn! Hwww ... www arkh mmmmfff?"

I see, then feel, her fingers as they pat and drag across my brow. She lets them dampen, then pulls them away to be licked, tasted, tested. A woman can tell much from the taste of a man's sweat, she had told me when first she did this.

"How ... how rock ...?"

I nod sharply: "Mmmfffss!"

"How do rocks move?"

She considers the question.

"Rocks always move. All the time. Fol Huun shakes and the rocks dance. You know this, Kal."

Do I know this?

I know rocks fall. There were times when my brothers and I would axe a good tree and the tree would collapse the wrong way, the bang of its landing making the hill on which it grew slip a little. Or sometimes we would throw pebbles high at the clouds to see whose token would fly the longest, or highest, or fastest – though they always fell back to the ground: no rock can fly for long.

A quick image forms in my eyes. Men and women wrapped in skins and furs, working together to sling stones at birds – guardians? No. Just birds. White birds, and black – to knock them from the sky and bring them back to the cooking pit ...

A grey sky, or sometimes blue. Or, when the sun sat on the edge of the world, copper and fire ...

I push the image away from my eyes, fill my eyes with hers.

"Sshhk? Hwww sshhk ffoww hhhn?"

She breaks my gaze. Silence and stillness.

Then: "You have a fever, Kal. Too many bones broken, and I lack the herbs to fix you."

She offers me water from a small clay pot. I grasp it in my wiping – no, *left* – hand and attempt to tip some drops of the liquid into a mouth I can barely move. The water tastes ... bitter. When I try to throw the rest of it away she moves fast to grab my hand, hold it still.

My weakness angers me. This woman angers me! I do not know why Melwais tortures me; a brother would have released me to the healing pools

as soon as he found me. She – refuses me. She keeps my Vital Breath tethered to this wrecked flesh. She keeps me fresh for the eating, I'm sure!

"Hwww sshhk!" I demand.

Still she doesn't look at me. She looks ... afraid?

No, she is right. My fever makes me see things which are not there. Like a family on a great river's shoreline, under a burning copper sky, slingshots in our hands, hunting gulls for supper.

"Drink all of the water, Kal. It holds some old powders which should help ease your pain."

"Hwww ...? Hwww sshhk ...?"

I can see a decision set in her face. Slowly; reluctantly. I shiver again, or the rock on which I rest shivers.

"If I tell you something, you will drink?"

"Sssss."

"Then drink the water."

I consider my options. Maybe the water is poisoned? Maybe Melwais has decided to release me after all?

A blade to the throat would be quicker, but Melwais is a woman and the ways of women cannot be questioned lightly. While I bring the clay pot back to my lips I lock my eyes to her face.

She seems to relax now her decision is made and I'm following her demands. Her shoulders ease a little.

"Do you recall your last Procession? The time I came to your strand to lead you and your brothers to the place of the Race?"

I nod, and sip.

"Good. Do you recall what happened when we reached the High Domains?"

I recall the Procession along the avenue into the foothills, and the cobbled track's winding passage upwards, beyond the trees and towards the clouds. I recall many such Processions. Was one Procession different from any other? Always we Processed, and at the end of each we raced our canoe against another gang's canoe. And sometimes we lost the Race and watched as the other team took their axes to our canoe, and sometimes we won and danced in consuming flames as Fol Huun watched, and approved.

Many losses, and many wins. As I recall my efforts, they all become one Procession, one climb, one Race. One consuming fire.

"Do you recall? I was with you when Her summons came. We were laying together. Do you recall Her summons?"

I stare at her face and try to image it in a different space. Closer. Much closer so our lips could touch, our tongues wrap in a woman's kiss ...

And ... yes! I recall the thick, sweet scent of reyalla blooms on her neck, a shiver of salt on my tongue. I remember us laying together after a long push of many steps. Our second time together – much to brother Jiar's annoyance as he had not yet been welcomed into the Lady's embrace.

"Ah, I see you recall something, little Kal," she says with a hint of lost laughter in her tone. "But that is not what I asked you to recall. Drink the water, now, and recall Her summons."

She demands too much. These reknows tempt me from pain; I would wallow in them! But I can see her eyes beyond visions and they are serious eyes, eyes that require me to be – more – than I am.

I need to know more of me.

I have dreamed of intimacy with women far more than I have experienced it. Sometimes I would pretend that Jiar was a woman as I entered him, though Jiar lacked the details I needed, and we never kissed ...

Sam ... Sam kissed as women kissed ...

No, that is a distraction! Sam also kicked me out of the longhouse. He kicked my Vital Breath from my flesh, as women sometimes do ...

Achoa had very sharp teeth, I recall, and unnatural speed in a fight ...

It is Melwais before me, not Achoa. The light from the gaps in this tunnel's roof may be dim, but it is enough for me to know that this is Melwais, and I have known Melwais before this moment. I've walked with Melwais in a Procession, and lain with her ... twice? Yes, twice!

That second time, we had talked. I can recall this now. I reknow our words: *'Does the Great One talk to you?'* I had asked. And she had answered: *'She always talks to those who have eyes to watch the skies.'*

Many words we had shared: *'The sun lives in another place,'* she had told me. *'Day,'* she had said as she let her fingers stroke my thigh, and *'night'* – sounds with no meaning, and yet they whispered of meaning as they japed in my ears ...

Sam, too, had said such words. And Maak. Each time I heard them, my ears tingled on the edge of ... of something?

I died on a hill with snow over grass, with a night sky above me and seven summers frozen in my face ... I *remember* that!

I feel the woman's fingers touch mine, here in the tunnel. I feel them push my hand up to tip water from the clay pot into my mouth. I cough as the bitter liquid scratches my throat, then swallow – once, twice – too trapped in *memories* to notice its cool scold in my throat.

"I recall that time we lay together," she says. "So many questions you had, such doubt in your face. Fol Huun had shaken as we shook each other into joy, as She had shaken for much of our Procession. Though the Great One always tremors, She seemed – more eager, perhaps? Yes, more eager for this Procession to complete. Do you recall, Kal?"

"Sssss!"

"Good. Because as we talked, the ground around us – it stopped shaking. Do you reknow that, Kal? You noticed it too; I recall seeing a confusion in your face, as if a certainty was gone. The ground stopped moving, and the air stopped ... moving! I heard ... nothing! Silence, Kal, like a relief – yes, a relief! You recall this?"

"Sssss ...?"

"And then ... the Great One summoned us all to attend Her. So gentle, that call. Such – such love! In its silence, love, like I've never felt before ..."

I look hard now at the woman's face. I watch as her eyes loosen and relax into her own Dream Sight. I take the moment to pull my hand from hers, to lower the empty clay pot to the floor and roll it away from me.

She shakes her head. A forced, quick jerk to scatter images away from her eyes, and suddenly her eyes are focussed again on mine.

"It was wrong!"

"Wwww ... wwrraa?"

She nods: "Wrong! Like when She summoned us from our pools to gather in the air, to watch the sea boil as rock burned, to watch the mountain grow and stretch to the clouds. To stretch us – me! – out and away from our shells and stretch us long and sprout limbs and breasts and, and faces! Wrong love. Wrong pain!"

She grabs my hand – my damaged *right* hand with its missing thumb. She traps my wound in the fingers of her hands and squeezes: "You recall that love, Kal? That racking pain?"

"Aaaarrhh! Nnnn. NNNnn!"

I cannot pull my hand away. I cannot close my eyes to block out the intense questions now etched in her face.

She nods again, slowly, then glances down to where we join. Carefully she disentangles our fingers. She looks almost rueful as she pats my hand back to my belly, where I like to let it rest.

"That makes sense to me," she agrees. "I recall Her summons and the love She offered and again I can feel my ... my disgust! My fear bathed in Her love. But you – when I looked at you, then, I saw nothing beyond a confusion woven into your face ... no fear, nor love. Just ... just something amiss. And then you stood ..."



"Sssss," I confirm. For I, too, am caught in this woman's Dream Song.

I can recall the terror stamped across the Lady's body, a sudden change from the contentment she had shown just moments before. I can *remember* pulling myself away from her sudden, stiff tangle of limbs. Her face, I recall, was – slack – not full of the love, the fear, her words now speak of. Slack, empty.

Gone!

She was gone from me, though her flesh lay at my feet. I recall that instant, when I stood and looked about me. I could see my gangmates, my friends and enemies, at rest for the sleeptime. Some sat around a hearthstone fire, others lay on the cobbles of the track, or in the grass.

Melwais is right. There's no sound in this Dream Sight, no movement of grass or wind, or flesh. The mountain is still; Fol Huun is – still!

"Ssstt," I say. "Nnnar mmfffss!"

I bring myself back to the tunnel, to the woman. I let my jaw ache into a shape of a question: "Whaiy?"

There's a wetness in her eyes, a glisten of tears."

"The Great One's summons – I refused it! I felt the Vital Breaths of everyone around us leave their flesh and rise up into the air, and up, and I – I fought Her command, even as I felt my own Vital Breath lift out of my flesh. I refused it!"

Her grief flows freely now, a stream of tears over her cheeks. I move my injured hand towards her, let it rest in her lap.

"And there you were, Kal, walking around as if nothing had happened. Nothing! Just a look of confusion in your face. And as the summons pulled me, I fought it!"

I watch her throat search for the next word: one breath; two.

"I forced my Vital Breath towards your face, and through it and, and into you. I found your Vital Breath, safe in your skull, and there I hid. I hid ..."

"Ssss," I say.

"I hid in you until the summons was done and the wind moved and Fol Huun shivered again! But you wouldn't let me go. You – you *knew* me and you trapped me tight at the edge of your skull and you were so – so angry! Such rage! How could you ... how, Kal?"

Her mouth is taut; her fear of me etched in dim shadows of teeth and lips: "How?"

"Ssss," I say, my broken hand in her lap. And: "Hhhsssshhh!"

## 15. The Crab Way

This healing pool has a shelf on which I can sit. It is midway between the seaward arches and the low cliffs marking the shape of the bay. Few waves reach me here, which is good because while my bones appreciate the weightless support of the pool's calm water, they are less keen for the slaps and ripples and pushes of the salt hills.

*~ Melwais wants to eat my leg, I tell my invisible visitor.*

*«Melwais wants to cut away your bad flesh» Caxtcheh replies. «You rot with each breath – can you not feel your limb's damage?»*

The crab is nearby, I guess. She does not need to be near me to plant all-sense into my skull, but when she is closer the all-sense is easier to ... hear? Maybe. Though touch is perhaps a better explanation, like my throat can touch my own words gathering behind my face before I speak them.

Not that I can speak much. While my broken hand with its missing thumb is wrapped in seaweed, the crabs were not able to wrap the healing kelps around my head. They only work when they are kept in water, and I need to breathe.

I form words in my throat, pretend to speak them into the air.

*~ To spill my blood would be a simple cure. Then Melwais could eat all of my flesh, even toast it in flames.*

*«You would prefer to form anew?»*

*~ Better than watch a woman eat my legs, my arms! Why do women need to eat men?*

I spot a wave approach from beyond the arches – a bigger wave, this one, though the wind is currently gentle and even. It smashes into the rock of the arches with some force, but soon gets lost in the net of healing pools, a weave of white caps breaking on the confusion of rough walls and their sharp barnacles.

*«Limbs are cheap – when I damage a limb, I drop it from my body, grow a new one, ready to reappear at my next moult»*

*~ That is the thing you do, instead of using a healing pool, this moult?*

From my healing pool I can see the giant strangers, gathered on the strand towards the sentinel rock which marks the limit of my gang's territory. They are teaching the new ones – Sam, Maak-em-ay-are-see; even Chick, now regrown after his first flesh choked on the guardian's vomit – how to build a fire and cook the fish Aherrket has caught for them.

*«These healing pools are dangerous – they suck away the know of things – much better to shed the shell and grow a little more»*

*~ Am I in danger, here?*

*«Yes – your leg rots – it fouls the water – soon it will rot all of your flesh – we can help you drop it, stop the rot»*

*~ And then you will eat it?*

*«Only the parts that have not rotted»*

*~ Why?*

A hesitation before the next all-sense sprouts in my skull. When it unwinds, it comes with a hint of a shrug ...

*«It is the crab way»*

Beyond the arched rocks I can see another wave approaching, larger than most. Fol Huun has been shaking more eagerly than usual, and the waters around the mountain jape with vigor.

*~ Melwais is a woman, not a crab.*

*«Melwais was a crab once – before the Great One cracked her shell and stretched her flesh – Melwais knows this; she never un-knewed it – she is still a crab, just ... uglier now»*

The wave approaches me quickly, its swell large enough to swamp pools with fresh salt. I turn my head away and close my eyes tightly as it rushes to swallow my head.

*~ She is beautiful to me!*

*«You scare her»*

*~ Why?*

*«You, Kal of Tintuun, are not a crab!»*

Now underwater, I open my eyes. Caxtcheh and her companions have done good work to remove all dangers from this small place: no spear snails; no Rappoe fish lurking in the sand just beyond the reach of my toes. One of my legs – my *right* leg – is double-double the aroundness of the other. Its skin is a mottle of reds and blues and purples veined like the mallow flowers that I can recall from my time before Fol Huun.

It aches, still, but it no longer burns.

*~ Healing in membranes would be easier for me, if I'm not a crab?*

And suddenly the wave has passed, my head is free of the water. I breathe in quickly, in case another wave hides behind the first, tucked in tight to swallow me.

*«You need to know more of you, not less – you need to know all of you»*

*~ I know too much of me already!*

*«Nevertheless ...»*

*~ Why?*

I feel the crab withdraw its all-sense from my skull. It is an ease of a pinch behind my eyes, an absence of force where pressure once sat – like a jaw becoming accustomed to its rearranged shape.

It is a relief. Beyond the stone arches a new wave builds, a blue mound eager to burst white foams across the jagged maze of healing pools.

~~~

Melwais had bought me here, to my pool. She had taken my broken leg and straightened it, tied it to my other leg and knotted both in a supple bark she brought to the tunnel. She explained how she had taken a man's axe to a tree to gather branches as she wove those very branches together with

thinner strips of bark. Then she attached my body to the top of the frame, ready to drag me down to the sea.

A sled! Much like the sled I was planning to build for Chick. I refused to admit that the results of her efforts looked – better, more fitting to the idea of a sled – than my smaller frame of twigs and struts would have been.

That journey was a whole race of pain! Easiest to cast out that recall to sit with the other happenings I wish to un-know.

"We can't stay here! This fucking stone is rank!"

The giant ones are arguing, away from the fire that Sam and Maak still tend. The wind has shifted a little, as if it wants to blow their words into my ears.

"Mebbe you need to build a better shield, keep the place out of your thoughts?"

The man seems upset. He stares at the woman with a defiance in his frame I've never seen before.

"My shields are fine! You want to check them? Send one of your little spider bits into my skull to test their strength?"

She's shaking her head. "Then what's eating you, Heszc?"

"Everything! The wind, the water. The fucking sand! This place is – it's poison! We can't stay here!"

"We ain't gonna stay here, lad. In and out, remember? Grab the boy and get back to where we belong."

"Kal – yeah. Grab Kal and run home. But what of the others? Are we taking them too?"

"Fuck 'em! Leave 'em – leave 'em to that woman who dragged Kal here."

"Aherrket won't like that idea."

The fact that a man and a woman can stand in anger, their faces so close, and one hasn't taken a knife to the other ... this is a fantastic jape! I have both eyes on them now.

"Aherrket ... do you even know what that one wants? I don't ... not a fucking clue, me! Did you tell him about our plans?"

The man takes a step back, lets his shoulders ease into a puzzled shape.

"Of course not. I barely know him. I thought it was your idea to bring him with us."

"My ...? No. You, me and Boude. I told you to bring Yorga – that's the sum of us!"

"Where are they now?"

"Still up in the hills. Searching, Yorga says."

"Searching for what? Kal's here – you told them that?"

"Course I told 'em! Soon as the fiskie speared him I was sending the words!"

The wave that suddenly washes over me is strong enough to push me from my ledge and across the pool. I let it carry me forward, lean my good elbow onto rock when I reach it.

Both giants have relaxed their stances when my eyes fix on them again, with a little more distance between them. The woman – Mada – has cocked her head as if to listen better to her Inner Voice. The man has his head turned away, checking on the fire, the brothers who tend it.

~ There's more of these giants?

It is a wasted question. The old crab is elsewhere, it seems, too busy with crab things to answer me. The idea of more giants roaming the High Domains, which is currently hidden from my eyes in a cloak of clouds, worries me.

'Where do they come from, these giants?' my Inner Voice wonders, safe in the space of my skull.

They are giants. I have no doubt of that truth. After Melwais left me in this pool, the giant called Aherrket had joined me in the pool, examined my flesh with care. I saw him standing on the pool's sandy floor, and his head was higher than mine as I rested on the stone shelf. Three long hands taller than me, perhaps? Or four?

Caxtcheh told me later that he had asked many questions about me, asked if enough of my flesh could be preserved to keep my Vital Breath secure from the pools.

Aherrket rarely walks on the land. He treads awkwardly, as if each step is across flint flakes. The other two giants lack his height, but not by much. They would easily reach over me. They certainly beat Sam and Maak for size, in all dimensions – both of my new brothers look like saplings against Aherrket.

Though Chick, my third new brother, near matches the giants' height now he has reformed his flesh – but Chick has no flesh to his bones; too thin in his blue-black skin, that one. He can barely balance on his feet, and the only sound he makes is a single word: "Maaton! Maaton! Maaton!"

Caxtcheh also told me that only Aherrket, of these giants, shares all-sense with her. The man called Heszic does not know how to all-sense. The woman ... Caxtcheh doesn't like the woman. Caxtcheh says she is from Fuebe – which is a new word to me – and people from Fuebe are built too wrong. Like the tullerscup, but far more tricky.

I was surprised the crab knew about tullerscups. Learning that those monsters can roam in water just as easily as they roam on land scared me more than the call of Melwais butchering me for lunch!

Mada doesn't look like a tullerscup. But then a roil of those bugs can look like anything when they put their many angled bodies to it.

Tullerscups are far worse than caddiwhips. At least the rats sing to each other as they hunt you.

Boude. Yorga. These are more nonsense sounds in my ears. But my Inner Voice does not trip over them. They are like words I know, but cannot recall. Like *lightning*, and *thunder*, before I discovered a use for those sounds.

The wind has changed direction again. It blusters tell me only that rain will soon come; the clouds hiding the High Domains are darkening already.

I wonder if the words of my Inner Voice are like caddiwheels that sing in my skull? Or perhaps they're a tullerscup swimming through the sticky jelly of my brain ...?

~~~

"You've stopped screaming then?"

I float on a bed of bladder-kelps. This pool is much larger than the healing pools. I know this because someone told me the fact as they settled me onto the bladder-kelps. It is not a healing pool: this pool, they had said, I think they said ... I like bladder-kelp; I don't remember meeting it before, except as dried heaps blown onto the sand after a storm. This kelp is wet and floaty; I can lie on it and float with my face to the sky which still cries in fat, slow drops ...

There's a chuckle in my throat. I share it with with the voice.

"Ahh," says the voice. "Melwais said you'll still be confused for a while yet. She gave you mushrooms before the crabs got to work."

"Sky move," I agree. I like the way words come out of my mouth. I recall a woman jiggle and knead at my jaw, soft fingers jiggling, kneading, her face close to mine so close to kiss but not close I ache for kisses ...

"You kiss?" I ask the face when I see it. It is a very long face, long like the sky and the cloud and the long patter of rain on water. And ugly that face, if long can be ugly, a fuzz of a long face with teeth in lips that don't shut to a line perhaps not a face to kiss ...

"She wasn't joking! I've witness some weirdness in my time but you, Kal, you are flying in loops!"

And the clouds cry and drops on my face and heat in my eyes and a chuckle caught in my throat, hurting: "My leg, poor leg they eat it now!"

And a hand catches the bladder-kelps and pulls me towards the face now big and wide and ... worried? ... and says: "It's done now, Kal. Rest, lad. Sleep if you can" and the bladder-kelps rock and I rock and the sky rocks so gentle and smooth and a shame of tears in my eyes which I let close ...

~~~

Heszic is a strange giant. Not that I know many giants: three is the limit of my knowing, when it comes to giants.

"Tar hart!" To press the point home, I pull my face away from the morsel of steamed fish Heszic is offering me.

I am, once more, vertical, though still stood in water. My latest pool is not a healing pool; it is not a rough hole chiselled into the sharp, semi-submerged reef that marks the whole of my gang's healing area. Instead it sits at the edge of the reef, its floor a wide length of sand that ends at the beach beyond waves where we used to mend our nets and cook our fish.

Heszic does not like the water. I watched him lift each foot high as he waded towards me with the food – a steam of mud slumberers mixed with chunks of sourscape root; whoever cooked it un-called to add herbs.

"If you don't like it, starve!"

"Yer dahn like it. Cark bad. Whar? Mada?"

The giant translates in his head, then grins: "Mada cook? The bitch doesn't know one end of a skewer from another! All she does is moan: *I need chocolate; I want pocket food'* ..."

I cock my head to one side, ignoring the complaints from my healing jaw: "Chahk-let?"

"You don't remember chocolate?"

"... Nah."

A moment of wonder crosses the man's face, quickly followed by a swipe of concern and a click of understanding.

"Mada did warn me; Aherrket, too, in his own way."

"Hah?"

"Aherrket? What was it he said? *'The shoal is scattered too wide for Kal to swallow – the story of Kal needs to gather and sing'* ... or something like it. That one speaks in riddles even he don't understand, I reckon!"

Aherrket has been keeping his distance from me, since the crabs severed me from my leg. The huge man had held me tight in the water while Melwais forced a paste of mushrooms into my mouth, then tighter still while the crabs stripped and cleared the bad flesh from my leg, clipped the bone free, patched skin around stump and weaved the flaps into scars. My contribution to the event was to scream, though the mushrooms did excellent work: I recall little in the way of pain, just an excess of terror.

Heszc holds the pile of food in his giant hand, wrapped in a couple of sculler leaves. Which makes a faint jape of sense. I hold out my thumbless hand and signal with my eyes that I'll feed myself, holding the wrap in my eating hand and pushing lumps of food into my mouth with my wiping hand.

'A perfect description of my state,' my Inner Voice agrees.

"Where get Chahk-let?" I ask. "Taste gued?"

"Where? It's an Outer World thing, chocolate. I've never met it in a stone. Recent, too, as things go. Do you remember the Outer World? You've been there often enough."

I consider his question, then offer him a slow nod of agreement.

"Cahld," I tell him. "Ver cahld. What stehn?"

"What's a stone?"

"Yer. Stehn."

The stare he offers me has wide eyes to it.

"Fuck, Kal! You don't know about stones? The Band?"

I take a lump of sourscape and huff on it before pushing it into my mouth.

"Nah."

"The stones – they're the Worlds Within Worlds. This place, Fol Huun, is a stone. Or at least it was a stone until the Band lost it. But it has to be part of the Band again. When we met with Mada in the Place Beyond Bounds it was clearly back. It's how we got here ..."

"Fuhl Hun is stone? Fuhl Hun is ... Fuhl Hun!"

"Yes. And Uekh, my stone, is Uekh – complete in itself and a World Within Worlds. You know this, Kal! You've gotta remember the fucking basics! And Mada is from Fuebe. Boude is from Mescwar – you know Mescwar, Kal, you fucking know that! It's your home stone! Mescwar!"

"... Wehrlds Within Wehrlds ..."

I've heard someone say that before. I recall – remember – those words. But where ...?

"Behll!" The man who taught me how to close my true eyes! Now my eyes are wide.

"Bull ...?"

"Yer, Behll! He said I a fehcking dis asteh! He say Wehrlds Within Wehrlds ... Behll!"

The revelation releases a clamp in my bladder. As I risk chewing on a lump of badly cooked fish I look down to see a stream of my bright yellow piss puff into the water beyond my legs – the real leg I stand on, and the leg the crabs took away but still cramps me, beyond its stump.

My bladder's relief brings a smile to my face as I – very gently! – chew.

16. Grussa

The giants made me these things they call 'crutches', which are sticks to walk with. I'm sure they meant well with their gift, but giants are shit at making things.

For a start, one crutch was bigger than the other. Not a lot bigger, just a couple of flat fingers taller than the other. To use these sticks I have to wedge them into my armpits and swing them out as I stand on my leg, then swing my body forward and hop and as soon as my leg lands the sticks swing forward and with a bit of effort I can move.

Except one crutch is taller than the other. Within a thousand hard breaths my armpit was red and sore. Swapping the sticks round solved the problem by making the other armpit equally sore.

I don't recall ever caring about my armpits before, like I care about them now. They won't shut up about their hot hurts!

And another thing: these sticks each have a handle along their length which I have to grasp hard to get the stick moving and set it to the ground. I asked the giants: have you ever tried to grasp something without a japing thumb? It's a real thrust up the arse to swing a stick forward and see it go flying. And while I watch it clatter away I brace my leg to keep me upright and, even though my leg tells me all is good, I still tumble because the leg I'm bracing myself on is the leg the crabs ate!

How can a leg that is definitely not there feel like it's there when I take my eyes away from the stump where it used to be?

Those fucking giants gave me these crutches so they could fucking laugh at me! Fuckers!

I think *fuck* means – it means an intimacy? That's how Sam used the word, before he kissed me and murdered me. Maybe. The giants use the word for a lot of different things, but mostly for 'very', or 'great', or 'jape'. I do like the word, the way it booms from my mouth just when I need a word to show a boom.

The giant's sticks need to go; I can carve better crutches, now I know their shape and use. I've collected a good set of branches to choose from,

dragged them down from the hill using Melwais's sled and piled them here in Vuanna's old grove. If I stare at each one long enough I'm sure the shape of a good crutch will reveal itself to me.

I also have my old knife and flints by my side again. They had not scattered far from my former flesh, which I found in the woods still with Aherrket's clumsy spear jutting out of my – no, its – chest. It was a few dozen breaths' work to pile the corpse on top of the sticks so I could push and drag it down to the beach.

The crabs have had my leg; they might as well feast on the rest of me!

~~~

Vuanna, I have come to realise, was not the same as the other women. This nest, which was her nest, is very different from Achoa's nest. For a start, it lies amid great boulders, and has a thick weave of live briars for a roof, while Achoa's nest was built in the boughs of a tree at the centre of her grove.

Though I've had to put in some hard work to clear briar canes from the space: it's easier to hack them out than weave them back into the roof. I did get a good harvest of berries for my effort!

Vuanna and Achoa, now I have a long, sweaty chance to recall both women, were different in many ways. Achoa's skills with a needle were excellent; her potions and balms were a natural part of her work. Achoa ... she fitted her grove as well as the tree in which she built her nest.

Vuanna ... she didn't fit. This nest is settled at the very edge of the forbidden area; it is guarded by thick stands of sharp reeds threaded with paths containing some very painful traps. Which makes sense, it being so close to the desolate rockfalls and tunnels that stretch (as I have learned) in a jagged line from the shore all the way up to the High Domains.

Dangerous monsters find shelter in that treeless length!

But I realise now, with my long recall, that Vuanna had the know of many things which other women cared not to know. The making of fire sticks, for instance, which scratch against rock and flower into flame, was a

speciality of hers. But she also had the know of many other strange powders and grindings that no plant or animal flesh contained.

My glassy blades, lost a couple of renewals ago – I recall it took me several attempts, and an unexpected visit to the healing pools, to thief similar knives from this nest.

"Why aren't you dead? Why am I alive again?"

The thick branch I hold between my thighs has a good heart, but I'm struggling to pull the shape of a crutch from it. The hand axe I'm using to chip wood from wood feels wrong in my wiping hand and the little blows I deliver lack the force to pull out the clean curls I expect.

It is annoying, but I persist.

"I know you can hear me, monster! I know I'm dead, too!"

The giants give me space, but no trust. Always there is someone in the grove to keep eyes on me. They've learned, for the most part, to stay in the grove. I threw a knife at Mada when she came too close – a clumsy throw but good enough: it caught her arm and drew blood.

That was a fine moment! I heard many new words in the following dozen breaths, very angry words. I look forward to learning their meaning, and shaping them in my mouth!

"Why won't you talk to me?"

Sam currently has the duty of keeping his eyes on me. He is being very brave, crouching low by the nest's entrance. He doesn't deserve my words, hasn't earned a right to them. I could tell him this, tell him to *fuck off*, but right at this moment the needs of the wood are greater than the needs of the man.

"Please! I need to make sense of it all!"

I bring the hand axe down gently, push it into the branch's flesh, watch a good curl of wood grow before my hand shakes too soon, releasing it to the floor before it is done.

"Don't speak then! I like it when you don't speak. You never stopped talking when you were in my head. Always muttering away to yourself."

It seems as if brother Sam has a need for words himself. I recall his refusal to stay quiet when we met the flayman, in the avenue. Those words found a purpose in the end; they serve no purpose now, except to mask more important sounds from the grove.

"I heard you, you know, even when you thought you had 'blanked' me so you could use my body to do stuff. At first I was terrified – thought I was going mad! But after a while you just became annoying. So. Fucking. Annoying!"

I shift the log between my thighs, turning it to bring the next place to chisel into line with my axe.

"I remember Mada."

... What?

"Hah! Now you're looking at me! I remember lots of things about when I was alive. I remember Marc, and I remember you. And Mada – that's her name, yeah?"

I feel a new knot begin to form in my gut. My flesh is telling me I need to pay attention the man, though much of what he says is nonsense. Yet my ears itch at the distraction: this is still a woman's nest, a woman's grove; all of my senses need to be aware of everything!

Sam shifts, slowly, takes a few breaths to move just past the nest's entrance, closer to me. He still crouches.

"She looked a lot different then, like ..." He struggles a moment to find words to match his vision "... Like a really old woman who moved too young for her age. But she was still a bitch, a gobby bitch who talked just like she talks here in this nightmare. 'Pocket food' and 'horsies' like she's a five year old kid."

My ears are caught in his story, my eyes set on his shape as he eases his back against the boulder wall. Only the hairs on my neck pay attention



to what lies beyond the nest. My hairs are unhappy; does something approach?

Slowly I let my thumbless hand fall from the branch it was clamping to my thigh. My fingers land directly on the cool sharpness of my larger axe.

Sam is in love with his words, it seems: "Yeah I remember lots of things. More things than Marc remembers. You know he's forgotten what writing is? I was trying to remember letters so I wrote my name in the sand. He was all 'what's that' and when I told him it was my name he didn't believe me! He's forgotten the fucking alphabet! I asked him to draw a picture of me in the sand and ... he doesn't know what 'draw' means! He's fucking losing it, man ... he ain't Marc no more!"

I can't throw the big axe with my damaged hand. I know this; I've been practicing. But I have worked out a way to hold it between my palm and my fingers, which should be good enough to cut the man should he move too close.

Still, I would prefer the option to throw the axe. Brother Sam is not the only danger here: my nape and my gut knot are certain of this.

"I remember Marton, too. You remember Marton, Kal? That's your name, isn't it? Kal. That's what Mada called you in the real world, and she still calls you that now. You call you 'Kal', too. That's how I know you're the monster that lived in my head ..."

*'... What the fuck?'*

"Oh don't you dare give me that look! Fuck you, you are a monster! I know what you did to Marton!"

My eyes have indeed widened. They fix on the man's face like a sting-flower sticks to its crab's shell. I see his stubble of sand-stained hair, the mark of unwashed mud across his brow. I notice a battle behind his eyes, the struggle he performs to wrestle his words from his throat.

"I was there, remember, when you jumped into that Marton's head and brain fucked the poor sod! I watched you drag half of him back into my head, like a dog rolling in shit and then curling up on my bed."

He suddenly smiles: "I enjoyed feeling all the bits of Marton damage you. You shoved what was left of him in a mind palace thing – took you days and days to fix yourself!"

Sam's words make as much sense as the guardian's dance song to me. All I know is that, whatever they mean, Sam believes in the worth of his words passionately. His stare is complete, consuming all the need he has, when he should spare need for his other senses ...

... Too late!

"He put me in a cave. An old woman's cave. Shallow, it was, and bare. Very cold – barely room for a hearth and that was just sticks and ash. The woman was so scared, so weak: she had her arms around her head as he stabbed at her head, her face – so much blood from such a frail old woman!"

Sam is throwing himself backwards away from the entrance. He flails his arms behind him, leaving his belly exposed to the danger.

*Idiot!* is the word in my skull. Not Sam. Me! How dare I let myself be so unprepared!

I shove against the ground with both hands to clear space for my real leg to bend tight to my arse, ready to push me forward to the attack. Already I have the branch I was carving well balanced in my wiping hand, level and ahead of me.

Melwais stands at the entrance.

She does not crouch. She does not hold her limbs tense. I search her shape for weapons; her fingers seem relaxed ... but women have no need for weapons to bring their quarry down. Hands are sometimes enough – shit, even voice is enough!

"Why did you choose that Dream Sight for me, Kal, when I sought refuge within you?"

... And suddenly I am still, my flesh locked and rigid as the woman's spoken Dream Sight traps me. A recall of blood steals air from my chest.

I can see the old woman. She is solid in front of me; her screams are the only thing I can now hear.

I know this woman! She is my mother's own mother. She protects our family with her charms and her herb-lore. She was – is – preparing a moonlight medicine as I come to her.

I recall I chased her here; so hungry I am, and so cold, and the horror that rummages through my head, that confuses me with impossible lights, that urges me on to find food, take food ... that tries to smash my mind, my history of me ... wants me to kill! Wants me to wallow in this monstrosity; wants to reshape me, make me a horror ... she laughs?

Yes. Yes! She laughs at me, at what she can make me do. She humiliates me as she takes control of my arm, my hand, sweeps the knife at my grandmother's neck. Makes me squeeze choked laughs from my throat as blood arcs from the wound to cover me, cover the walls of the old woman's chanting space.

"NO!"

I have never! never! never! felt such rage!

I know this ... this *thing* in my head ... I know her name!

She is – was – Grussa. Grussa the hateful. Grussa the hurtful. Grussa the echo of mirth, the whisper of shame, in my head.

She came to me from the Band as the metal magician, who was dying, slipped the string necklace from which it hung over my head. She came like a storm into my skull and cracked me apart. She took my limbs and my seven summers of flesh and, and ... she wrecked me!

So far she walked me, through day and night.

Sometimes she would let me eat, drink. Sometimes she would let me pull down my leggings to shit, though not always, and never to piss. We walked together, me with my sodden legs and her with her japing whispers, until I dropped to the ground.

She kept me from people, from help. She made me steal from good, decent, honest – whole – people. She made, made me push sharp, sharp

thorns through my cheeks, my lips – my ... (my tackle) – push and bleed so she could, could take joy from my stabs, my pain ...

I recall, recall ...

She called her friends out from the Band so they too could enjoy this jape, this joke on me. Soon there was four of them, each with their own flesh. They came from far-away places called *Fuebe* and *Tincas* and *Spoy*, each hidden in its own stone hugged into the metal amulet.

I ... I watched her summon them each in turn from the red stone, the green, the bright one – pull sparks that flew from the stones into the heads of travellers and hunters we met, yes met along the river's wide, muddy bank. I watched people collapse and change and rise, rise again ... broken, different.

They played together, these monsters in their flesh garments. They played with me as I lay shattered and, and trapped in my own skull. As the men turned me on my belly and took me hard, I let a part of me scream, let other parts of me come back into me. The weather turned cold. I turned cold. I built a rage in me, I recall this thing now: an angry rage, yet cold. A rage became me and as, as rage I waited, and gathered, and waited.

And still we walked on, four monsters and me, with piss and shit spoiling my legs.

Snow came and my thing, my hate yes, it became winter. I know this now. Snow scattered across the highest hills; puddles grew the thinnest sheets of ice each morning, just before a cold sun rose. Often the sky cried, and, and ... I liked that. I took comfort that the sharp rain was real, was my mother's tears perhaps. I imagined I saw her, sometimes, a quick face in the fast clouds here, and here.

Grussa the monster didn't notice me anymore. I recall she turned her words from me to her friends as they walked, more and more and not good words. A monster in a man who enjoyed rolling my flesh onto my belly too much said, he said they should take a boat south, to some place where the clouds were scared to go. Grussa said she liked cold mists and made me pick up a sharp rock and, and smash it into the man's head while he slept. I saw, no watched a red spark seep from the rock-shattered skull as the not-a-man lost the skills to breathe; I heard the monster's words, curses as it drifted

back to the amulet that still hung on its reed twine around my ... yes, my neck.

I killed my mother's own mother ...

"NO!"

I murdered my grandmother. I know this thing now.

Grussa did not kill her; I did. Grussa just made me carry the knife in my seven summer hand as she finished the job. Perhaps she enjoyed it, or enjoyed feeling me break, again, break as the knife sliced life from flesh? Perhaps she missed me, yes, and liked me again more than her friends?

I murdered my grandmother. As the sun guttered on one horizon, the moon was rising on the other, fat and full. A special night. Grussa lifted my legs in turn away from the river and towards the hills. I knew these hills, their shapes in the sky: my family's hills, my hills. I told Grussa this but she had her friends and didn't hear me.

A special night for special medicines. I saw a woman walking through the ice-tipped grasses and knew beyond doubt that my grandmother was walking towards her special place.

My grandmother!

Grussa heard that pulse, caught my shout, my shivered joy. Suddenly, again, she knew I existed. I felt her anger as a shudder; I ... I welcomed it?

By seeing my grandmother, I expose my joy. Because I am noticed, am I not seen? Look how I am here!

Grussa does not care that my muscles are wasted and my belly is fat from starvation. She pushes me to an edge and forces my flesh to run towards the woman who taught me how to turn every chore into a game. She clasps a stolen flint knife into my fist and shows me how to stick it in flesh. *'Do it,' she whispers, 'do it yourself, do it hard and again and harder and bring me joy!'*

As Grussa laughs and calls for her friends to come see what she has done she, she lets go of my flesh. I collapse into my grandmother's body. Into her blood. 'NO!', I cry, free to use my voice. 'NO!'

And still there's a pulse in the old woman's body, air in her lungs. Pity ... pity? Yes, pity in her, in her eyes.

I hear ... I hear her last, long whisper in my ear: "Oh, Kheil, we thought you were dead! But this is not you."

And then: "You must recall your uncle, the hole we put in his head, yes?"

And at last: "Know always you are loved, little Kheil. I love you!"

My uncle, I recall him. Spooky Uncle. He lived because a healer chipped a hole in his head. I *remember*. As Grussa reaches out to her friends, I take my skull and smash it hard into the cave's smooth wall. I smash it again. As Grussa tries to trap me in spin, I collapse to the floor.

The cave's smooth floor is covered in a scatter of strong herbs. After the healer chipped a hole in Uncle's head, grandmother had fed him herbs and mushrooms.

I lick the floor. I feel my Grussa's ... perplexity? The spin she forms in my skull should leave me screaming as it has done before: smell as color as vision as whisper all together in spin-trapped madness!

'*This is not right,*' she says. Still my tongue, my jaws and lips, are mine. I lick the floor again, gather as many spilled herbs and dried mushrooms into my mouth as I can fit. I swallow as grandmother told uncle to swallow: no chewing, just swallow.

And ... and ... and ... she slips?

I feel Grussa slip! I see inside me talons in the white of a fish's flesh and the fish flexes and the talons ... slip? The talons ... they melt like frost on the morning puddle. Grussa swears, her favourite words; she screams? She slips again!

I feel-watch an icy shape fall from my face. I feel-watch it try to grow wings, to take flight into the frost air but already the Band has her – a thin

rope reaches-reached from the stone with no color, the one that looks like a dazzle of water caught in a chalk stream's drop. As it catches her I catch ... I catch it too?

I feel a sear of a line and, and I take it to me. I see the wings of Grussa shrink with her as she draws near to the stone? I want her gone! I need her friends gone, the friends that like to roll me onto my belly so they could ... they can ...

I remember my grandmother's whispers, the sad smile I sometimes spot in clouds, an arch of blood. I tell ... no, I beg the rope to find Grussa's friends, to take them with her, away from this place.

The stone – Spoy? yes Spoy of the glassy depths – it speaks ... yes, it speaks to me!

It asks if I, too, would like to come. I say: yes. I say: I watched my mother and father and cousins die. I say: I crushed a man's skull with a rock. I say: look! I have murdered my grandmother.

I tell Spoy the impossible light ... I tell it, no Him – I tell Him that I am happy to have seven summers in my face, but an eighth summer would be too much.

I know these words now, here in Vuanna's nest!

Spoy took Grussa and her friends. Then He took my limbs and my flesh and stood me upright and told me to walk: *'Meet me at the top of the hill,'* He said.

'Yes,' I said.

I recall the long climb up that hill, where snow was gathering already. I recall the shouts and screams of my wide family and friends as they discovered the healing-woman I had murdered, as they called to their dogs and followed the tracks of my seven summers feet stumble-climbing the hill.

At the top of the hill I ... I pulled the reed string loops from my neck and held the amulet – the Band – in my hands. I can see it now. I called to the stone – to Spoy ... but the stone was muddied with milk and snow, no longer clear like water, and He would not answer me. As if He was gone. A

wind came across the hill's brow, blowing sheets of snow into shapes of ghosts, their howls drowning out the shouts of hunters and barking dogs far below.

I walked, lost. And then I knelt, tears frozen into my face. When I lay down, the wind and the snow hugged me, whispered sweet nothing into my ear ...

"NO!"

... So cold on that hill. So, so *fucking* cold!



## 17. "Water Speaks To Water"

"Marton. Marton!"

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak! Ak!"

"Marton!"

I thought the guardian had come to visit me, lying here in the not-healing pool on my bed of bladderwracks. I was wrong. The guardian only has eyes and voice for Marton the Chick. He stands in shallow water near a rock and says his word, sometimes quiet, sometimes loud. The guardian, perched on the rock, responds in kind.

This is an improvement on the bird's previous visit, where it had hopped onto the seaweed and forced its beak into my mouth. I can still taste its unwelcome vomit!

My head is hot. My whole body is hot.

*«You shake because you are rotting»*

*~ You told me this already.*

*«The rot grows in you. This is not a good thing»*

I glance at my visitor, who is busy knotting the weed to the wall of rock protecting me from waves. Caxtcheh has been away in deeper water to moult, she told me. Crabs do not moult often, but they like to moult together.

*~ You really hold a healing pool in your tail?*

*«Yes»*

*~ Who is in it?*

*«Melhaget has joined me for his healing. He is a good weaver; I enjoy his company»*

*~ How did he ... did he ...?*

"Marton ...?"

*«It was his fifth moult – males always fight after their fifth moult – they all need healing after»*

*~ Even the winner?*

*«Yes! It is the crab way»*

*~ But females do not fight?*

*«No – we feast – we welcome the Vital Breaths of our friends to come heal with us»*

Her new shell does look magnificent, especially the carapace, whose spread of iridescent colours make her look – *younger?* – than when I last saw her; she also has two eyes again, as if to prove my fear of losing my leg was a wasted worry.

"Ak! Ak! Ak!"

*~ Because eating the spent male flesh is the crab way, I say. ~ What does my brother say to the guardian?*

The crab pauses her knotting for a moment: *«They say nothing – the man has no words in his head – the bird cannot lay an egg of understanding in him because there are no words – they make noises at each other»*

The sky feels hot; there's little cloud to darken its even, lilac roof. This worries me. I shift my head so I can rest my cheek into the drying, pungent mat of weeds and watch the crab resume her work.

*~ Women do not wait for men to end each other before they feast, not on land.*

*«You have been consumed many times – but always your Vital Breath was free of your flesh first»*

*~ Not always ...*

Caxtcheh swivels her new eye stalk in my direction: *«Women sometimes forget that they are crabs – they stray too far from the water; they weave many things, but they do not Weave»*

I find myself un-calling the lack of wind, this worktime. Fol Huun barely whispers and all directions lie.

*~ They weave ... and they don't weave ...?*

"Mar! Marton! Ton Marton!"

*«A weave of twine and sinews is not a Weave – a weave of barks and feathers is not a Weave – women who were crabs weave but they do not Weave»*

*~ Men weave. I can weave nets!*

*«A net is not a Weave – you do not Weave – you have seen a Weave and it was not a net»*

I've seen ...? Ohh!

*~ You made me look at an image at the bottom of the healing pool. I recall that thing. Was that a Weave?*

The crab looks pleased ... how, I don't know. Perhaps a shift of its legs as they clasp to the rock? Maybe the tightening of a knot or the twitch of a stalk?

"Ak! Ak! Ak-ak! Ak!"

*~ I wish I had never looked at it! It has broken me more than any rot in my leg!*

*«You are not broken – you mend»*

"I ... mend?"

No! *~ I rot! My head is infested with bad Dream Sights, images of lies. Had I closed my eyes, refused that sight, I could be far away from giants and crabs. I could be meeting new brothers, earning my place at their cooking hearths with a net of fish, sharing a jape as we carve spears ... a canoe!*

I am impressed by my fevered anger!

*~ All denied to me by your refusal to let my flesh set still and stiff and cold! You fuckers torture me and, and you say nothing for why ...!*

If the crab still hears me, she doesn't show it. Two legs lift from the rock and stretch, and settle. Then two more. Then four at once to bring the greater claw and the lesser claw closer to the next place where weed can be knotted to rock.

~~~

Silence. I can hear my bones shake. Each spasm starts in my neck, my shoulders, and taps its way down my spine into my hips and my legs ... my leg. So noisy, my bones!

The clouds have come and smothered me. I can barely see shapes on the beach; the sentinel rock is gone, whitened like bones by the cloud.

The cloud is cool, damp. I like this cloud. It even smothers the stench of my kelp raft, my rotting flesh.

The smell of me ... no, do not dwell on the smell. Think of other things! Think of the Race, of my brothers in line before and behind me as we haul on our oars, push our canoe almost to flight between waves as we strive to beat the other gang, fight to reach the celebration beach first.

Think of glorious things, Kal!

This sea is so, so flat. The wind is gone and the water has no friend to play with, no dance of water here. The cloud is cool and silent. Like my last Race ...

'Do you recall your last Procession?'

Melwais had asked me that question: *'Do you recall your last Procession? The time I came to your strand to lead you and your brothers to the place of the Race?'*

Yes. I recall it. I recall her soft arms, her kiss. My bones had shaken then, too, but in different ways.

'Do you recall her summons?'

There is no know of a summons within me. I felt nothing but lust at that moment, and what I took to be pleasure in the woman's flesh – the way she stiffened and curved herself backwards, curved her neck – and held her breath long, too long and she shook once, twice and her eyes became, became ... white?

I recall shaking her limbs from my body as I stood up. Around me I could see my brothers-in-Procession, some alone, some in groups. No hint of wind. No shiver of rock. No sound.

I found Leic, our leader, but his flesh was empty. I hunted for Jiar, my friend. He sat with some brothers around a small hearthstone, its fire still consuming wood but the flame's smoke rose in a line straight up, and Jiar was gone.

Was there an anger in me? A rage? Melwais claimed that it was so ... but Melwais also claimed she hid her Vital Breath behind my face and that ... that is a jape of a claim! Who hides behind faces?

... Grussa hid behind my face ...?

No! Think of glorious things!

I ... this was a jape of the worst taste, I recall telling myself, my brothers all pretending to have left their bodies to cavort together in a great healing pool.

Maybe I was angry. I did kick Jiar quite hard, several times, but all he offered me was a slow topple into the fire. Leic ... I didn't kick. I sat beside Leic and shouted questions into his face – he refused to answer.

I recall my decision.

This was a Procession. We had a duty. I had a duty and I would perform that duty. I found our magnificent canoe. I found the oar I had carved and lashed it to the canoe with twine. I took one end of the canoe onto my shoulder and I Processed, as was my duty!

I Processed for many, many, many hundreds of steps. My feet knew the way, and my body owned the luck that kept predators from attacking me as I hauled the canoe to the sea.

So calm, that sea, as I pushed the canoe into the water, gathered my oar and stepped into the Race. There was a cloud on the water, though that cloud was hot – a steam of a cloud that brought me to a quick sweat. I paddled. I rowed hard! I knew the course of the Race, the great cliffs of the headland, the bay with its celebration beach beyond. I rowed hard towards the beach, my oar breaking the smooth mirror of water. I rowed and I paddled and rowed until the canoe drove into the sand and I claimed the prize!

«What was the prize?»

~ Aherrket?

«I am here with you, yes»

~ You hear all my words? You always hear my words?

«No – only these words – only now – what was the prize?»

The prize?

The prize is what the prize always is. An axe. A big one, too. The leader of the winning team wins the right to take that axe and smash the canoes, break them into logs for the celebration fire.

«Did you use the axe?»

I recall ... I stared at that axe for a long, long while. Many breaths. Rightly it was Leic who should wield it. Who was I to put my hand to its shaft, to heft its great stone weight into the canoe's wood?

I used the axe. I cried as the pride of our gang's work shattered, splintered ...

«And then?»

~ I made a flame, brought it to the stack I had built, turned flame into fire ...

... And stepped into it.

... There was no pain. Only love. Fol Huun's love. She saw me, and knew me ...

«And?»

~ *The mountain went: 'boom!'*

«... Boom?»

~ *BOOM!*

As my flesh turned to cinders, the great mountain ... I have never seen such a thing! A great black trunk sprung from the summit as the ground shook and rocks tumbled. Suddenly the water in the bay was a frenzy of foams and steep hills!

My Vital Breath got caught by a storm wind, carried up and high and higher and the great hot black trunk came closer and then I was, I was dancing in searing heat and it ... it hurt me!

It burned me!

~ *It was wrong, this thing, I tell Aherrket. ~ Wrong!*

«What did you do?»

~ *I said ... I said: no!*

No! I do not want this reknow!

«Then open your eyes, your ears – your nose if you have to – remember you still have flesh, you still have breath»

And I can feel my bladderwrack float at my back; I can smell its comforting stench. I can hear the gentle lap of water against rock as my flesh starts another shiver attack. From the beach I can hear voices – loud voices, unhappy voices.

~ *Aherrket – are you really here?*

«Yes»

~ I think I am tired of reknowing. I want to be done with counting breaths.

«Soon, little one – a few more breaths – and a few more»

The mist seems a little thinner; above me the whiteness tints towards lavender. I raise my head to see if the sentinel stone has reappeared – I think I can see a shadow of its shape?

The movement increases the reek of the rotting that sweats from my body. I can no longer feel the stump of my leg; I dare not check the state of my tackle. I can see my hand has blackened, with dark bruises swirling from the place where my thumb used to attach. I can smell sulphur, too, and a hint of guardian vomit and beneath it all, supporting it all, a rot of damp seaweed hauled from its home in deeper waters to suffer its end with me.

~ The other giants argue?

«They are not happy with me»

Aherrket manages impossible things. He catches at my attention, hauls at it.

~ Why do they not like you? I recall the giant Mada's strange words: ~ Is it because you fart out of your head?

«No – they shout because I won't help them»

~ So you don't fart out of your head?

«No»

A ripple of water approaches me. Soft, it is, and quiet. I am not surprised when Aherrket's head breaks through the water near to my raft. As my shoulders command a new clatter of shakes in my bones the man drifts easily towards me.

~ Why won't you help them?

«I cannot help them»

~ You do talk in riddles!

I watch his face fold into a shape of considerations – a slight frown, a small curve of lip.

«We agree that to remain here in this stone is not ideal»

~ You mean Fol Huun?

«Yes – Fol Huun is unhappy – we must depart – but the journey to the lodestone and the Place Beyond Bounds will take much time»

I have no idea what a Place Beyond Bounds is. Maybe a cave? It is not important, I decide, as I admire the way my remaining foot jerks at the end of my last leg.

~ ... And?

«Water speaks to water»

He must see the confusion sweat from my face.

«We can leave this stone now, together, because water speaks to water – this water speaks to the water of Ounous, the water of Mescwar»

~ This is a good thing, then?

«No – the others wish for you to be taken to Mescwar – they say it is where you belong»

~ Mescwar is like Fol Huun?

«Mescwar is very different to Fol Huun – Mescwar ... is Mescwar»

I try to think for a breath, and another.

~ You do not want us to go to Mescwar.

«I will not ask the water of Fol Huun to talk to the water of Mescwar»

~ Where, then?

«Ounous – you are known in Ounous, and seen, and loved – Ounous is where you belong»

Ounous ... is just a word, some sounds in the mouth and ear that trigger ... nothing. But so works *Mescwar*, and *Fuebe*, and even *Uekh* – though I recall that when brother Geit spoke that word his eyes gained a deep, lost sadness in their focus.

~ How ...?

«How are you known?»

I manage a nod of my head that is not a shake.

«You are part of the Song»

More confusion must seep from my pores.

«Recall your Dream Sight, the moment you said 'no' to the mountain»

~ When the mountain went 'boom'?

«Yes – what happened when you said 'no'?»

~ I do not want that Dream Sight. It is a jape, a lie!

I feel the raft of rotting kelps slope as Aherrket rests the weight of his elbows on it. A hand reaches across my chest and strokes my shoulder.

«The mountain – Fol Huun – laughed at you»

... And I'm there again, in the Dream Sight, an ember among embers dancing in the great bellow of the mountain's vomit. I said, I said 'no' and ... and She refused my decision. Every fleck of my Vital Breath can feel her mirth!

«You refused Her refusal – with your rage you straightened your path away from the burning gyre – you pulled away – you dragged your rage from that place and you found another place, yes?»

~ ... Yes.

«As water speaks to water, so Tintuun speaks to Tintuun – Tintuun was of the Band, then Tintuun was beyond the Band and together with the world, yet still Tintuun speaks to Tintuun»

~ I ... I do not know ...?

«Your story is part of my Song, Kal of Tintuun, and you are part of Ounous, and seen, and loved!»

~~~

To say we swim together ... that is a lie. I keep my head above water as Aherrket swims for us both. The giant moves through water with an ease which surprises me, legs together, arms mostly by his side. I have my good arm over his shoulder and my bad arm clenched to his chest.

We are in deep water already; I have never swum this far away from the shore before, nor even ventured such a distance in a canoe. I can still see land, the mountain's High Domains now free of the mists that cling to the low sea cliffs.

This water is cold: I welcome its rush against my flesh!

We travel in silence. The pressure of Aherrket's all-sense has gone from my head, which is a good thing as I need all my strength to pull each new breath into my lungs. There is a deep need within me to let my eyes close, to welcome sleep.

I barely notice when we slow down, come to a rest.

"This is a good place to ask these waters to speak to the waters of Ounous, yes?"

I do not answer. I have no clue what his words mean, and no strength to speak my own words.

As we stand in water, he loosens my grip and turns me to face him.

"This is the last flex, my friend. I have persuaded the waters to converse close to us, here. When the time comes, soon, we will dive-swim into the stream beneath; I will have a hold of your leg, so you need do

nothing, just relax your flesh. I will bring us to the place where the waters talk."

~ *The crabs ate my leg?*

"Let your lungs empty of air; you have no need for Fol Huun in your chest anymore."

And with that he is gone. I cannot feel if he grasps my foot; all I know is that one moment my eyes are in air and the next, in water. I feel water move past my face.

I feel a need to breathe.

I let bubbles of air escape from my nose, my reset jaw, my lips – and more air – and more ...

... There is a pain in my ears. A sudden pain! A sharp pain! I open my mouth to protest and the last of my air is gone ...

... There is a COLD! There is a push on my chest, my eyes ...

... My ears, they ... they hammer!

... So fucking cold! Bad cold. "Bad cold," I scream ... "BAD COLD!"

... My chest aches for air. Burns for air. My chest – it opens ...

My throat it burns! My throat it chokes! ~ *Bad Cold!*

ThereIsAPAIN! The Pain ... it is at, on, through me. The Pain is all me.

I jerk, I jerk all ways! I HURT!

IAMAPAIN ... IAMAPAIN ... IAM ... I ...

## 18. The Worm Katsepet

*«Finally we can converse: it has been a long while! Your brain always grew slower; we should have remembered – then again your returns were always a little, hmm, erratic! At least you're here now»*

I am ... tightness.

No.

There is a tightness. There is a ... me.

There is a thing and a different thing: there is the me, and there is the tightness. The tightness is parted from me. The tightness arounds me ...

*«(annoyance) – Too soon, Katsepet, too soon again!»*

... It is a warm tightness, a dark tightness. I am – I have? – a warm, dark tightness at – in? On? – no, around me. Surround me. I am – no, it is – a cozy tightness.

I like this, this ... cozy!

~~~

There is a song in my bones, in my flesh. Or rather a Song. I know many songs, I remember. But this Song is a part of me, and I am a part of It.

All around me, darkness. I know I can open my eyes because when I open my eyes I can feel that they are open. The sting of stale piss helps remind me.

I close my eyes. Just to be sure, I also close my mouth and throat, and push my new-formed lip upwards to cover my nostrils.

My Song needs no words: it thrums in my bones, my web of veins and arteries; its pulse is my heartbeat, its chord the curling coils of my extending guts.

~ Hello, Katsepet!

«Welcome, Kal! Do you draw sufficient nutrients from the mud?»

~ I don't feel hungry, or thirsty, if that is what you mean. Though to be fair I have not yet grown teeth.

«We appreciate the update. Do you remember whether we thanked you for your old flesh?»

~ No. You're welcome to thank me again.

«Of course, of course! Thank you for the gift of flesh you brought to us. We've barely finished our feasting!»

~ You still work with Psattan, Psikenel?

«(consideration) – Psikenel, yes, at times. Psattan, no – they have chosen to coil with themselves and are busy guarding eggs»

~ You chose not to coil with them? I thought you two were destined to coil ...?

I say this to annoy the worm. They and Psattan worked together through necessity rather than joy. Psattan, I remember, was a good source of jokes and gossip. Katsepet can be a little – officious – at times. I already know they will avoid answering my question.

~ So how far along am I? Will we have time for a longer chat?

I feel the worm's legs against the membranes which hold me safe, half-sunk in the mud, almost immediately. Katsepet measures growth in segments, rather than events, which means they need to wrap around me several times to gather my measure.

I think of it as Katsepet's 'welcome home' hug.

«You need at least another five segments, maybe six. This is a very slow growth rate for you. But then your returns are more conventional than this last one – for the most part. We must ask: why arrive from the depths in the flesh of a, a ... was it a dolphin, of all things? A big one, too!»

~ Ah! I say, letting recent events trickle back into my mind. ~ Yes. I came back by ... unofficial ... methods, let's say.

«Unofficial ... should we be worried?»

~ You've eaten the evidence, yes?

«But ... what should we say, should we be asked?»

Worms, I remember, have their own hierarchies, their own politics. It is not my problem.

~ Say: 'water speaks to water'.

«Portentious! We can work with that response. We thank you for the suggestion!»

~ So, old friend. Perhaps you have a few moments to spare for me? I would appreciate your news. And welcome it, of course!

«Of course! Though we have many tasks to our name. What news would you seek?»

I have been imprisoned in bliss for too long. The simple joy of this guardian is a relief. Ounous is not my entirety, whatever the Song may claim.

~ Recent news, Katsepet. The movements of islands, the reckonings of settlements beyond these muds. Proper news, you know: proper Mescwar gossip!

19. The Dragon Bone Path

As mildly annoying as Katsepet can be, they are highly skilled when it comes to work. When the time arrived for me to breathe air they moved my leathery egg through mud to rest against the side of a path. They split the leather with care, using a pair of sharp bristles to make the cuts.

I emerged in water. Soon enough I was free of the membranes and stood on the solid gravel of the path. An elegant return, I mentioned to the worm. My guardian waited until I was fully free of the water before turning their attention to what I had left behind. I shook water from my fur and then settled on my haunches to watch the worm claim their wage.

The guardian worms of Mescwar, I will admit, are stunning beasts! As Katsepet writhes in the shallow water, enjoying the mushroom-like effects from consuming my healing membranes, I can admire all parts of their long body.

"You've grown well, old friend," I tell them.

Their loops make it difficult to be sure, but I would wager the worm is easily four times my length, arms stretched high. The three parts of their body are clearly defined: their tail is smooth, long and engorged, a shimmering light blue that suggests Katsepet will soon be seeking a friend to curl with.

The mid-section – the longest part of them, by far – shows their segments with some pride, each segment's paddles and bristles pulsating in rhythmic waves – resonating with certain movements of the Song still in my bones. The scutes that mark the back of each flattened segment remind me of rich, polished wood while the fronds of the engorged gills that emerge beyond the scute's shorter edges call of delicate feathers: green, blue, gold. Where Katsepet writhes to show their underside I see smooth, white skin – a touch translucent to show a blush of blood beneath.

And the head – such an admirable terror! Here the segments grow deep and round, easily the girth of my new-formed chest. I see the worm's massive jaws, currently wide in ecstasy, and can respect their purpose: I have no doubt that they snapped and diced my former flesh in moments! The colours displayed here are like a slick of oil on water, and extend across

scutes and skin equally, even to the tips of the long nest of tangled feelers beneath the jaws. The line of the worm's edge bristles are sharp knives, yet also nimble like fingers, for which I am grateful.

As I watch, I am mildly surprised that I know what a slick of oil on water looks like. The Song has helped to rebuild me in surprising ways, though there is still work to do.

I could watch Katsepet for an age of breaths! But I am on a path, and paths can be dangerous when walked alone. Leaving them to their mind scramble, I stand tall to investigate my immediate surroundings.

First the sky: amber; cloudless; empty of movement. This is a good sign for a number of reasons.

I relax in my pelt and drop back to my haunches, my knuckles. My fur is still sodden; the shake I give myself starts at my shoulders and quickly travels the length of my spine: my own private storm.

So, a path. Scratching at the pavement I can feel that it is old – the crushed shell is compact and solid, almost rock. Damp patches in ruts and furrows speak of recent rain. I look ahead to check its straightness; I see no bends.

A healing arena, then. But a very old one, which is not good.

I stand upright again and take a long, slow look at my surroundings. Everything around me is flat, brown water, darkening to green in some stretches. I can spot long banks of crusting mud far to my left, and nearer to my right – a few show a blue fuzz of salt sedge along their ridges. The path itself spears straight ahead to the horizon, where brown meets the glowing amber skies. So huge, these skies! My eyes ache to take it all in.

The wind, also, is quiet – an occasional buff of breeze from this direction, then that, unsure of its purpose.

The lack of reef cliffs worries me. I need more height.

I turn to look behind me. Here, the path offers more interest: an arched tunnel of long finger bones, some askew, all tall. Beyond them, the path continues straight towards another flat horizon.

It's an easy decision. I drop back to my knuckles and start moving towards the bones. Slowly at first, at a trot, then faster, letting my feet and knuckles gallop, letting my spine flex and stretch as each leap swallows an ever greater length of path. Now I can feel a wind through my drying fur and it is ... wondrous! The luxury of new muscle, the ease of joint in socket! I hurl myself along the shell track and through the finger tunnel, not slowing until I am several dozen easy breaths beyond it. When I stop, I indulge myself in another shake, then turn to amble back to the bones.

The first few bones I test feel brittle, taste sharp; they do not meet their partner at the apex. I move towards the central part of the arches where a set of more substantial fingers rise up from the muds at the edge of the path to soar into the sky. These are definitely sturdier – they barely move as I shove my weight against them.

I grab one finger that leans a little more than its companions and start to climb. I'm almost halfway up before I realise I have toe thumbs ... oh, storm! How I have missed my toe thumbs! I stop for a moment to look down, admire how they grasp to the bone strut, their flat nails black and still a little soft from their recent formation. I take my weight on my hands, release my feet and draw them upwards, tucking my knees tight to my chest before letting them grasp the strut tight enough to hold my bulk as I reach up, and up, until I am at full stretch. Hands tighten, feet loosen, crunch; hands loosen, feet tighten, stretch. I copy a reed worm climbing its leaf, and I laugh!

When the bone starts to flex under my weight, I halt. From here I can see, as I look around, that this place does have the shape of a healing arena, near perfect in its circularity, its low reefs half submerged yet still separating the shallow brown-green muds within from the deeper opal water beyond. My path is indeed the main path, slicing the arena into two equal halves. I can spot the traces of other, lesser, more degraded paths as they branch away towards the wide pool's perimeter.

In several distant places I spot the ruins of structures, oblong footings that tell of sheds, shacks, work spaces. These all need investigating, I decide, while checking the skies for small dots of movement ...

A splash! Where? Below!

The movement I was not expecting comes from below. Katsepet has spent themselves in ecstasy and now seeks the promise of more. I missed their unravelling, their quick slither to the bony arch, but when they spring into the air, jaws wide for the kill I, too, leap like a toad into the air, my aim for the bones on the other side of the arch true and solid.

~ Katsepet! That was uncalled for!

«(chagrin) – we thought we had overcome such juvenile reactions. Your egg was more potent than we expected»

~ So this attack is my fault?

«You always had a rich edge of difference to you, we remember this now»

The guardian's attack may have been precise; their fall back to the muddy waters is less elegant. They splash down at an angle, segments still tightening as they impact.

~ That must have hurt!

«A deserved pain, we admit. And a good lesson»

~~~

Most of the healing arena's edge is submerged, a wide wall of mud-covered rock, which makes movement along its top edge both painful and dangerous. It hadn't taken me long to decide that swimming was a better option.

The water beyond the rock is, thankfully, deeper. The arena's edge drops steeply into the milky green water. When I dropped beneath the surface I discovered I was blind.

I am still too new to this flesh; it lacks the ability to sound its surroundings. To click shape and edge to the rocky perimeter – it's what I do, a thoughtless reflex ... but not anymore!

*«The echo sense does seem like a sensible approach»*

Katsepet considers that we are settled between us: where once they owed us a debt for trying to end my flesh, they have now compensated by saving the same flesh from drowning.

*~ There's no light in the depths of Ounous, I tell him. ~ Eyes are not enough.*

All I can taste is grit in my teeth, from my attempt to generate the click stream. The water I swallowed as I choked has less salt than the arena's water, but still holds a rich mix of mud in its weight.

*«We cannot understand why you would place such high reliance on this 'seeing' thing. We have so many senses we can barely keep track of them all»*

*~ You have eyes. Too many of them!*

*«The least of our entirety. Vestiges from when we were food, nothing more»*

*~ You were never food!*

*«Many times we were food, almost. Fish will eat anything»*

With the guardian's help, I'm approaching what I hope is the largest of the structures that I spotted while swinging from the dragon's finger bone.

I thank Katsepet for their help to push me through water, and attempt to move towards land. Again my memory and my flesh fight: my new form also lacks the ease of swimming. Thankfully I haven't forgotten the old coordinations I need to apply, to remain afloat and moving. The result is not pretty – my splashes precede me, knock silt from stone as I move forward.

I still have the map of the healing arena in my mind, from what I saw atop the bony arch. If this arena is like the one I remember, the structure I seek would once have been a store with two rooms, one atop the other.

But I also know the building's bricks will be gone, dissolved back into the water. From my low position in the water I have to guess which of the protruding shoals contains the remnants of the shape I seek.

*~ So your eyes don't work?*

*«Light and dark: it was enough to know when food moved close to us»*

*~ Not everything that moves close to your eyes is food.*

*«This is a truth»*

I emulate a toad, extend my arms and pull in my legs, breathe as my head leaves the water; move my arms wide and straighten my legs, closing my eyes as water engulfs my face. Another stroke. And a third, a fourth.

*~ I can't imagine you ever being small enough to be food.*

*«We barely remember it. Most food perishes before they learn their name»*

This shoal does look promising. It has a long shoulder of rock pushing through its mud. The tufts of mixed sedges and reeds that I can glimpse between strokes hint at substantiality.

I spot an outcrop of stone approaching, let my body glide towards it. Once I have solid rock in the grasp of both hands, I flex my muscles and leap cleanly into the air.

*~ I don't remember eating any young worms like you, when they bit my ankles.*

*«That was considerate»*

*~ I'd just throw them far from me, then go find someone to help me remove their heads from my flesh.*

*«A sensible approach. Food that is too eager to attack deserves such an end»*

There's enough space on this spur to let me knuckle down and shake myself less wet. I check the skies before indulging in a second shake. Then I settle on my haunches and examine the plants closest to me. None of them are nut sedges, and none have seed heads. Not that I'm hungry yet; I'm still replete from my hatching.

*~ You never felt the urge to bite a limb? You almost had me a while ago!*

*«We don't remember being food in an arena. Our first memories are of deep water, a good pressure around us. And plenty of right-sized fish to pierce with our jaws»*

My judgment remains true. This is indeed one of the more substantial parts of the arena's perimeter. A sudden urge to explore brings a grin to my face; I stand, stretch, comfort my nub while checking the sky for dots.

The saltier waters of the arena lie a good stone's throw to my right. The vegetation is thick around me, but low, as if recovering from a recent wave. Though no sign of the oblong depression I seek. I check behind to confirm I'm close to the start of the shoal, which curves some distance ahead of me. I need height, so I stay upright as I start to walk. When I spot a green path I edge towards it, take joy in the feel of soft grass under my feet when I reach it.

The path leads slowly upwards to the low spine of this narrow hill. Reeds grow thicker here, especially on the inwards side. I take a moment to knuckle down and check – my intuition matches my judgment: these reeds grow in terraces. When I dig into the soil I can feel dampness. A moss base, perhaps? The thought makes me happy: a person can survive on the brackish seawater here in Mescwar, but sweet water is always more pleasant to drink!

I spot a bare, stony outcrop ahead. I fall to my knuckles and push my way forwards. Soon enough I reach the rock – shallow steps have been carved into its slope, as I expected.

I step up to the top, then take a moment to check the skies, then look ahead. The first of two rectangular pits appears almost beneath me, only a good leap away. This one is smaller than the structure I seek, but still worth investigating.

My heels tell me the outcrop is covered in a sponge of lichens. I scrape at them with my toes, hunch down to bring the sample to my mouth, to taste – but there's no bite to the yellow scab. I spit it out, stand tall, retrace my route down the steps and angle around the outcrop towards the built depression.

*~ If I may, a question.*

*«Of course!»*

*~ How far are we from the Reaches?*

Katsepet considers his response as I arrive at the edge of the ruined building. Beyond its shape, there's almost nothing left – no bricks, no thatch ... nothing. Still, I jump off the ledge onto what remains of its floor.

*«We're a significant distance from the Reaches here»*

*~ Which Reach is closest?*

*«We're ... not sure»*

That is a surprising answer. Guardians usually know where they are in relation to the moving islands of Mescwar.

This floor used to have a thick clay cover – mixed with reed, I guess, when I step on a remnant patch and feel its texture against the bare skin of my instep. I glance to the structure's outer edge to confirm my suspicions, spot the drainage channel almost immediately. I can even see a scatter of bones, long enough to be ape thighs, scattered near the drain – once they would have supported low wicker seating, a long bench against the wall on which people could sit in comfort as they pissed and shat.

A toilet block, then. A good place to rest and gossip between bouts of work ... but not anymore.

*~ Has there been much movement while I was gone?*

*«No, though some guess that He may be preparing a move»*

*~ It's not like you to be so uncertain of where we are ...?*

*«We weren't paying too much attention while we travelled»*

Ohh ... interesting!

*~ Is this something we could maybe discuss?*

*«It is a possibility we might consider»*

Now that's a clear 'mind your business' from the worm. Guardians like to be friendly and helpful, but only so far, and no further.

Still, I need to know where I am. I have places to be, people to meet. Things to do. I'll have to consider a different approach; work out which of Katsepet's vanities I can use to tickle the knowledge from them.

~~~

This space is easily three times larger than the toilet block. I've not hurried to reach it – time is not an immediate concern, and hunting for edibles is always more productive when I'm not rushed.

On first glance the foundations, which are deep, offer me no comfort. Rainwater has formed a shallow pool covering the entire base and the light, dancing cloud of midges and hunter flies skimming above it make me less eager to investigate the space in any detail.

The undergrowth surrounding the old building is the densest I have seen so far. Small shrubs compete with the reeds and sedges, their wind-chopped branches and twigs knitting together to form a chest-high mass which is difficult to push through. I had circled the structure twice before finding a path through its border; the bushes, I discovered, had sharp thorns and a profusion of hard seed burrs which managed to tangle in my fur as I squeezed by.

I crouch to my haunches. Think, Kal, I tell myself. What next?

Clearly there's no shelter, here. A glance to the skies confirms there's no danger of a storm anytime soon but, still, finding – or building – a shelter would be useful.

I comfort my nub, relax in my skin. Beyond a need for shelter, my luck does hold well. Some of my returns to Mescwar have started in far worse places. One time, I had to leave my flesh twice before I reached the safety of a settlement. And I certainly remember the time I reached a settlement, only for the bastard island it was built on to decide it was a good time to shift. I kept my flesh that time, but I had to contribute some seriously heavy work on a belly that starved for many, many work shifts.

Here I have sweet water, and sufficient height to withstand all but the tallest of waves. And still no dangerous movement in the sky. And there's also Katsepet, who's being far less officious than usual.

A returning Vital Breath could not always rely on the help of a guardian. Mostly, they kept close to the current healing arena, the island Reaches and settlements surrounding it.

Why is Katsepet here?

I put the question to one side, stand and turn, stretch as I scan the sky. Stare at the narrow path between the shrubbery.

Why is the path here?

Thorn bushes are not common in the wild; they are a cultivated thing, and the thorns on these bushes are particularly long. And I've explored islands before, both unsettled and abandoned, and where bushes have established themselves: they rarely form such an impenetrable ... hedge?

The terraces I found earlier – they make sense. I remember that the current healing arena is terraced almost in its entirety, no space left uncultivated.

A mystery! I wonder if Katsepet enjoys a good mystery? Psattan was always game for a bout of investigation, when we travelled together; sometimes they would even invent puzzles for me to solve whenever we found ourselves in each other's company.

But then, I realise, Katsepet is part of this mystery. Why are they here?

~~~

It took some hunting, but I finally found a good crop of clams close to the shoal's shoreline. Without a rake, I had to wade into the arena's stinking mud and reach down to feel for the oval packets of food. Blue clams are not my favourite: they have thicker shells and muddier flesh. I found them in handfuls, and most made it to land when I pitched them through the air.

This mud, it reeks! I can still smell it in my fur even after walking across the shoal to dip into the cleaner water on the other side. I could really

do with a comb right now to get rid of the remaining tangles of stubborn filth. I could also do with a good sized pot to wash the mud free of my meal.

*~ Have you had a chance to eat, my friend?*

*«Yes, thank you for asking. Your mention of juveniles reminded us that the white-bellied quickfish in these parts do make for an excellent snack»*

I'm still not too hungry, yet, which means I feel no urge to chew the clams entire. Instead I line them up on a conveniently flat rock and bring a stone down on each in turn, to crack them open. Once I have the flesh exposed, I toss each clam into a rough-woven reed net, ready for transport to a rock pool close by, only a couple of dozen steps away. I can rinse them in sweetwater to get rid of most of the sharp shards.

*~ What do you prefer to eat, then?*

*«There's many sizeable jellies to be found in deeper water. Though to be honest you have spoiled us with your old flesh»*

*~ I hope I haven't changed your preference towards people?*

*«You joke, yes? Ape-people taste foul, and dragon-people offer nothing much beyond bone and skin»*

I check the sky.

*~ Oh, I don't know. There's a good amount of meat across a dragon's chest, and around their thighs.*

*«Jelly meat pleases us more»*

*~ I've been stung by jellies, several times.*

*«The sting is part of the delight, don't you agree?»*

~ No, I tell the worm, taking a couple of the washed clams and popping them into my mouth. I take a moment to feel them move before biting the flesh and swallowing.

Katsepet appears in an amenable mood. I cannot see them, though their all-sense is clear in my mind's ear so they must be close.

*~ I do need to ask, will you maybe have an opportunity to help me with one last thing? I know you have many other tasks to attend to, and your help with my return is already beyond requirements ...*

*«Welcoming you back to Mescwar has not been a chore, Kal. Let us consider this new request together»*

I remind myself: keep things simple!

*~ I, too, have responsibilities – indeed I avoid them here, with you! But I am not where I need to be to fulfill them.*

*«You didn't choose to return to this place?»*

*~ Sadly, no. My skills are lacking when it comes to selecting a place for my return.*

*«Your responsibilities lie with your company, we expect?»*

*~ Indeed. And then: ~ Guardians know about companies?*

*«We take an interest. This we, at least»*

This is old news to me. I know Katsepet keeps tabs on the politics of settlements, to keep an edge to their standing with other guardians.

It annoys me that I need to ask for further help because such need damages my own standing. I make a special effort to keep all frustration from the cadence of my Inner Voice.

*~ This healing arena has not aged well.*

*«It is rather desolate, yes. It speaks of old healings, of loss. We sense it was abandoned many ages before we were food»*

*~ Which suggests to me that we are a considerable distance from the Reaches, here in this arena?*

*«That 'considerable' is a very appropriate word, yes»*

*~ Which makes me think that it may be a good place to find armoured fish? I believe they, too, like to keep their distance?*

*«Armoured fish – they are common everywhere in deeper waters. An excellent meal!»*

I take a deep breath, relax into my pelt and pop another couple of clams into my mouth.

*~ Indeed. Though rather small. Though still useful – their armour can be used to make boats.*

*«You seek a boat, Kal?»*

That response was a lot more direct than I was expecting!

*~ I have responsibilities I cannot fulfill here, old friend.*

*«Our understanding is that constructing a boat takes effort, and materials beyond the plates of some armoured fishes ...?»*

*~ This is a truth. Though the most basic requirement is armour that can float ...*

*«A big fish, then?»*

*~ Two sets of armour are the minimum requirement for a boat, though I have never seen fish of that size.*

*«The biggest such fish prefer to stay clear of the Eldest and His lines of islands and settlements»*

*~ ... Really?*

I pop another clam into my mouth and bite down, doing all I can to mask my pleasure at managing to sound so genuinely surprised. I need Katsepet to agree to go hunting for me, and I need the fish he catches to be of a size that its armour can be used as a vessel with minimal effort.

*«Oh, yes»* says the worm, suddenly keen to share their knowledge of the deep waters. *«There are some fish not far from here which have spent a*

*long age growing. The biggest make for a worthy adversary – they would be happy to feast on our tail!»*

*... Damn!*

*~ They would eat you? I cannot possibly ask you for a favour now. Your friendship and company means too much to me!*

*«(amusement) – you have played me well, Kal. Though we think that last emotional tone was genuine»*

*~ ... Chagrin?*

*«Indeed! Yet by mentioning the armoured fish you have shivered a desire into our guts to taste their flesh again. And an older, larger fish will contains a wealth of oils – suddenly we hunger to hunt, and fight!»*

## 20. The Endless Sea

I have a fair wind behind me as I approach this island's harbour jetty. I barely have to guide the sail in its socket as I slowly approach port.

If Katsepet is right – and I have no reason to doubt their accuracy – I'm about to arrive in the outlying Spedianis Reach, specifically Spe Tantes settlement. It is a place, they pointed out, where I can trade my cargo for some well respected credits, for these are people who have moved well beyond barter.

I hold memories of this island: larger than many, low like most, with a good number of hill ranges which run parallel to each other across its length, resulting in a place with many headlands and bays. And the island has deep roots: it rarely rocks or moves. Spe Tantes itself is the smaller settlement; it faces outwards to the endless sea. The other settlement, on the other side of the island, was always far more popular.

I check the sky, adjust the sail, look back to the larger vessel behind me – the one holding my haul of shells and other trading goods. Katsepet had found me an armoured fish the size of which I've never heard of before! We had feasted together on its flesh and oils as we hollowed out the creature and prepared its long head plate for its new existence.

There was no way I could have used it for transport! Even with a sail, such a vessel would need a crew. But the guardian had been so proud of themselves, I didn't have the heart to mention the problem.

I'm close enough now to make out the shapes of people on the jetty. I can see they have spotted my approach. The Spedianis folk like to have things ordered and expected. I'm not on their schedule: I can see somebody already knuckling from the jetty to warn the authorities.

The sky remains empty of movement, though there's clouds above. They don't threaten rain, preferring to scud slowly over the island, heading for the more crowded archipelagos beyond it. Still, there should be at least one dragon in the sky.

Time to trim the sail, I decide. If the harbour master wants to maintain their standing, they'll have a boat heading towards me within a few dozen

breaths – claiming to offer help navigate through the wave breakers and the harbour barriers (for a credit) while keeping spears hidden beneath the gunwales, just in case.

~~~

"We have an agreement, Master?"

The Harbour Master – who has changed since my last visit – grasps at the shoulder loop of her sash. I've made sure to negotiate with her here on the boat: I invited her to inspect my cargo even as the pilots were throwing ropes over bony posts, ready to secure both their boat and both of mine to the jetty. She had an audience; she couldn't refuse. I'm sure she opened our negotiation with extortionate mooring rates, but I didn't put too much effort into bargaining her down to a more reasonable price.

She does have a good, well adjusted smile to her face – a woman at ease with her standing. I let her lead, let her stroke my nub to seal our deal and tip my head to my right shoulder, to expose a very trusting grooming spot on my neck for the fingers of her other hand.

"Are you planning to sell all of your cargo here in Spe Tantes?"

"I would need to confer with my company's representative first, but yes, some of the cargo is for trade here."

"Yantos, yes?" she asks. "Your vessel displays the sigils of the Rujan Company, I believe?"

"You are correct on both counts, Master! I hope my good friend Yantos has maintained both his own good standing, and our company's?"

"He bargains well, I hear, and is punctual at settling his dues."

"Does he maintain the same offices?" I ask. "It has been a while since I last had the opportunity to visit Spedianis Reach."

Her smile tightens a little: "Hurrind! To me, please!" she calls.

Storm! A question clearly beneath her station. It's been a long while since I've needed to watch my words so closely: this level of precision used to be second nature to my face, my stance!

I spot Hurrind as soon as he rises from his knuckles. He's further back along the jetty; the way he chooses to move around the crowd rather than through it tells me that either the man has recently renewed, or he's lost a good amount of standing since we last met. He does look well groomed, which suggests the former.

I offer him my arm as he steps aboard; he doesn't hesitate to take it.

"The trader here, Kal by name, desires assistance navigating our hovel of a settlement."

I smile at her joke, bow and offer my hand up in a request to groom. She nods an acceptance and guides my hand to her nub, which I briefly touch before moving my fingers to her side waist – an unchallenging area of fur to search.

It is enough to soften her smile, add a hint of gratitude for my public act to the wrinkles around her eyes.

"You think of all comforts for your guests, Master," I tell her.

"I know," she says. "Hurrind here can finalise our arrangements back at the harbour house, then direct you to your company's office. Please don't waste too much of his time!"

~~~

It's good to be out of the stuffy room with its tight walls of contract rolls and mild whiff of mold. Hurrind and I walk together along the street closest to the shoreline, neither taking the lead.

Spe Tantes was always a tidy town, I recall, more organised than many settlements with its rough grid of streets and alleyways between brick buildings, some with one storey, more with two. Looking ahead, I cock my head and try to reconcile memory with reality.

"Have you moved the paper mill?"



Hurrind offers me a raised eyebrow. "It has been a while since your last visit, Kal. The mill flooded the last time the island shifted. The owners rebuilt it in the next bay – which made people happier."

"Ah. That would explain why the hill feels closer!"

"Oh, yes," the man confirms. "It was more of a roll than a move. Slow, mind. No harbour wave. But we lost the old harbour and the lowest streets to the water. Spe Lopleis" – the town on the other side of this island, I recall – "did well from the change: many new fields and even a lake which now fills with good, sweet water!"

"Was that when you lost your flesh?"

I feel comfortable asking Hurrind the question. I had settled our status back in the harbour house by complaining about a sore shoulder, which he was more than happy to groom and massage for me. There was no need for me to stroke his nub, nor him mine.

"No indeed. Very few casualties from that shift. Mescwar can be gentle when He sees fit."

"I do remember you. I took great pleasure from your ales."

"Ah! A fond customer! I do enjoy hearing about my previous life. Was there a particular favourite?"

"Your green barley beer was a remarkable brew."

"Many people tell me that, even now. It is a kindness I take to my heart!"

We turn away from the shore to walk along a wider street. Here the buildings seem to be mostly warehouses, with some workshops scattered between them. There's signs of occupation on some of the upper floors: I can see the shapes of stools and bed rolls leaned against the brick pillars that cut between the many narrow windows, mostly open to the air during this dry time.

"I would be eager to hear the story of your loss, if it doesn't offend you?"

"No, no. It is an old story, I've long reconciled it to me. Are you in a hurry to meet your colleague?"

"Not especially, old friend."

"There's a good ale house on our way. We can share a brew between us, if you like."

I'm tempted by the offer, but I have no credits yet to my name and I'm not ready to put myself into this man's debt. Also, some of the Spe Tantes brews can go to the head.

"I think it best if I don't meet my colleague with alcohol on my breath, yes? Sometimes it's better to avoid expected behaviours, you'd agree?"

Hurrind grins, briefly touches my arm. "A pity, I would say, as by all accounts I used to make a handsome profit from such 'expected' trader behaviours!"

We knuckle further up the street. Halfway along, the man points to our left. One of the buildings has a stall displaying some fine-woven nets in front of it. "I'll assume, if you've been on the endless sea for a while, you'll be keen for fresh protections? Feyettin's shop here offers some of the best nets in town."

It's a good point: "I was going to rely on whatever nets my company has spare, but they're usually a little threadbare."

"You'll need a good net. The midges grow tiresome before rain, and word is some of them are carrying a nasty fluke in their guts."

I check the sky for clouds: "You think it will rain."

"I've always had a knack for predicting the weather. It's the way the static sparks an ache in my elbow. I'm told I used to add a couple of credits to my prices before heavy downpours."

I move over to inspect the nets. "Your nose for profit is one of the other reasons I liked you. You're almost a sea trader yourself!"

"Ha, no!" he laughs. "Just looking at waves moves my belly to spasms."

I glance over the stall to the woman behind it, lift my eyes to seek her permission to touch the goods. She dips her head to give her permission.

"So," I say as I lift an edge of a net to let its weave run between my fingers, "how did you come to your present station?"

"It is a sad tale indeed," begins Hurrind. "And mostly my own fault. I was inland, in the Tiz-ayan Hills area – you know of them? No? – Well, I was seeking a good crop of rye for an idea I had for a new brew. The man I met there was keen for business, keen to share his own attempts at making beer with me. I want to believe that the drink had fermented badly."

"You always gave the benefit," I agree, "always happy to give others a knuckle up."

"Another kindness from your memory of me. Thank you! Whatever the story, I must have taken ill on the journey home. The last thing I remember is the dragon lifting me off the ground, keen to harvest my flesh on the sly!"

"Ouch!" I commiserate, my eyes darting up to the sky by reflex.

"Indeed! I nursed that pain for a long while as I healed in the arena muds."

I nod my thanks to the woman, let my fingers signal that I was interested and hoped to return to her shop soon. I extend my other arm towards the street, invite Hurrind to lead on.

"But that doesn't explain your change in trades?"

"No, indeed. Mescwar gifted me a cruel healing, is the answer to that. Maybe He thought I needed to learn some humility? Anyway, by the time I stepped from the egg I discovered my memories of my last flesh were not entire."

"Oh, shame!"

"In particular, the desire to brew was lost to me, and all my special recipes with it."

"Now that is a loss to mourn!"

"Of course, my former workers offered me an apprenticeship as soon as they learned of the situation. They maybe hoped that practicing the craft would trigger memories in my head. But the honest answer was that I was glad I had lost the knowledge. I was ready for new challenges!"

~~~

When I walked through the entrance of our company's office, Yantos moved fast. No greeting, just a finger pointing to a stool by a low desk. I did as he ordered, knuckling my way across the small room to ease myself into the seat. The man was already busy, pulling a heavy, woven frame along the wall to block the entrance. As I was finding flint to light the lamps on the table he was already securing the door with scaffold reed poles. Soon enough, both narrow windows to the right of the entrance were similarly covered and secured.

Only then did Yantos approach me, pull me to my feet, hug me. No care for standing; no etiquette. No attempt to groom my fur, my nub – which he knows repulses me. Just a solid, tight hug – two brothers forged in adversity, long lost, now reunited.

No words. He doesn't loosen his grip as my flesh starts to shake. The tears on my face, now soaking his fur – an irrelevance!

I make an effort to still my shivers, stop up my silent yowls and cries. I slap his back gently, once, twice. I feel his hug loosen. Finally we pull apart, stare into each other's faces. If there is dampness on his cheeks, then it must be a fiction created by the lamp light.

"You found a boat, I hear."

I settle back down onto my stool while he moves round the table to sit with his back to the wall.

"Yes. It took some finding. Someone hid it a little too well."

Yantos scrabbles through the mess of papers and objects spread across the table. He finds a wax tablet soon enough, holds it out for me to take. "It has one of our sigils?"

I find a reed splint in the mess he has made. The boat – which had been hidden in a shoal on the far side of the healing arena from where I had

first explored – did indeed have sigils scratched into its hull: company marks, and other, quieter scratches. I copy the shape of the sigil Yantos needs into the wax, hand the tablet back. He stares at it for a good half dozen breaths as he considers implications, then smooths the wax with his thumb.

"I argued against scattering perfectly good resources so distantly," he tells me. "Sometimes I let the tally of company balances overwhelm deeper necessities."

"Yet you came round to the idea. I remember you even took part in the plan."

"Ha, yes!" For the first time, he smiles at me. "That was Ripuen's doing. She suggested a voyage across the endless sea would be good for my health. She was right – didn't it annoy you when Ripuen was right?"

"Insufferable!" I agree.

"We used to meet regularly after that, you know. She'd steer her boat into the harbour and drag me away from my work for a couple of days together on the water. Somehow she always found a storm to sail through. That woman loved her some waves!"

"I can imagine." The Ripuen I recall was a comely woman, well muscled yet smaller than most, smarter than many. I'm glad to hear she found joy with Yantos.

"You say 'days'," I continue. "Have the locals fully embraced the idea of measuring time?"

My friend grins: "Hours, yes. But only to the point of a dozen hours marking a shift. And the measurement of hours is shaky; the maintenance of the water clocks in some settlements can be a bit hit-and-miss. They still count longer periods in sleeps. It's very frustrating for contract negotiations."

"I can imagine," I repeat. "Though there's always Game time."

"Not anymore, Kal." He gives me a more direct stare, an invitation to business. "How long have you been away?"

Now that's certainly a question!

"What do you mean, brother? The Games are the most regular event in Mescwar ..."

He's shaking his head. "The Games – they ended a long while back. That you do not know this ... you've been gone from Mescwar since before then? Storm, Kal! What the fuck is your story?"

And suddenly I'm aware again of the Song, its thrum in my marrow, across sinews. It's always been there, I realise, since my arrival in this world. I've just learned to ignore it, treat it as background noise.

But now it has a coherence to its melodies: now it is interested!

I am – more – than I have ever been before. That is the Song: the sum of all of me. A gift from Ounous I never asked for.

The Song gives me a chord, a memory of an exchange from a different world ...

"Boude ... she said something that didn't make sense at the time," I tell Yantos.

"What?"

I interrogate this chord, this memory: "It was the last time we were in the Outer World. About how she was pulled there."

I do not need to explain the Outer World to the man opposite me, his face both eager and yet timid for my answer. Yantos knows the joy of witnessing the majesty of a cloud-speckled dawn, the heat of a ball of fire in the sky as it counts lives in days.

I struggle to summarise the gist of the woman's words: "Boude told me that she had been summoned to the Outer World in the middle of a Game ... she said Mescwar was 'not happy' ... but that makes no sense! When has Mescwar ever been 'happy' or 'unhappy'?"

"Go on."

Mescwar ... is Mescwar. He – it – is the world, one of the Worlds Within Worlds. A Power – just as Fol Huun is a Power, Ounous is a Power: Worlds Within Worlds.

Whatever everyone around me may tell themselves, may try to convince me, we don't live on top of Mescwar. These islands and reaches are not scales on the back of a giant lizard that buries itself in the muds of the endless sea; they do not move and turn and roll because the Flame Drake twitches in His sleep. That's just a story people tell each other to help make sense of their endless lives.

"What she said, it still tickles like nonsense. And yet ... the Games are gone? How? How did they end?"

Yantos furrows his brow: "I wasn't there," he starts. "Why Boude chose to attend ... I don't know: a challenge, maybe? I remember you took more of an interest in the Games than most of the rest of us Rujan folks."

"Dragons!" The interruption surprises the man. "I remember the thrill of hunting those fuckers across the Games arena. The bones I harvested made the company a good profit!"

"I don't remember collecting you from the healing arena, after what happened. Then again, I don't remember collecting Boude ... though everything was chaos at that time."

"What happened?"

"The stories I heard ... the mud boiled, they said; the air caught fire and everyone touched by the flames, they burned entire: no bones left ... nothing!"

I'm confused. "You mean the Fire Drake ...?"

The Fire Drake was my favourite part of the Game, apart from my battles with Charlie! It was the signal to mark that competition's close, when gentle sheets of cool flame would rise up from the mud and coil around us survivors like serpents, and reward us with a rapture that felt like limbs shaking free of their joints.

He pauses, searches around him, finds two baked clay beakers beneath the table. The distraction helps him form words. From beside him,

next to the wall, he pulls up a fresh flagon of beer. I watch the liquid froth as he starts to pour it into my mug.

"Maybe this time the flames were for real, Kal."

He gave me a shrug: "Of course people searched the arena, what was left of it. By the time I visited the site even the arena cliffs were gone, swallowed back into the mud. When the victims returned to new flesh, they ... they didn't remember a thing. All memories of the event removed: most struggled to remember what a Game even was! Soon enough, people stopped talking about the Games, if only to ease the standing – the self respect – of the poor afflicted bastards."

He takes a long draught from his own mug: "I had to redraft a lot of contracts after that. Sneakily, too, because, all of a sudden, to mention the word 'Games' was very bad form. But I remember it."

I lift my mug to my lips, drain it in one, slow tip. The Song is combining chords now, joining them into runs which bring the surroundings of my conversation with Boude into soft focus.

"It was the last time I was summoned to the Outer World," I tell Yantos. "Everything about that job was ... wrong!"

"Wrong?"

"Very, very wrong!"

"How was it wrong?"

I hold my empty mug in front of me, wriggle it to ask for a refill. Yantos doesn't disappoint, taking his time to fill both mugs to their brims.

"Boude said ... yes, she told me that Bull performed an impossible summons. He pulled twelve of them from the Band, all in one go: bang! Bang! Bang!"

Yantos's face is suddenly a sketch of mirth as it attempts to fit both astonishment and disbelief into its skin at the same time.

I do not laugh.

"Falc – you know him? From Tincas? – confirmed it. Bull did this thing, and then straight after Spar clubbed his host with a steel bar and rendered him back to the Band, right there! I met them later, well Spar and what was left of Bull's host. Everyone was in shock!"

"So you were part of this impossible summoning? It could explain why you don't remember the disaster ..."

I'm already shaking my head.

"No, no. I got summoned soon after. A little job, Falc said. Sort out this mess for us. Like I had a fucking chance!"

"So you should know about the Games!"

"I must have been healing at the time. I remember that last summoning. I'd stepped free of my egg for no more than a few dozen breaths and suddenly I'm hauled out of my flesh and into the sky, and through it, and gone!"

Yantos is thinking hard now: "Bull, Spar – Bull and Spar. No, Spar would never render Bull without him asking her to. Those two ... they've been inseparable since forever ago!"

"They're separated now," I tell him.

"...?"

"Bull missed his stone during the render back to the Band. He got caught by Spoy."

"Storm no!"

I nod, concerned now that this news is perhaps too much for Yantos to take in. Though to be fair, he's just blown my mind apart too ... no more Games? The Games ... they are Mescwar, to me! What is Mescwar without them?

Yantos is shaking his head, one hand self-grooming the nape of his neck. I turn my head as I hear a noise outside ... Hurrind was right, it turns

out: the noise is rain, heavy rain by the rattle the water makes on the windows' shutters.

We sit in silence, listen to the rhythm of the rain, sip at our beers as the air seeping through the weave of the shutters begins to cool the room. I stare at the lamp, the way its flame slowly bends and flickers: it is easier work than staring at my brother as he tries to reconcile impossibilities into his view of the world, here and beyond.

Finally, he puts his mug down. "No," he tells me. "Give me different words. I need to hear words about business. I hear you made harbour with goods to trade?"

I feel a crack in my back as soft tensions in the air start to dissipate. "Yes," I confirm.

"In a second boat?"

"Yes. Two boats. I've got giant clams shells, for the main part, and some rare seaweeds drying out which might find a buyer."

"Pearls?"

"Yes, a couple of full hands. Nothing of quality though."

"Quality is not important; provenance is."

"All from the flesh of the giant clams. I needed to eat as I sailed. Why pearls?"

"Hah!" And suddenly I see the man grin wide, to the point of bared teeth beyond his incisors. "There's an outbreak of stomach flukes in the settlement. Whatever passes for doctors in this place have decided that, this time around, crushed pearl is the best cure."

"Really? Some purgative sedge leaf is usually enough for me ..."

"I can get excellent credit for giant clam pearl, today. You have them with you?"

"They're back in the boat ..."

"You've left them in the boat?" Yantos stands suddenly, clattering his stool back into the wall. "Idiot! We have to get down there now!"

I stay seated, sip at my beer.

"Stop worrying! Nobody's going to steal them!"

"... What?"

"The big boat's protected."

"... How? Who?"

"Relax, man! Everything's going to be fine. Anybody stepping into that boat's going to end up with a foot full of guardian spawn. Now go find us another flagon of beer and I'll tell you all about who I met when I hatched, and how I ended up with two boats."

I've intrigued him: "And how the pearls are really protected?"

"Of course," I agree. "But only if the beer's good, mind!"

~~~

The wind is typically chaotic, this far away from the island reaches, which I can no longer see. But there's an order to the chaos which I've recently learned to read. Katsepet has given me many insights during our sojourn: reading the breeze the guardian way is one of his more precious gifts.

Our trade hasn't all been one way, mind. I've given the guardian the gift of new purpose.

*~ How did your business go?*

*«Some productive discussions. I shared a part of our mapping with colleagues I like»*

I remember – more accurately, my Song reminds me – that it was Boude who taught me to sail. She is my captain for a reason beyond being the only person to help me when I first arrived in Mescwar. Becoming a part of a boat, its steering, its heading ... this, I now know, was always my chief pleasure in this world. The Games were a bonus to me, nothing more. Here,

on a boat with only the endless sea around me ... this is where I feel most alive!

My sojourn with Katsepet has been by far my longest voyage. It is good to resume the adventure with them nearby.

They move faster, now they have lost their heavy tail. My Song insists that it is nothing more than coincidence that it was Katsepet who found my dolphin flesh beached on a remote sandbank near a long-worked-out healing arena ... But I'm not so sure.

Water speaks to water. Aherrket taught me that lesson. And maybe Power speaks to Power. Ounous, I suspect, has plans for me, little Kal of Tintuun.

A tempest on the plans of Powers! I have plans of my own, here in Mescwar, to start!

But first, some fun. This wind seems to be gaining a purpose. It speaks of a building storm somewhere ahead of me. And Yantos reminded me of Ripuen's grin, sailing straight for bad weather.

Ripuen, lost to Spoy a long while ago. I shall honour her memory with danger and joy and high, high waves!

## 21. Kahelis Reach

This room has stone walls, and a solid ceiling. I like stone walls: they speak of stability, history – an understanding of foundations.

In most reaches and islands, the locals build with mud bricks and scaffold reeds. It makes good sense. Why build of stone, which takes long labour and effort, when you don't know whether the land you're building on is about to shift, tilt, disappear under the waves. But this office – this settlement, Ste Kahelis – is different.

Kahelis Reach is the only part of Mescwar that barely moves. The stone walls of this office have probably been here for thousands of Outer World years: they're probably older than me! The purpose the walls serve, the interior they define, has no doubt changed hundreds of times. But the stones that surround me are honest, and true.

Unlike the idiot knuckled and haunched on the other side of the table to me. He calls himself Batanean, and claims he's the regional coordinator for the Rujan Company's activities in these parts. I've never met him before. Not even the Song recalls him. He's just another face and pelt in the crowd to me, until now.

He acts as if he knows me. Welcomed me by name, was off his haunches and across the room as soon as I appeared at the entrance. Quick to rub my nub, establish his superior place in our mutual pecking order. I – play along, for now. Mostly. There's no fur ripped from my skin by letting him keep his imagined standing.

For now.

Currently he's trying to establish requirements. Apparently there's a need to transport these goods to that island, for some such purpose and profit. I'm not listening for details, only for the words that need an appropriate response. To his credit, the man has not mentioned my long absence since our initial groom. The story I sold him is one of renewals that stripped me of my desire to trade, of meeting Yantos (in an imagined past) who persuaded me back to the tiller. He bought the lie, just as Yantos

predicted he would when he waved me farewell from Spe Tantes's harbour jetty.

Though is it a lie? The Song reminds me that I had no desire for a life of business in Fol Huun. I could quibble with the assertion – most of my time in that stone was a neverending negotiation. But the music Ounous has gifted to my marrow, my sinews, cares more for themes and progressions than it does for details.

Batanean the obscure told me early on that the name of our company has changed. We are no longer known as 'The Rujan Company of Kahelis Reach'. He had explained how large and influential the company has grown. Two hundred traders, three hundred more working out of fifteen offices across Mescwar. Another two offices opening soon. I should be proud of our growth, he said: associating my name with 'The Rujan Company' gave me a new edge of standing against traders from other companies.

I know – knew – Rujan. She was a remarkable woman with a rare capacity for generosity towards those she loved, and the sharpest fangs for a deal I have ever witnessed. If she had offered me twenty credits for my pelt, I expect I would have ripped it from my flesh and handed it over without a care!

Her loss to Spoy ... oh that one hurts still! How many of her original company still stand?

There was only ever twenty two of us. Twenty one before she and Boude took me to their hearts and welcomed me home. We were a tiny company in the scheme of Mescwar business, yet constant. Like the stones in these walls. We traded as needed, to maintain appearances. But it was not our main purpose.

Batanean the clueless still witters on; I still simper responses as the conversation dictates. It's as clear as the spot on my nose that the man has no concept of the company's real purpose. How could he? From all of Mescwar's populations, only twenty two of us have walked under the sun and moon of the Outer World. The real world, in which the existence of the Worlds Within Worlds is but a hint of a rumour.

"You've outlined a good proposition," I finally interject. "But maybe this is an opportunity for someone else?"

"How do you mean?"

"The timescales are tight, but easy to achieve for someone who already has standing with the contacts. My recent work has been with Yantos, mostly across the Spedianis and Kleamand Reaches. I would not want my inexperience here in Kahelis threaten a good outcome."

The man does not look put out by my words. Has he been cornered into offering me this contract?

"The word is you are quick to learn," he tells me, "and your ability to bring contacts on board precedes you."

"Your praise is generous. And I am grateful! Nevertheless I have some personal business, here in Kahelis, to complete before I can set sail again."

"May I enquire ...?"

"Of course! A long absence will often damage personal relationships – I'm sure you understand such difficulties. The time has come for me to offer apologies to some people I was close to, once."

"Of course, of course. I shall not ask further," says Batanean the pretending-to-be-concerned. "I shall wish you all fortune for a healthy outcome! Then once that is done, you will be available?"

"Of course!" I lie. "The apology is not for traumatic actions. Perhaps if I could ask your staff, maybe one of them will know where I can find a trader named Boude ...?"

~~~

Kahelis Reach: a string of five islands, some long and a little wide; some barely large enough to farm. Like bladders along a kelp stem. Ste Kahelis settlement sits on the fourth island, the largest of the five. Boude – for reasons that neither Batanean nor any of his staff were willing to gossip about, but which I'm sure I'll soon discover – has decided to spend her current time on the second island.

The island closest to Mescwar's lodestone, atop its towering pillar of rock that the guardians call the Eldest.

There's no settlement here, no harbour where I can dock my boat. I had to circle the island near twice before discovering Boude's boat, hauled high onto a small, sloping beach. A third circuit of the high cliffs confirmed that it was the only good place to land.

I knew this already, my Song reminds me. Maybe, but those memories are old and things do change, even here. Not that my Song cares for my mistrust: for my Song, only the themes pertain.

The climb from the beach was a difficult one: few people come here; fewer bother to spend time maintaining the path cut into the cliffs. When I reached the top, I had sunk to my haunches and knuckles to recover my breath.

This is an island like no other, my Song serenades. Where there should be low, rolling hills I see steep mountains that choose to sink their roots directly in water. Some have been terraced to support the growing of food – for a while, I recall, this had been a popular place for mystics and magicians, hermits and seers to make their home.

That had been an interesting time, but it passed soon enough. Society moved on to the next new thing, leaving the island to its colonies of birds and the occasional wind-blown dragon. And us, of course: the Rujan Company always has an interest here.

The cliff I knuckle on marks the start of a hill which rises for a few hundred strides. The path leads straight up; I follow it more in hope than certainty – the thrum of my Song infers several visits, but offers few details concerning geography.

And beyond the hill? A steep valley cutting from my left to my right. Fully terraced, a fast flowing stream pouring through it, heading towards the valley's mouth where it launches itself into the endless sea as a waterfall.

There's a stone house, higher in the valley just out of sight from here. I remember this. A house with strong, thick walls and three levels to its name. The air is cooler there, a stray chord chimes, with a sloping roof built of

slate to keep out the rain which this place seems to attract like midges to warm skin.

... And suddenly the island resolves. Terraces gain names, and likely crops. The stream grows features, signs of places where a person can cross from one bank to the other. An outhouse built of scaffold reed which we would have to move after every tenth sleep.

The place where Boude became more than just my companion, my captain, my friend ... here in the valley of the stream fed by hot and cold springs that leave its steep course downwards covered in a low mist of quick spume and steam.

I can see movement in the valley below me. A shape of a person bent down to harvest the daily crop. And suddenly I'm smiling, my heart a breeze through cloud. Storm, I've missed Boude so badly!

I narrow my eyes to focus, and one body becomes two. Two bodies become three ...

~~~

I'm more than halfway down before one of the figures notices me. Which is strange: I have not hidden my presence here. Now I am closer, I can tell that it is indeed Boude who spots me: the bands of burgundy and brown stripes swirled across her pelt are unique to her.

Boude shouts something to the others, causing them to stare in my direction. I do not recognise them. They quickly gather their tools and start moving upstream towards the hidden house. As soon as she is satisfied they are moving, she scans the narrow sky. Then she stands upright to face me, both hands on her hips.

A challenging stance.

I do not call out to her. Instead I resume walking down the hillside. The stream between us cuts deep into rock at this point, so I have some safety should our reunion start on the wrong knuckle.

The path I follow winds across the hill in steep lengths capped by sharp turns. As I walk down, a terrace of unkempt scaffold reed, tall and sturdy in its growth, blocks my sight of the woman. I do not pause my step.

Soon enough I reach the the turn and continue walking through the midst of the reeds, then beyond them.

Boude, too, has moved. She stands much closer to the stream now. One hand remains on her hip. The other holds a coil of rope.

Or possibly a whip. The woman has considerable skill with whips; I've witnessed her snap a dragon's neck as it sailed four full body lengths above her. For the fun of it.

*How did we part?* I ask my Song.

It is a reach, but the Song returns from my marrow with a note of assurance. I last saw Boude in the Outer World, the last time I had been pulled there. I was the Band's Guardian, that time. She had helped me with that job in small ways: I helped ease her render back to the Band with some sort of drug.

Did I meet her in Fol Huun, after I rendered back there?

No, accents my Song. I met only her name that time, in the mouths of others. But she had been in Fol Huun.

~ *Kal*, she says, using the trick with the Inner Voice she taught me long ago. The one I've used with guardians ever since.

I continue walking. The valley cuts steeper here, too steep for terracing. The path I follow peters out into dirt and scattered boulders.

~ *You're late!* She reminds me. She hasn't moved a fingernail. Still she challenges.

Finally, I stop. I knuckle down on a smooth, near-level slab of rock that juts into the misty stream a bodylength below. I watch her, watch her refuse to shift. Slowly, I stand back on my feet.

"Boude," I say. "My eyes dampen to see you!"

We stand face to face now, our locked gazes level, separated only by the sharp dip of the rumbling water.

Now she moves! A sudden jerk of her arm sends the whip across the stream, unwinding as it flies. My response is near instant: I leap and somersault, reach for the last coil and grab at it with my left foot. My landing is not graceful, but I don't sprawl.

"We're expecting company," she tells me. "Cjaxirj. Not you!"

*~ Charlie ... why?*

I've never been able to pronounce the dragon's name; my tongue laughs at my attempts to shape it. Charlie doesn't mind: she calls me Oaf, and sometimes Flatfoot Halfwit.

Boude returns to her stance. This is not a good stance for the woman to maintain. My Song remains confident in my sinews, my marrow – my Song is wrong.

Storm! Is this because I spoke with words? There's no tightness behind my brow ridge; whatever connection she opened with me is shut now!

No. This isn't just another person stood across the stream. This is Boude; she is my *captain*! She knows me better than I know myself, and she doesn't give a storm's drop about status or slights when the only ones standing are me and her.

Time to knuckle down, though. Just in case she's reached the point of teeth with me.

I ease back down to the stone, then lift my legs to swing them between my arms so that now I sit perched, my toes touching cool steams above the stream. I take a moment to transfer the whip to my hand, coil it back into its loose loops.

And then: "When did you get back from Fol Huun?"

Her face doesn't move.

"I know you were in Fol Huun. Mada told me as much."

Her eyes narrow. She's never liked Mada ... but no words, no other response.

"It was kind of you to come and rescue me. What I want to know is: why?"

Words, finally: "Is that what you want to know, Kal?"

"Yes. You came to rescue me, but you didn't bother to visit me. I remember that! Was the stench of my rotting flesh so offensive?"

She breaks her stare, checks the sky for movement.

"You want to know why? I'll tell you why. Mada asked me to go along on her little expedition. *'He'll listen to you, do as you tell him!'* – that conniving bitch knew exactly how to play me to get me to go with her!"

And again our stares lock.

"You should have said: no."

That widens her eyes!

"What, you didn't want to be rescued?"

I throw my head back and yelp a laugh: "Rescued? No! I was happy in Fol Huun. I knew what I was, and where I was. I was strong, and able, and there was nobody around to grab me by the fucking nub without asking for my permission first!"

I resume our stare: "And then suddenly you turn up with Mada and the whole fucking gang, strutting around like giants who owned the place. And all of a sudden everyone's forcing me to remember stuff that was better off lost forever and my whole. Fucking. World. Collapses!"

Silence. There's a spring beneath the slab of rock I sit on which bubbles as it leaks into the river; I can feel its faint rumbles through my thighs, my hips.

"Don't you dare rub your turds in my fur!"

She's not shouting. She stands at challenge, but her voice is low and even. I lower my cheek to my shoulder, twisting our shared gaze.

"Oh, Kal. You think that coy look of yours is going to help? You will look at me straight or I will take pleasure ripping your arms from their sockets ... you have no idea how you've ruined my fucking life!"

I straighten my spine, bring one leg up to tuck it tight beneath me. Just in case. A quick check of the sky confirms that Charlie is not here yet.

"Tell me."

"You weren't alone in Fol Huun, Kal. You bought company with you when you rendered back to the Band. How the fuck did you manage to do that?"

... Aah, moderates my Song. There is that.

I breathe out, long and slow: "I don't know ..."

"You don't fucking know?"

I look away, shake my head: "It was not a normal render, back from our last job ..."

"Not normal? What did you do wrong this time?"

"Nothing!"

"Storm, Kal," she finally shouts. "Answer me! What went wrong?"

And before I realise it, I'm standing, shouting: "Fol Huun, Boude. That's what went wrong! I got rendered back to the Band by a fucking Power!"

My words freeze her face mid-snarl. For a breath she is static, then she turns away, her foot already stepping uphill and her hand behind her to wipe my nonsense from the air. She turns, steps back down, opens her throat and lips to start a retort, closes her mouth as she turns away again.

*~ Impossible!*

*~ Yes, and yet it happened! Fol Huun was in the Outer World. She was soaked into every cell of my host's flesh. The whole time, Boude! The whole time I was in that bastard's skull Fol Huun was there too. All. The. Fucking. Time.*

*~ Impossible ...?*

*~ I never knew she was there, Boude! I could sense ... something. I could feel the wrongness ... do you remember the wrongness, that time?*

The woman turns again to face me, slowly this time. Her cheeks are grey and her eyes wide. She says nothing, but she does nod: she does hear me.

*~ You all told me there was something badly wrong, that last job in the Outer World. All of you. Falc pulled me out to be the Band's Guardian and then most of you ran away.*

*~ Yes ... I remember that. I remember ... it didn't seem to affect you? That wrongness?*

I lean back my head, encourage Boude to start thinking.

*~ I still don't know why it didn't affect me. But what if it was the stench of a Power in the Outer World that was freaking everyone's sanity?*

*~ She was in, in ... Sam?*

*~ He called Her his 'invisible friend' – I remember that. He said he talked to Her all the time, said that She gave him advice ...*

*~ ... And She rendered you back to the Band? To Fol Huun?*

*~ She was ... suddenly I knew She was there in Sam's flesh ... and She was every part of Sam, every cell ... She threw me out, out with a flick of a thought and I was sailing through space back to the Band and, and I missed the Band, Boude! Mescwar was there and then gone and Spoy ... fucking Spoy was reaching for me! And I ran from Spoy and, and the lavender stone was just there, somehow there ...?*

She's thinking now!

*~ That stone's been missing since Keftiu, since that island exploded.*

Yes, I nod.

Since I first rode a host in the Outer World, my Song sings only to me.

*~ And Sam, the host, he was with you?*

I nod again: *~ Maybe? I think so. Something followed me to Fol Huun's world ...*

... And suddenly Boude laughs. Not a soft laugh. She howls!

I feel a shiver pulse through my skin. There's no joy in that laugh, I realise, as I watch her throw her head back, pull air into her lungs, fold herself over to bring her hands to her knees.

A dozen breaths in my lungs, a dozen more. Finally the woman manages to control her outburst, bring herself back into herself. She still leans her arms on her thighs. She scans the sky: upriver; downriver; along the valley ridges. Then she brings her eyes back to me.

"No, Kal," she says. "No!"

"It happened!"

"No! Powers ... they're Powers, Kal! They're the stones, the Worlds Within Worlds. They aren't alive, Kal – you know this! Mescwar isn't a bastard Fire Drake: He's a bunch of rocks floating in a mess of mud ..."

*~ It happened, Boude. I was there: you weren't. And then I was back in Fol Huun ...*

"And now you're here! Lie if you want, Kal. I don't want to listen to it!"

Finally she straightens, moves her hands to her hips, challenging me: "But since you're here, that's a ... that's a good thing, yes? Now you can get on with the job and fix the fucking mess you left me with!"

"... What mess?"

"They're here, Kal! That mess you made when you dragged your little friends into the Band? They're here! Sam, Marc – remember them?"

... Aah, my Song echoes, uncertainty in its note.

I nod. Yes I remember Sam, and his lover Marc.

And now Boude smiles, teeth clear of lips, incisors exposed to the gum: "Well I am done babysitting your storm-addled mistakes. You deal with the idiots, Kal! You work it all out because I am done with it, and gone!"



## 22. Charlie

Oh, this is delicious!

I can't stop laughing! Each time I try to draw breath, another gout of mirth erupts from my bones. My tongue is too loose in my mouth to form words; my spine can barely keep me upright. When piss cascades from my nub to wet my calves, my feet – another bark of joy breaks from my jaw!

I should be picking up the whip, getting ready to defend myself and my companions from the two great, leather-wrapped monsters perched on rocks no more than a score of knuckled strides ahead of me. I can't do it! All my arm can manage is to lift my hand and point a finger at the creature closest to me.

~ *He's a dragon?* I can't stop my Inner Voice projecting my words to any who can hear them: ~ *Marc? A storming dragon ...?*

Charlie is not impressed with me: ~ *Turds, Kal. Pull yourself together before I rip your liver out!*

As Boude predicted, Charlie the dragon has come to visit us. Or rather, Marc has flapped his way back to Sam, and Charlie has been forced to follow him here. Like Boude, she is clearly not happy with her duty.

I don't care – this is too rich a joke for me to ignore!

Someone comes alongside me, kicks me in the groin and then leans forward to pick up the whip.

"You've got him under control, Cjaxirj?" asks Boude.

~ *Just about*, the female dragon perched just behind Marc answers. ~ *You can finish him whenever you're ready. Though the way he's been acting this time round, I'm keen to rip the little shit myself!*

Oh, Sam and Marc, Marc and Sam. Two lovers who crossed between worlds – one seeking immortality, the other sanity – now reduced to the flesh of different species, eternal combatants in a place where there are no stars to cross.

I never met Mr Shakespeare, my Song reminds me. Though I did spend time in the skull of a woman, during a quick job in the Outer World, who was obsessed by the man's poetry. This thought generates a new cascade of laughs from me that end in coughs and finally bring me to my knuckles, heaving for air.

For what it's worth, Marc does look magnificent. His long, thin jaws with their even rows of sharp, peg teeth are balanced perfectly by the blue-white marbled crest projecting behind him, both equal in size to balance on his strong, mottled neck and its bloom of red pouch where the speared fish can wait before consumption. His wings, folded now as he rests his sharp-clawed knuckles on the ground, arch upwards to the fingertips which meet above his supple back. A good bulge of muscle across his chest speak of a recent renewal, matched by strong thighs and thin calves which end in black talons as long as my forearm. His skin may be naked, but it sheens!

Charlie, by comparison, looks dull – she perches behind Marc on a higher terrace, her brown-grey markings more functional than sexual. Her crest is plain white; what it lacks in length it gains in heft. She is also, I remind myself, bigger than Marc, which is the way of the dragons.

Marc has his eyes only for Sam, somewhere behind me. He has to move his head from side to side to give each eye equal amounts of Sam-time. Dragons can see everything, of course, but they struggle with knowing the distance of things in front of them. Not that Charlie needs that precision right now: she is perfectly positioned to reach down to sever Marc's neck with her jaws, should the idiot make just one wrong move.

I take a moment to look behind me towards the stone house before I attempt to regain my legs. Sam, I assume, is standing ahead of another person – a woman, I think. His face, even at this distance, shouts his inner turmoil: confusion; fear; determination; love. He stares above my head at the two dragons, as if he knows what is about to happen and both wants it to happen and hates that it will happen.

I haven't talked to Sam yet, nor his companion. Boude has kept me outside, camped in the valley, on permanent guard for the inevitable arrival of Marc. What few words she's chosen to share with me tell a story of a dragon obsessed with an ape to the point that it bought danger to

whichever settlement Sam was in at the time. Which is why Boude bought Sam here.

My 'mess' is, apparently, common knowledge across Kahelis Reach, and even beyond. Though the company has done hard work to kept my involvement in creating the mess out of the gossip.

That Batanean fellow must have known I was lying through my teeth during our meeting! Who else knows? Not an important thought, I decide. What is important are the facts.

Dragons hunt apes. It's the Mescwar way, just as ape hunting, and feasting on dragon flesh, is the Mescwar way. Most of that hunting used to happen during the Game, but now the game is no more things have changed.

*~ So, Charlie, I say as I begin to stand straight, ~ Well met! I apologise for my outburst. How have you been?*

*~ Your manners appear a little rusty, she agrees, ~ but I hear you've been sailing in distant waters. I have my health, thank you for asking. And you?*

*~ I was doing well. I have been travelling, but it is good to be back home among friends.*

Now I am upright again I take a risk, raise my arms above my head to stretch them long. The dragon responds by clattering her fingertips together above her back – a sign to me that we are relaxed here, in each other's company.

*~ I met Katsepet while this one was regrowing. They send their warmest regards.*

... Which explains Charlie's reference to 'sailing in distant waters'. Katsepet enjoys their gossip – though I hope they have not been sharing too many of our plans.

I glance at Boude, stood slightly ahead of me to my left, whip ready in her hand. She knows I look: she turns her head a fraction and shares the glance, notices my raised brow, nods an acknowledgment and lets the tension ease a little from her stance.

Clearly she can hear me talk to Charlie – I've never been good at directing my Inner Voice; maybe the dragon also includes my captain in her responses?

I turn from Boude and stare hard at Marc, still switching his head from side to side.

*~ Katsepet is a good friend indeed. Their help during my return was invaluable.*

*~ You've done some excellent work together since then, I hear. A new map is always useful, especially during these changing times.*

"What changing times?" asks Boude. Then: "Welcome back, Cjaxirj. My apologies for this arse of an ape's lack of charm!"

Another rattle of finger bones from the dragon, but no response. The tilt of her head makes it clear that I need to answer the question.

"Katsepet is of the view that our healing arena is losing its power," I say out loud.

*~ The dragons concur, says Charlie.*

So, how do I explain this?

It's not like I'm among competitors. I know Charlie so well because she, too, is a member of the Rujan Company. She, too, has been to the Outer World.

And Charlie has Boude's full trust. The whip in the woman's hand is aimed at Marc's neck.

I'll give them the official story, I decide.

"When I arrived, the guardian found me and helped me to grow into flesh. But that was a long way from here ..."

"How far?" asks Boude.

"Maybe twenty dozen sleeps? A good distance. I was glad Katsepet found me, but the truth is they weren't looking for me."

"It's rare for a guardian to stray so far from the islands," agrees Boude.

"Katsepet has taken it upon themselves to build a new map of the Old Ones" – which is the official story. "I was happy to join them in that work once I was full-formed and free. They told me they were worried our current healing arena was losing its power. They explained that when a new healing arena emerges, then the reaches and islands will move towards it. They said such events were times of great sorrow and hardship, thus having a reliable map of the endless sea would be a very useful tool."

*~ And an excellent boost to the guardian's standing!*

Charlie is the most dangerous dragon I know because she can, when she wants, think like an ape. It makes me smile inside, knowing that we have corrupted her thoughts in such devious ways.

I smile an agreement in her direction. I make no effort to tell my audience that Katsepet had only decided to build the map after he found me. But that is the worm's gossip to share, not mine.

"So that's where I've been, Boude."

"Saving the world, huh? My, how you've grown!"

That's an unexpected turn: "How do you mean?"

"You say you've been with the guardian for twenty dozen sleeps? Well, the idiot perched right in front of your nose has been my problem for a lot longer than that!"

*~ This also is true, says Charlie. ~ Though my problem more than yours. Your problem doesn't keep ending himself. Your problem just screams a lot and runs away.*

Boude isn't smiling: "Now Kal's back, it won't be our problem anymore, Cjaxirj. We can leave these fuck-mates here and let him deal with his mess."

*~ You always did know how to cheer me up, says the dragon, rattling her fingers in mock appreciation.*

~~~

The stone house may have three levels, but each level is a single room, a small space. Four bodies makes for a crowd. The floor below us is for storing food gathered from the valley; the floor above for sleeping.

This middle room has many narrow window slits, wide enough to let the weather in but close enough to keep dragons at bay. Light crosses the floor in a maze of stripes, their brightness dappling as clouds pass around the house.

Sam hunches in one corner, sat on a stone-slab shelf next to the climbing pole. He was the last of us to climb into the room; it's clear to me, as I watched him enter, that he struggles with the concept of foot thumbs.

Boude sits legs forward on her mat. She looks so tired, here in the room where she can finally relax. How much work has it been to carry the needs of these visitors? To teach them just enough of the little ways that keep people alive, here in Mescwar?

Her mat is old. She has some skill with weaving reeds, my Song recalls. Much of our shared time in this house was with her sitting exactly there, me opposite, our feet clasped mine to hers as she taught me the craft. Rain work, she called it. Later, we'd sell our mats to a man in Ste Kahelis who was willing to pay more than their worth for a reason nobody ever explained to me.

Four apes in a room, each to a corner. Though only one of us is truly an ape.

Sam doesn't know my name yet – Boude at least agreed to keep that detail from him, and she is always a woman of her word. I don't need the help of my Song's serenade to remember what happened the last time I told the man my name.

The other woman ... oh, storm, I *know* Spar!

We last met in the Outer World when she served me a mug of tea in the house she kept with her partner, Bull, south of the river in the Lonely City. Later that evening I ordered a man – Falc was his name – to arrange for the death of her flesh, to render her back to the Band.

It was an easy decision. I was riding her flesh-born son at the time, and needed to keep him compliant and controllable while I completed my job.

A grieving host is always easier to control.

I'm confident that Sam won't remember my presence at the last meeting he had with his mother. It happened before he became aware of me in his skull.

The way Spar stares at me – it makes me uncomfortable. Unsure. I did all in my power to hide my presence from her when she and Sam chatted that evening ... but was it enough?

So, this is the shape of my mess.

I don't even know if it's a problem to solve, or a situation to control. I'm a trader, storm take me! I move sedges here and shells there, and woven mats to the next Reach. I pretend I know what I'm doing and sometimes I make a profit for my company, when given the chance.

And sometimes I get pulled into a completely different world to ride in some poor bastard's brain for a short while, to complete whatever job my companions see fit to give me. And yes, sometimes the jobs I get given, out there under a real sun and a real moon, go wrong. Badly wrong. This much wrong!

... And here I sit.

"It's good to see you, Spar," I start. "When did you arrive?"

"A short while ago." She has a pelt of thin stripes, white and black, mourning and loss etched into her Vital Breath. Yet she answers with cautious alertness in her face, as if she's worn ape flesh before. "Boude invited me here."

"She invited you?"

Boude answers: "I went through the lodestone to Onuun. I needed a break from that one's screaming after I finished his flappy boyfriend last time round."

We all glance at Sam. He's keeping his head low and close to his hands, but I can tell he listens.

"You're welcome in Mescwar, Spar. Though I apologise for the setting."

"I've been here before," she confirms. "To Mescwar. At least this island isn't ... flat."

"The flatness in Mescwar can get a little – tedious," I admit. "I believe Onuun is more generous in its landscapes?"

Spar considers the question. Or rather, she's probably considering the questions we're avoiding. I know this woman well: we've been in the Outer World too many times together for me to forget the way her mind works.

"Tell me about your mapping work, the work that kept you from visiting us sooner?"

Spar also has excellent hearing, I recall, whatever suit of flesh she occupies. Her question tells me she's not ready to discuss the main problem, sat in the corner of the room closest to the climbing pole.

Neither am I, I realise. I need a rest from revelations.

And the lifecycle of the great bristle worms of Mescwar is a fascinating diversion. I knew almost nothing of it, until Katsepet discovered me stranded on a mud bar in the middle of the endless sea, dressed only in dolphin.

Many thoughts hit me, now: a harbour wave of decisions to make! So much of my recent history is tied to Katsepet, so much of it not mine to tell.

I will not share the fact that Katsepet, when we met, was preparing to end their life.

Oh, it is a rich tale, ripe for sharing, of how the guardian had misunderstood a situation and acted in a way that bought them to a place of unyielding shame.

They told me their story as we sailed the endless sea, mapping the Old Ones. They told it in snatches and hints, here and there. They gave me pieces of the shell in which their recent history hid until, after we

discovered the new healing arena, I managed to fit them together to complete the clam.

The worm Psattan – I liked that one, always the joker in the guardian community – had started growing a tail. They had hinted to Katsepet that a mutual curling could be a possibility. My friend, who admitted they had always admired Psattan, secretly, despite suffering more than their fair share of consequences from the worm's pranks, also started growing a tail. Remarks were made; gossip travelled through gatherings of worms. Katsepet followed when Psattan departed, ignoring the knowing rattles of those in on the joke.

There was no mutual curling, my friend finally admitted to me as we watched the nascent healing pool start to grow. Psattan, it turned out, was tired of being a guardian and had decided to move on. Their tail was not to nourish the millions of progeny a curling creates, but rather to start the process where a guardian becomes an Old One. They found a place far distant from other Old Ones and buried themselves deep into the mud. They split, male from female, to form between them the structures that, should Mescwar permit it, would soon speak with Mescwar's voice.

They made Katsepet watch. Forced them to confront their gullibility. Where one secretly admired the other, the other had always despised them – too stuffy, too officious, too full of their own spent mud.

I will not tell the people in this room the story of how Katsepet was ready to eat their own fat tail when they found me beached and shocked on a mud bar far from the islands – an act which would have dissolved their guts and separated segment from segment, ending their life.

... No. That's Katsepet's story, just as the story of how the worm witnessed the waters suddenly boil and sing when a dolphin from Ounous appeared in the midst of the endless sea is not Katsepet's story to tell: that is my story.

This new friendship we have – our absurd siblinghood – is built on understanding the limits of gossip.

"You've been here before, yes?" I look Spar direct in the eye. "You know that nothing here is stable?"

"Except the lodestone stack," adds Boude.

I ignore Boude. She's done enough. Only Spar, and Sam, matter here.

"Well there's this thing our guardian worms do when they reach the limits of their life. They go out into the endless sea and they find an empty patch of mud where they can turn themselves into an Old One."

"Go on," says Spar, her quiet voice carrying no hint that she, too, has been split male from female, half of her lost – it's my Song that adds that colour to my deep note of her.

"Well, just like the lodestone stack, Old Ones don't move. They turn into a sort of living rock. Some people say they become the voice of Mescwar – they certainly make sounds."

The slatted light in the room dims and dances, perhaps the shadow of a wing overhead.

"But their main use, as far as the guardians are concerned, is that each Old One has its own sound. And because they don't move, we can use them as points on a map. Wherever a person might find themselves they can, if they know the map, know where they are."

"That's clever," says Spar. "But if they don't move, why do you need a new map?"

"Ah, that's because the Old Ones don't last forever. They weather with each storm. Some storms are so vicious they may get ripped from the mud. Stuff happens, and so maps need to be updated every so often."

"Stuff happens," says Spar.

"It does indeed," agrees Boude.

... My muscles tense as if challenged; I ignore their reflexive reaction. I can only control me, here in this room.

"Katsepet told me," I continue, "the guardians believe that the islands were once Old Ones who grew too large, as if Mescwar kept covering them in rock to shut them up!"

"Like a pearl?" asks Sam.

I turn my head to look at the man, confirm that he hasn't changed his stance. Though I'm glad he listens.

"Yes," I agree. "Just like a pearl in clam meat. Now, Spar. Why don't you ask me your real question."

The stare we share lasts two breaths, then another. Maybe I aim to challenge her with such eye contact, but she does not look worried by it. If anything, she looks calm.

"What have you done to my son, Kal?"

"Nothing," I tell her. And then: "Everything."

It is a struggle to keep my neck relaxed, my face facing Spar. I ache to see Sam's reaction to hearing my name. But Spar's need fixates me.

"Tell me!"

"The last time I was summoned into the Outer World, I was pulled into Sam."

The woman's eyes widen. She didn't sense me, that evening Sam and I visited?

She turns to look at Boude: "Was this your doing?"

"No," I say quickly. "Boude was elsewhere. When I was pulled from the Band you were still in London. But Bull was gone."

She doesn't believe me. The way she juts her head forwards is enough to warn me of this. I make an effort to relax my joints.

"Bull summoned a dozen Vital Breaths from the Band. Boude was one of them. Falc another. You rendered Bull back ..."

Turds! I almost said 'back home' ...

"Then Falc pulled me out and into Sam ..."

"That's not possible ..."

"I know, I know! You were the Band's Guardian. But that's what happened! That is the truth of what I recall. Ask Boude. Ask Falc if you can find him. Storm, ask Mada if you have to! I did nothing to Sam! I didn't even know he was the child of your host!"

"She's not my mother," says Sam.

I cannot help it. I have to turn my head, stare at the man. As soon as I look, I can see he has his four incisors – each as long as a finger, each a dagger sharp enough to separate meat from bone – exposed. A small smile, we call it.

"I like your fangs, Mr Kal," he says, talking to his hands resting on drawn-close knees. "I still hate you, but I think you make sense. I remember what happened, like the way you said it. Dad waving his ring all around in Waterloo Station. Mum hitting him over the head with a big steel bar."

"You were there?"

That's a new thing, chimes my Song.

"Yeah. We were catching up over lunch. Which she would remember, if she was my Mum! Then Dad just stood up and wandered off towards the platforms and, and Mum ran after him and suddenly she's clobbering him over the head with a pole. So fucking quick! I dashed over ... I dashed over! Mum told me to help her pick him up. Dad was, he was a bit dazed, but he could walk. I got them a taxi ..."

Now Sam is staring directly at Spar: "That thing ... she should know this!"

He tilts his head sideways, his wide stare a challenge: "... That's not my Mum! My Dad ... he killed my Mum, and then he hung himself. My Mum ... she's dead. She ain't sitting here in this fucking nightmare!"

Tempest! This is not the conversation I need!

I think of my Song, which is the sum of all me. If Sam can tell us this thing, maybe he ...?

Such a quick thought needs an answer: "So how much do you remember?"

"Before ... before this mad shit?"

Now Sam looks at me. I offer him a nod of encouragement.

"I remember ... lots. Not all. There's pieces where I know there should be something, but it's ... empty. But not like when you tried to make me forget stuff, when you were inside my mind. I remember that. It's other stuff ... gone!"

I follow a hopeful thought: "Do you remember Fol Huun?"

"The empty place, before the giants turned up?"

"That's right."

Another small smile appears on his face: "Yeah, I remember it. We went there after I died."

"You died?"

"I must have died. Marc told me we died because we were in that tiny room under the warehouse and his uncle turned up and he had a gun and shot us. And then we were on a beach. And then you showed up and Marc died again and then I murdered you and, and you came back and I went a bit ... a bit mad, I suppose? But I remember it all!"

And then: "I'm sorry you lost your leg, Mr Kal. I'm sorry I murdered you."

I don't have time for apologies. Above me, I can hear the faintest of scratches: "I don't want to ask this, Sam. But it's important. Do you remember dying in the empty place?"

The man is back to staring at his clasped hands resting on his knees. But his smile is sudden, genuine.

"Yeah ... I remember that! I was still mental, convinced I was in a zombie film. Marc had tied me to a big wooden post: he was trying to get me to eat. And then there were all these fucking rats all over the place. Big

fuckers! Hundreds of them. Marc did his best but they were all over him in seconds in a big pile and then it was my turn – fucking hurt, that did!"

Hah! "Were they singing, these rats?"

He thinks for a breath: "... yeah. Really loud squeaks."

"Caddiwhips," I tell them. "They hunt in packs. The only way to beat them is to find the lead rat, sat on a rock or in a tree. The one with the loudest trill. Kill that one and the others will run away."

"Useful to know," says Sam, "though I don't wanna end up in that game again."

I glance at the women. Boude has her eyes closed, though she doesn't sleep. Spar is on her knuckles and haunches, leaning into the room. Desperate to know every word.

"So you were only in the healing pools twice?"

Sam thinks, then: "You mean the rock pools? Under the water?" When I nod, he continues: "Yeah, only twice."

My unexpected thought is beginning to develop a shine; a pearl of an idea.

~ Charlie? Are you on the roof?

~ Yes, I'm here.

... Which explains the flicker of striped light across the floor

~ How many times has Marc been healed?

~ Now there's a question! Boude has taken him out thirty seven times. I've done it twice. He's managed to end himself fifteen times – no, sixteen. Apparently he walked out of the lodestone and straight off the stack before he realised he had wings.

~ And three times in Fol Huun, that I know of. That's fifty eight healings in all – you have been busy!

~ Soon to be fifty nine. How much more talking do you need to do?

~ Another question, if I may? How much of Marc is left?

~ You mean his memories?

... That's a surprising question.

~ You can hear us talk from up there?

~ Boude's been telling me about it.

... Which is fair enough. *~ Yes, how much memory does Marc still have?*

Charlie considers the question: *~ He's near empty. He barely knows how to body talk. All I can get for him is some need to defend his little friend. There's also some urge to do what you apes do to each other? You know, when you don't think people are looking? Sometimes when people are looking, too. That thing, like a good fight but both people still breathe after.*

Sam has his eyes closed. Now I look at him, I notice his hands have tightened into fists. The small smile is back on his face, too.

Perhaps it's just the pain of that old memory of his, him and Spar and Bull in a London station?

... No. Spar has sensed something, too. Boude has her eyes open again. There's is more than just a bad memory going on in the man's flesh.

~ You can hear me, Sam?

And suddenly his jaws are wide, his tongue pulled back. The signs agree: he's primed to attack!

"Samuel Lewis, you stop that RIGHT NOW!"

Not my words! Spar is off her knuckles, ready to leap at her son, ready to bring him down.

... And it works! Sam freezes, his attack undone before it happens.

~ You can hear me, Sam. My words inside you.

This time it's not a question. My realisation hits me quicker than my Song can remind me. Of course he can hear me! This is exactly how we spoke to each other during those weeks and months, in the Outer World, after he discovered me lodged in his brain.

Turds in fur! This is turning into a fury of bad weathers! Too quick; my head can barely keep up with the speed of this weaving.

~ ... Charlie?

~ I'm still here, Kal. What's going on?

~ Can you distract Marc for a while? I think we need more time here.

~ I suppose I can bully him into some fishing. Just tell Boude to keep our link open. I'm beginning to enjoy your little show!

I'm not smiling as I hear the dragon's claws clatter on slate, as she unfurls her wings and lifts clear of the house.

"Samuel Lewis. I forgot that was your full name. Look at me, Sam. If you open your eyes, I'll talk to you with my mouth, yes?"

His breathing is heavy, his fists screwed tight. One leg is cocked beneath him, ready to leap. But Sam is closing his mouth, hiding away his incisors. He's controlling himself despite the battering shocks he's taken from many directions.

When he finally complies, the first sign I get from his eyes is pain. Not flesh pain; a deeper pain.

I've known that pain. I remember when Spoy first spoke to me, loud in my head, loving, as my last breaths froze over my grandmother's still-wet blood on my arms. To talk, mind to mind – it takes a while to get used to that hurt!

"You're doing well," I tell him. "Apart from the going mad thing. But even that – you can beat that too, Sam. You have the strength."

He shakes his head, a refusal of sorts.

"Tell me what happened to you and Marc, after I left the island."

His mouth moves several times, his thoughts emerging and dying before his throat can act on them.

Then finally: "We walked. You called them avenues. We walked up the mountain along those avenues. Marc ... he loved it, the adventure. I remember – I remember terror. All the time, something was going to attack me, eat me. That woman you don't like, Mada, she was there. And that other man – he told me about being a horse and he stayed awake when I slept ... are you going to kill Marc again?"

"No, I ..."

"She's very good at it, that one," he says, nodding towards Boude. "I hate it when she kills him, but he ... he fucking scares me! It's Marc, but not Marc. My Marc, he knew when to leave me alone ..."

"I remember your Marc. This Marc, here, there's a lot of him missing ..."

"I remember her!" He's staring at Boude, across the diagonal of the room. "She – she was the demon in that poor kid's head. The kid who was in the papers; Marc was really upset about it, but you made me lie about it because she was in the kid's head when she arrived."

There's truth here, notes my Song.

Sam falls silent, but I know he has more to say: the fidget in his fingers, no longer curled into fists, tells of words and thoughts being sorted.

"She – Boude – that poor kid was sick, man! That's what the reports in the papers said. She was dying but that one made it worse! I watched her cut the kid's hair off, then ... she changed the kid's face? Turned the girl into a boy? How ...?"

"Boude can do that," I tell him. "But she never asked to be in that kid's head, Sam. We don't get to choose whose head we end up in, when we get pulled into the Outer World."

Sam grins, sudden, near-feral: "That's right! You said you ended up in a dog's head, one time. You fucking hated it!"

We have that chord, confirms my Song.

"I don't enjoy being pulled into the Outer World," I say, my eyes steady on Sam's face. "It's not my place. My life is here, in Mescwar."

"Then why do you go there?"

"I ... I don't know. Sometimes others need someone to do a piece of work, they think of me, they pull me out of the Band. I do what I have to do and then I come home, here. Pick up my life, carry on."

"Pieces of work. Like when that one took over my friend, Lee. Made him crash the car we'd lifted. Teach me a lesson – she told you that, I remember it. You thought I wasn't listening, but I heard everything you said and thought. All of it – I remember it all. Even the fucking dreams!"

I don't know what to say! I glance at Spar, diagonal from me – does she know how to fix Sam? I don't!

What do I need to do here? I can feel one answer scratching at the base of my skull. But there's a knot in my gut too and that a knot saying: it's not enough. There needs to be more!

"How did you get here, Sam?" I try.

I watch as the recollections in his eyes shift: "Get here?"

"Get here. Get to Mescwar."

"We ... we walked down the mountain back to the sea. There was a tower, huge fucking tower – I'd seen it before. One of your dreams from before I died, it was. We had to climb the tower to that, that thing at the top. Shiny and hot and black and cold and small, big – everything. Nothing. Just a pebble ... that's when I knew! That's the moment I worked it all out!"

"Worked what out?"

"It's all a bunch of lies! I'm in the fucking Matrix! Stuck here until someone shows up with the Red Pill!"

... I'm lost.

... Spar rescues me.

"I remember that film," says Spar. "Do you remember we watched it together, Sam? You told me about it and we found it on the telly, watched it together. You and me. Not Dad; he was working nights."

Sam is nodding: "That's right; a film – but it's not a film. It can't be a film because I'm living it now ..."

"It was just a film, sweetheart ..."

"His anger is sudden: "Then why am I stuck in the middle of Planet of the Fucking Apes?"

... Silence. My confusion is complete.

Spar breaks the still air: "I don't remember any dragons in that film."

Sam turns his head, stares hard at Spar: "They ain't dragons. Marc is not a dragon! They're pterosaurs. My Mum would know that!"

"I would, wouldn't I," Spar agrees. "I remember how angry you would get when people misnamed any of your dinosaurs."

I stare at Boude. She stares back at me. Lifts a shoulder to confirm we're both sailing the endless sea of this conversation with no map to hand.

"My Mum would know that pterosaurs are not dinosaurs!"

"Yes," says Spar. "And mesosaurs are not dinosaurs. And neither are ichthyosaurs. You told me all about ichthyosaurs after we went on holiday to Devon, when you were ten."

I glance back to Sam. His face is giving me a map of uncertainties. If I was a lesser person, I'd listen in on his thoughts: my Song certainly wants to know what all these strange new words mean.

~ What did he just call me? asks Charlie.

~ Terry's sores? I guess.

~ I don't know a Terry. One of your friends?

"The dragon wants to know what you just called her, Sam," I say.

His stare returns to my face. His lips are parted, but teeth are hidden. There's no space on his face for a small smile.

"I don't think the dragon appreciates being told that she's not a dragon."

"... What?"

"Dragons are," I continue, "well, dragons. That's what they all call themselves, each other. Dragons. And people have a right to choose their own names, yes? We can all go round calling clams, clams. Because clams are not people. But dragons are very much people. Marc is a dragon, and he's a person."

I watch as Sam shakes his head, an uncertain denial.

Spar cuts in again: "What have I told you about calling people names, Samuel? It's unkind! And I will not tolerate any child of mine bullying other people. Do you hear me?"

... And Sam's uncertainty becomes complete as he returns his eyes to staring at his hands.

"Calling a dragon a pterosaur," concludes Spar. "Well that's a very insulting thing to do. Very human-centred! I hope you apologise to poor Cjaxirj!"

In my head, I sense a dragon collapsing into the sea, too jerked by laughter to remember how to fly.

~~~

I'm surprised Sam has agreed to do this. He still believes he's inside some sort of film or magic game, convinced that I don't exist. He said being in a film was better than being in Hell, or Purgatory – whatever those things are.

His explanation seems to be helping him: why else would he agree to act as bait? He has a good memory of the last time I used him as bait, to overcome the flayman. He told me that anything was better than harvesting reeds; if it helped to cure Marc, then that was a bonus.

His presence makes my mad plan more workable. As thanks, I've promised to show him how to dive for pearls once we're done here. There's some good beds of cockles and clams nearby.

Right at this moment, though, he's mostly fascinated by Katsepet's head segment, which the guardian has lifted out of the water and rested on the edge of the boat. Katsepet, in turn, is fascinated by Sam.

*«We thought we knew everyone!»*

*~ Sometimes a new person comes to Mescwar.*

*«That is how we met your friend Spar, we know. A person goes travelling in a place beyond Mescwar called an Outer World and then loses themselves when they return. We met Spar in the healing arena»*

*~ Yes, I confirm. ~ But that is not the only way strangers can arrive.*

*«The Eldest, yes. But that is only for the lost of Mescwar to return from other Worlds Within Worlds places»*

*~ Mostly, yes.*

*«We do not meet those people. The Eldest grows them their flesh, I'm told; they have no need of healing. Are there many such people not from Mescwar?»*

*~ No. The lodestones do not lead to a welcoming place. It really is a path of last resort.*

*«And now there is this new way for people to come to Mescwar, wrapped in dolphin flesh – your water talking to water! How you have enriched our understanding, indeed our range of taste, my friend!»*

Sam can only hear my side of the conversation. Katsepet has not attempted to place an all-sense in his head. A good decision, I think, given the man's fascinated terror of this giant worm with their huge, sharp pincer jaws. But he is determined to confront his fear. If I am able to sit close to this monster, then so is he.

*~ You don't have to do this, my friend!*

*«We are grateful for your concern, and care, Kal. But we can perform this duty with ease, whereas you and your new friends would struggle as the dragon fights»*

*~ But ...*

*«No, Kal. We have considered it long, this chance»*

*~ It probably means your death!*

*«We understand all of your concerns. We remind you that we are tolerant of a wide range of salts and pressures. We are guardians, after all! And we are conciled to an ending: we had accepted this before your most recent return. The concept of becoming an Old One – it is repugnant to us»*

*~ You are not deserving of an end!*

*«And yet an end must come, Kal. Ever since you told me of the Songs of Ounous, we have known that if we are to die, then we would die happy with such Songs stroking our bristles. The wonder of swimming through new water – is it not amazing?»*

*~ But what of our plans ...?*

*«Our part of the plan is done. The map is as complete as we can make it. And we have seeded the new healing arena with our progeny. Our name will echo in the jaws of many ... that, my friend, is enough»*

I ... cannot argue. I have no arguments left. I reach over to stroke the worm's hard head. I take Sam's hand, his finger, and slowly guide it along the side of my friend's closest pincer. The look of wonder across Sam's face doesn't disperse when Katsepet pulls away from the boat and sinks back into the waves of the endless sea.

We wait in the boat, silent, letting the gentle rock of waves unbalance our flesh together as they play. I check the sky, breathe out. And another breath. And another.

And then they are here, curving around the headland, skimming low over the water. The lead dragon is smaller, more colourful. He screams with worry and frustration, searching for his lover who sits in the boat with me. Behind him, and higher in the air, Charlie keeps her enormous wings taut;

she holds her feet, her talons, ahead of her, ready to take Marc down should the plan go wrong. Closer they come, and closer, Marc's screeches growing louder as he approaches.

Sam tenses in the boat, ready to dive out and beneath it if Marc comes too close. I stay relaxed, lay a hand on the man's knee.

When Katsepet attacks, their aim is true! They launch from the water and leap high, higher. I doubt that Marc even sees the long worm beneath his wings until it is too late ... and then they are falling together back into the water, a whirl of leather wings and shocked cries and determined loops of segments curling already to bring them deep into the water.

*'Now,' I tell my Song, as I jump from the boat and angle my course towards the place where my path, and the guardian's, will intersect. 'Dig deep to the place where I hid the dark songs, the black songs of the great whales who chant in the abyssal gorges of Ounous. Bring forth the resonances that command water to speak to water!'*

And my sinews and bones and muscles and fats and skin respond with a melody that cannot be refused, a celebration that sends water to spin across unchartable spaces to meet its kin, and join, and dance!

Ahead, a dazzle of impossible colours appears. Into it pushes a great worm, part wrapped around the form of a dragon, wings broken, fighting still to reach Sam.

... And through!

... And gone. All gone ...

*~ Katsepet!*

The silence of their voice is ... is complete.

How does this absence burn in my head? How can it be done, and gone? But it is done, and I must still breathe, find breath. Somehow my body curves through water, somehow it heads towards light, and waves, and bitter air ...

~~~

Charlie has come to say her farewell. Now her work is done, she has better work to do elsewhere.

~ We could fight here, she says.

~ Yes, I agree.

The dragon has a deft feel for possibilities. Here at the top of the valley the cliffs are stepped and close, with many good anchors for me to launch an attack. The nearness of rock would give Charlie an ariel challenge equal to any the games arena could offer.

A fight is not just to the end: the artistry of the fight counts too.

~ How far behind you am I? I ask.

~ You're getting good! You lost our last combat, but won the three previous.

~ Which brings me to?

~ Eight thousand, two hundred and seventy.

~ I still have some catching up to do, then.

~ I have fourteen thousand, five hundred and twelve wins against you.

~ Not too bad then, I say, ~ given I lost the first three thousand challenges.

I'm surprised when the dragon doesn't correct my number. It took me a long while to grow accustomed to the nuances of my ape flesh; any victories I gained in those early fights were mainly due to stray gusts of wind throwing me favours, or blind luck when other fighters strayed into our space. The Games are – were – supposed to be a team competition, after all.

~ You're tail is trailing low, Kal. Yet your talons are forward, stretched. There's more for you to relate?

It is the dragon way, to assign feelings and decisions to body positions. Most of their language is body signals. Then again, most of my

ape language is in the face. Neither of us have the best flesh, here in Mescwar, for forming sounds like they do in the Outer World.

I've already given Charlie every detail of Katsepet's new map. Including the location of the new healing arena.

~ Have you ever watched a guardian curl?

~ That is a strange question. I suppose it's your way. Yes, a guardian's curl is easy to spot from the air. They are not – elegant – about it.

~ I watched Katsepet curl with themselves, after we found the new healing arena. Elegant – is entirely the wrong word.

Revolting would be a better word, I decide. Also brutal, the way Katsepet split their belly skin with their sharpest bristles to bring things together. The harpoons they used to pulse the mess of foul fluids into their tail ... I would be happy to lose that image during my next healing!

~ It was a good decision, though. Their progeny will be the controllers of that arena. Already the remains of that spawn will be big enough to fight off other spawnings.

~ The future will indeed be the Age of Katsepet's spawn!

~ Which is not the guardian way ...

I pause to rearrange my legs and knuckles across the outcrop of rock on which we both perch.

~ I'm certain now, I tell the dragon. ~ Our friend made their decision then, alongside their decision to self-curl. They had no intention to continue with life – at least not in this world.

~ You think they could survive in Ounous?

I shake my head: *~ Ten dozen of my breaths, maybe the full twelve. Not much more. I don't know where in Ounous I sent them, and most of Ounous is deep, deep water. Many fish; many teeth. Many things bigger than our guardian worms even at their full stretch, and all of them hungry.*

~ That is not what I've heard about that stone.

~ And yet it is true. A game that never ends, and is not played for points. But the Songs – Katsepet would have heard, felt the Songs, before their end.

We both fall silent. I watch a bank of clouds that has been building on the far side of the lodestone stack. We can do with some heavy rain, I decide. A good wind to blow fresh air across the reach. I tell Charlie this.

She agrees: *~ It's always more fun to fly into the storm.*

~ And to sail into it.

~ So, what shape of storm are you planning to attack, Kal?

I turn back to the dragon, her long beak with its sharp, narrow teeth no more than an arm's length from my face.

~ I'm losing my trading skills if I'm so easy to read!

She rattles her wingtip bones from back to front, an honest dragon's chuckle.

~ Boude will soon be heading for the new healing arena.

She blinks the eye currently focussed on me: *~ I shall be with her. Wherever a new healing arena grows, a new games arena will quickly appear. I fully intend for my sister-wing to own that space!*

I nod. Hierarchies are Mescwar's intoxicant of choice.

~ Spar has decided to join Bull.

I feel air rustle the fur around my ear as a beak rushes past it. Suddenly I have an eye the size of my face within a fist's distance from my nose.

~ Is that even possible?

~ So Spar says. The way to Spoy was present when she passed through the Place Beyond Bounds to get here. She plans to go to the lodestone as soon as you and Boude leave us.

~ She told you this plan?

~ Yes, I confirm.

As quickly as it arrived, the eye is gone from my face. Charlie lifts her beak and screams into the sky – a cry of annoyance, of challenge. I give her some moments to vent her shock.

~ You knew this would probably happen, I tell her. ~ Spar and Bull, there as much the same creation as Katsepet ever was. One person in two bodies. They lived for each other!

As her beak lowers, the dragon agrees: *~ They could get very tetchy in the Outer World, if they were separated. Spar more than Bull!*

~ They could get very tetchy with each other when together, I say.

~ Their very own eternal challenge. But that is the octopus way.

I smile at her comment. It amazes me still just how different each stone can be. Truly each a World Within Worlds.

We look again at the clouds, soon to cast a shroud around the Eldest stack.

~ Spar will leave her ... child? Yes, that's the word – she'll leave him here with you? Though that, to me, has been the strangest thing of this entire mess.

~ What do you mean?

Charlie turns back to face me, rests her beak on my shoulder – a sign of great trust from a dragon, given that she can no longer see me.

She asks again, with different words: *~ Why did Bull and Spar breed in the Outer World?*

I would shrug my shoulders, but now is not the best time for that response.

~ I remember asking that question when I first learned whose head I was riding in. I've never found an answer. I'm not sure even they have an answer!

~ It leaves me uneasy, a fish slipping from the teeth back to the sea.

~ Agreed. But nothing was right about Bull's last Guardianship, as far as I could tell. Mada told me he pulled very few of us through to the Outer World, until his madness, and he and Spar were there for a long time: thirty, maybe forty years?

~ Too long. Nobody should be stuck with that job for more than five years!

That answer – as I hear it, I feel an old knot of a question long knotted in my guts tighten.

~ Charlie ... why does the Band even need a Guardian? Why does it need us?

I watch her consider the question: *~ Well, to move around, I suppose? I've never seen the Band grow its own wings.*

~ But if it's that, then the Band only needs one of us to ride whatever flesh is closest to it?

~ A true statement. But the Outer World ... it gets lonely if you're there by yourself. I was alone for too long once, one time when the Band got caught around the claw of an albatross. I saw too much of the world that time. Most of it cold, mind: lots of ice; not enough fish.

~ But why does the Band have to move around all the time?

~ How do you mean?

~ What is it for?

~ What is the Band for?

~ Yes.

As Charlie lifts her beak from my shoulder, she responds.

~ The Band is where the Worlds Within Worlds exist.

~ So what are they for?

~ They are our homes.

~ So what are we for?

I think I may have confused the dragon a step too far! Without warning, she hops to a new rock nearer to the top of the cliff. She stretches her wings wide, then folds them vertical.

~ We just are, Kal. You know this!

~ No, Charlie. I don't know. I know Mescwar; I knew Fol Huun. Ounous. I've never known the why of any of it!

Charlie stretches her wings wide again, angles herself to face into the wind. A good way to launch herself into the sky.

~ Your words are not the Kal I know!

~ I know, I agree.

~ What has changed you?

~ Sam ... I think. Sam has changed me. He doesn't believe any of this is real. Which is a torrent of stupidity, I know ...

~ And yet you doubt?

~ ... Yes, I agree, ~ I doubt. Why can Katsepet end, but I cannot?

That closes her wings!

~ I don't understand this 'death' thing, she says. ~ Guardians die; dragons exist. I've never gone beyond that ... Kal, if you ask such dangerous questions, you end in bad places! Think of the next job, the next trade, the next challenge. Survive. Be! You have work to do. You have Sam to teach.

~ Sam ... he's not my problem anymore.

~ ... What?

~ Sam has told Spar that he wants to go with her, to Spoy.

~ Turds from on high! But, but that solves all your problems, yes?

I stand now, on my shelf of rock high on the cliff. I let my legs and hands stretch into a line. If I stepped out into air, now, the fall would surely end this flesh, let me return to the healing arena – possibly let me forget these questions, if Mescwar would be so kind to a poor, lost ape.

~ *Maybe*, I tell the dragon. ~ *I don't know anymore*.

23. Spoy

When I step away from the Place Beyond Bounds, my bare feet sink into cinder. I look down at them, notice that my toe thumbs are gone. This skin is dirty, marked with the scratches of briar and the stains of iced grass. My heels look calloused from too many steps taken outside the fold of a soft leather shoe.

The dirt I can feel between my toes feels dry, like baked brick grit. A scrubland's sand, dark in its flush of greys. These grains hold no heat, no cold. My nerves are numb to such distinctions.

I hold out my damaged hands, stare at the clotted blood smeared across them. I pull them to my chest, feel ridgelines of ribs that once held a weave of muscles. My belly bulges in hunger. I look to my legs, from ankle to knee: sticks covered in skin.

There's air around me. I still breathe. My breath is transparent, quiet, even.

Feet appear near to mine. These are the feet of giants. They are covered in soft leathers: white to the left of me; brown to the right. The white feet are larger. I follow the legs attached to those feet upwards, trace bright material that covers flesh to a crotch, itself draped in looser cloth. The body that wears these layers stretches up, up again. I bend my neck back to see the face at the end of it all: a man's face, I notice. My face reaches his chest, but no further.

I turn to look at the person the other side of me. I see tight curls of not-long hair. It surrounds an older woman's face. She is not tall, this woman; my nose is level with the crease of her armpit. She, too, wears clothes in patterns and layers.

I see colours abandon cloth: whites, blacks, all the greys between.

Why am I short? Why am I naked?

"So this is Spoy," says the woman.

I see the man turn his head towards the woman's voice. I watch his eyes widen: a shock of white around blue, around black: "... Mum?"

She, too, turns her head towards sound. Her eyes widen more eagerly.

"Sam ... Sam!"

"... How?"

"The lodestones ... they build the flesh you need for the world, and Spoy ... I don't know what this stone is anymore ... you look like my Sam, the last time I saw you in the Outer World!"

Moisture appears in Spoy. The man's eyes, set in the grey-pinks and grey-browns of his skin, dampen.

He lifts his arm, his hand, his finger. He reaches his finger to the woman's neck. Over the top of my head it arches. He touches the woman, hesitant.

"Oh fuck, Mum! Are you hurt? Do you feel pain?"

"What, Sam?"

"Your neck! Bruises ... all around your neck. Are you okay?"

The woman reaches up with her hand, catches the man's fingers with her own. Takes a moment to confirm their solidity before touching their tips to the skin of her chin.

"It's a little sore, maybe, but no, love – I'm not hurting. I'm good. I'm fine!"

I am glad that Spar and Sam have found each other, finally and again. But this is their space. I step away from it, one foot forward and the other to its side, and again. I feel the stir of a note in my instep. I feel the first chord of me resonate my heel's tendons.

They come. Three of them, then four, then five.

«You are welcome here»

«Most welcome here»

«We see you»

«You are welcome»

«We love you»

«Come follow» «You are welcome here»

«We can lead you»

«You are seen, and welcome, and loved»

«And loved!»

The moths flock around the heads of my companions. Their wings are a dust of swivel and flap, but their bodies are tight segments – round yet long. Wide stalks fork and feather ahead of them as they dance and chant their welcome. I take another step, this time letting my right foot pass ahead of my left, my left ahead of my right.

Each time my foot settles into dry cinders, my Song grows through my bones. It warms me as it weaves melodies through meat.

«Come follow us now»

«Now we shall lead»

«You are seen, and known, and loved» «Follow the little one»

«Come follow, be seen, be loved!»

"Who are you?"

I look to my side. Sam strides along, his long legs quick to catch up with my smaller steps. Spar, too, has moved: I hear the dissonant crunch of her steps behind me.

I feel no need to respond. My song is past my hips now: it eases unnoticed aches as joints move in their cups.

"Tell me who you are?"

«He is seen, and loved, and welcome»

«Come follow him»

«Yes we must move forward»

«We have a place»

«Peace and serenity»

«A place for serenity»

«Follow us»

«We must lead you»

«We see you and love you»

«Follow us now»

"Why are you covered in blood?"

It is the blood of my mother's own mother, my song reminds me, its rhythm a sweet percussion in my chest. I tell the man this. I tell the woman this.

"I wear my grandmother's blood."

I like the sounds my throat makes as air pushes out from my lungs. I like the way the noise rings alongside my Song's percussions in my jaw.

«A place for peace and harmony»

«Follow us into love»

"What? Why?"

His questions grate. They cause the moths, their wings wider than his arms, to gyrate in the growl of his tone.

"It is her gift to me," I tell the woman. "Her last gift," I tell the man.

Around us, the flat plain: ahead and behind; left and right. Beneath us, dark cinder scrub bare of leaf. Above, a sky marbled with the streaks of delicate yet solid clouds. They reach across to touch horizons. They shine – silver skeins and milk veins.

Another step. Another step. Another.

~~~

One horizon, the horizon ahead, breaks its flat line. As we walk forward, ripples in the distance become forms. They become shapes. They become people.

We walk through a crowd of loose-knotted people, clumped into rings and swirls of silence and stillness.

The woman walks ahead now, the man behind. At one moment the woman had my hand in hers, but that moment passed. We walk alone, now, in a line.

*«Welcome»*

*«We see you, we love you»*

*«We know you»*

*«Welcome!»      «Here you are safe»*

*«Here you are loved»*

*«You are safe here with us»*

*«Our love is safe, and good»*

*«You are here among us now»*

*«We love and welcome you here»      «Now you can rest»*

*«Now you can love»*

*«We know you still, and here»*

The woman Spar does not stop. She walks with care and purpose. I walk in the slight dents of her steps. The man Sam walks behind: no words bother his throat.

Sam walks more slowly. I hear this, notice it. The heavier crunch of his step sounds lost, feels distant. I look behind and see a wonder of love in his drying eyes, his face. I depart from the steps of the mother and circle a line of steps around and back to the son. I am behind the man, now. I walk in the dents of his slower, heavier steps. Too slow; too heavy. I reach his side; I

take his hand in mine. I pull him forwards with me. I pull the son into the light dents of his mother's steps. We walk faster.

~~~

There is a man ahead of Spar and Spar stops. Spar stops her breath. She cannot walk more steps for her steps are complete. I know this. I can see her shoulders ease as she discovers wholeness again. I know this because of the word she says, soft and quiet like the repeated chords at the base of my Song. 'Bull' she says, and 'Bull' she says, and 'Bull' she whispers as clear tears pearl from her eyes.

Sam stops and he stands by Spar and he takes his left hand to Spar's shoulder and he takes his right hand to the man's shoulder and he breathes only a word: 'Dad?', and 'Dad?' and his eyes douse in wet wonder: 'Dad?'

The Song in my heart is glad. This is what I know the man and the woman search for. This is why they came here. I have that memory: their loss, their need, their decision.

Completeness is good, I tell my Song.

My Song agrees.

I step around and beyond the stopped ones.

I know I will not find my mother and my father here because my father and my mother are dead. They are dead at the end of spear of a man whose hair burned like fire. They are dead like my grandmother is dead, dead at the end of my flint's sharp edge and long ago, long before. They are not here.

They are not in Spoy.

That is not the completeness I seek.

I step left foot to right foot to step left foot to right foot to left foot to step.

~~~

There is a boy ahead of me and I must stop. This boy has my height. He has my face. I know he has my face because I remember the shapes of my face from still puddles of rain and the shapes of this boy's face are the shapes of that face.

Though it is thinner, this face. The boy's cheeks sink into his mouth. The boy's chin juts too sharp where his cheeks recede. I reach my left hand to the tip of his chin and I reach my right hand to the tip of my cheek and as I draw my fingers along jaws: like for like, I can feel their sameness.

This boy has the hunger of a starved dog carved into his loose flesh. I remember starved dogs, barking as they rush through snow. Here is a witness to my last, chilled hunger, chiselled in skin that is not my skin. His skin is smooth; it falls in folds and welts.

He wears no clotted blood across his skin, this boy.

I smile: "You are not me."

I tell the boy: "Your name is Grussa."

I say: "My Song tells me your name, but it does not know you, Grussa. I know you. My Song remembers me; it does not know me. I know me. I know you, Grussa."

"My name is Kheil," I tell the boy who stands ahead of my face.

"I know me. I know you. I know we are not done."

I consider leading the boy, take his hand and let him step in the dents of my steps.

I decide a different thing. I take the boy's arm over my shoulder and place my shoulder into his belly and I stretch from my crouch until I am tall again.

"See, Grussa?" I tell the boy, whose slack face is now next to my face. "I carry you again. But one day you will carry me and you will hate me as I have hated you and your spite will lift me to do work that needs to be done and that is all I shall tell you."

The boy across my shoulders weighs almost nothing as I step forward again.

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Ahead of me, a man with his hands on the shoulders of people he loves. I step towards the man.

"Look," I tell the man as I reach the group. "I am like you. You are not alone in your Song. I rode in your mind for a while and you hate me for it. Grussa rode in my mind for a while and I hate her for it."

I stare at the man for some breaths. The silvered clouds above shine in his eyes still pearly with tears. He looks only towards his mother, his father. His mother stares at his father with a hunger to match my belly. His father stares at his mother with a shock that shivers the cinders and grits on which he stands.

"But I do not need to hate." I continue. "There is more than hate!"

I let the boy on my shoulders who is Grussa fall from my flesh. I am done with carrying. I reach down to the ground and grab two full handfuls of gravels and sands. I throw one into the face of Spar, the other into the face of Sam.

"We are not done yet! We have work to do!"

The voice that answers is not the voice of the woman, or the man.

No, this is the first voice I heard, my Song tells me, after Fol Huun tried to consume me in Her mountain's pillar of burning ash. This is the voice of the man who taught me to close my real eyes and look through the eyes of a host, my first host.

"Kal?" says the voice. "I can see you, lad. I know you."

I turn around to face the face of the man who speaks. His clothes are of many layers, clothes to withstand the chill of late winter. His hair recedes from the crown of his head. He wrinkles more than the woman by his side.

He has Bull's smile. He has Bull's eternal eyes. He has Bull's voice, though his throat struggles to recall how to shape air.

"Well met," I tell him.

"You should leave us now. This is good work and we are complete and now you should go."

"No," I tell him.

His face forms a question that doesn't need a chest's breath to be asked.

"The Band of the Worlds Within Worlds is not an 'is'," I tell him. "It is a 'does'. But it has become a 'does not' and that is wrong."

"How do you know this?"

"I travelled in Ounous," I start. "Ounous was my prison but also my release. He still is. He rests in my bones, though my bones are full of my Song, not His. I am not Ounous."

I smile, knowing that my words sound like nonsense. Then I continue.

"In Ounous I swam with my pod, my friends. We hunted fish and worms and great squids. We escaped the snatch and teeth of fish and sharks, the cups and beaks of great squids. We sang, always, and in song I became me. I became all the parts of me that were once lost to me. I became Kal again, though I was always Kheil."

I lean down to grab more dirt, throw it again against Sam's face, and against Spar's face. I take a moment to offer Grussa my kick.

"I moved beyond the will of my friends, my pod. I swam for a long while. I dove deep into Ounous, who is all water amid His weaves of rock spires, cliffs and reefs. I swam in cold water to deep, deep places. I swam to the edge of an abyss. I heard the songs of the great whales who pod together in the darkest reaches of Ounous. I heard the songs of the great whales and I learned how water talks to water. I heard more of their songs than I desired to hear, for they found me in the great crush of those depths and they sang long to me of their laments."

I focus my eyes again on the old man's face.

"When my flesh screamed for air, there in the abyss, I should have ended and returned to the gentle healing reefs beneath the ink-blue skies of Ounous. But I sought no return. I caused water to talk to water. I moved elsewhere."

I lift my hand up and up to rest it across his cheek, let it stroke the stubbled hair of a human's nascent beard.

"We are well met, old friend. Your inseparable other is here, and the Vital Breath of the child you made between you. But your work is not done. Your place is not here, in Spoy. My Song hints at this, but my guts knot in the truth of it."

The old man laughs at me: "You said it yourself, lad. This is Spoy. There is no place else to go from here!"

I nod to acknowledge the truth of his words, then point behind him to the horizon, to the floss of salmon pinks and copper oranges and bright gold glints. They weave now, those colors, through the forever clouds that smother Spoy. They mark a horizon, one among many. They mark a place to go.

"As water speaks to water, so Tintuun speaks to Tintuun."

I watch him turn to face the horizon. I watch as the colours of our dawn reach his face, reach past his skin into the struts of his Vital Breath. I watch him move from contentment to hope, from the comfort of love to the necessity of that love that reaches beyond.

I watch as a man ripens.

Bull nods, once. He takes a deep breath, a long moment to stretch his limbs, his spine. He yawns loudly, as old uncles do. He focuses his eyes to mine, and I know again that he is here by my side, ready.

"So we have a job to do?"

"I don't know," I admit. "But I know there's a job that is more than guarding the Band of the Worlds Within Worlds."

"How so?"

"I know what the Band fears!"

And now Bull laughs. He reaches out to Spar, to Sam, hugs them and places an arm around each.

I reach down to the twin flesh of me and lift Grussa to her feet.

Together we step towards the new dawn.

THE END